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India flays 'lethal' action on mariners

Jaishankar raises issue with Rubio who warns against violations in Hormuz

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Washington

Secretary of State Marco Rubio told External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar that the US will not tolerate any violations of its naval blockade or illegal transport of Iranian oil through the Strait of Hormuz. This message was delivered during a phone call on Friday evening, when Jaishankar strongly protested the deaths of three Indian seafarers in recent US military actions against commercial ships off the coast of Oman.

State Department spokesman Tommy Pigott said Rubio emphasised that all commercial ships should immediately follow US forces' orders to help maintain peace and security in the Strait. Rubio also made it clear that breaking the US blockade or illegally transporting Iranian oil will not be accepted.

These incidents are the first confirmed deaths among merchant sailors since the US began strictly enforcing its naval blockade on Iran in April 2026. This week, three ships with mostly Indian

crews were attacked in the Gulf of Oman near the Strait of Hormuz. The worst attack happened on Wednesday, when US forces hit the Palau-flagged oil tanker MT Settebello. Three Indian crew members died, and the Omani Navy rescued 21 others.

The three who died were Cadet Aditya Sharma from Himachal Pradesh, fitter Shivanand Chaurasia from Uttar Pradesh, and chief engineer Patnala Suresh. On June 8, US forces also turned off another Palau-flagged tanker, MT Marivex, which had 24 Indian sailors on board; all were rescued safely. A third ship with about 20 Indian crew members was targeted around June 11.

The Strait of Hormuz and the Gulf of Oman are at the centre of the current crisis. This narrow waterway carries about 20 per cent of the world's oil trade. According to US Central Command, the ships that were targeted did not follow orders, ignored several warnings, and tried to move Iranian oil against the blockade.

CONTINUED ON >> P4



US secretary of State Marco Rubio with External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar

File photo

US-IRAN PEACE DEAL TODAY: TRUMP

Washington: US President Donald Trump said on Saturday that a deal to end the war with Iran will be signed on Sunday and the Strait of Hormuz will be "open to all" immediately after that.

"The Deal is scheduled to get signed on Sunday, and immediately after it is signed, the Hormuz Strait is OPEN TO ALL," the President Donald Trump said in a post on Truth Social.

MODI-TRUMP TO MEET DURING G7 SUMMIT: WHITE HOUSE

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will hold a bilateral meeting with US President Donald Trump in France next week on the sidelines of the G7 Summit, the White House has confirmed.

The announcement comes as Prime Minister Modi departed on Saturday for a week-long official visit to

France and Slovakia. In his departure statement, PM Modi emphasised the strong and growing partnership with France.

"France occupies a special place in India's strategic vision. Earlier this year, President Macron visited India, and we elevated our relationship to a Special Global Strategic Partnership," PM Modi said.

The Prime Minister's visit to France is expected to feature high-level engagements, including the much-anticipated meeting with President Trump. The White House confirmation underscores the importance both nations attach to the India-US strategic partnership amid evolving global challenges.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

GREAT OFFERS!



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Govt takes possession of Jaipur Polo Ground



Security personnel stand guard at the entrance of the Jaipur Polo Ground in New Delhi on Saturday PANKAJ KUMAR

RAJESH KUMAR ■ New Delhi

The Land & Development Office (L&DO), under the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs, on Saturday took possession of the prime 15.20-acre Jaipur Polo Ground in the Race Course area, located in Lutyens' Delhi. The action follows an eviction order issued on May 20, through which the L&DO sought possession of the land.

The department, however, cited its requirement for a "larger public purpose" without specifying how the newly acquired land would be used.

The takeover was executed less than 24 hours after a city court declined to grant

interim protection to the Indian Polo Association (IPA) against the Centre's order directing it to vacate the ground. Upon taking control, officials installed prominent signage declaring the land as Government property and warning against any unauthorised entry, encroachment, or construction.

The IPA termed the eviction "wrongful, arbitrary and contrary to law", and said it would pursue all available legal remedies to safeguard its rights and interests. According to the IPA, the land originally formed part of the Jaipur Estate in Delhi and belonged to the erstwhile Jaipur royal family.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

UP GOVT FORMS SIT IN RAM TEMPLE TRUST ROW

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

The allegations regarding donations and financial mismanagement of the Ram Temple trust in Ayodhya have stirred a hornet's nest in the politically sensitive Uttar Pradesh, where Assembly polls are due early next year.

Following the direction of Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Saturday, a three-member Special Investigation Team (SIT) was constituted to probe allegations regarding the financial management of the temple trust.

Yogi took cognisance after a request from the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust.

CONTINUED ON >> P4



21-year-old caught impersonating as Brigadier

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A 21-year-old man was arrested in Shahjahanpur, Uttar Pradesh, on charges of impersonating a Brigadier. Aryan Verma was apprehended while wearing a Brigadier's uniform and accompanied by others suspected of posing as security personnel. The arrest followed a covert operation conducted by Station Headquarters, Shahjahanpur, in coordination with local veterans.

During interrogation, Verma informed investigators that he had failed the NEET examination, despite his intention to study at the Armed Forces Medical College. He stated that he misled his mother, who suffers from a heart condition, by claiming to have



Aryan Verma (second from right) was apprehended along with his security personnel and driver for impersonating a Brigadier PIONEER PHOTO

become a doctor in the armed forces. To support this claim, he is reported to have purchased military uniforms, insignia, and related items from Noida and Gurugram.

According to officials, the operation was carried out on June 12 following two months of intelligence gathering

regarding a suspected impersonator in Shahjahanpur and surrounding areas.

Colonel JS Jaglan, Administrative Commandant of Station Headquarters Shahjahanpur, collaborated with local veterans to verify Verma's identity.

Authorities arranged for Verma to attend a function

at the Shaheed Museum under the pretext of motivating and honouring students. Upon his arrival, he was identified and taken into custody. Officials stated that he arrived in a Tata Harrier bearing a one-star plate and an Army Headquarters flag. He was accompanied by a driver who carried a Government of India identification card and by two individuals dressed in black, reportedly posing as NSG commandos.

A search of the vehicle and its occupants led to the recovery of a forged Brigadier identification card, an air pistol, an AMC regimental cane, and additional military-style items. Police reported that Verma had also affixed Army insignia to his father's car.

CONTINUED ON >> P4

5 IAF personnel killed in AN-32 crash

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

An Indian Air Force (IAF) AN-32 transport aircraft crashed on Saturday morning while landing at Jorhat Air Force Station, Assam. Five IAF personnel on board were killed. The co-pilot survived and is receiving treatment. The IAF ordered a court of inquiry to ascertain the cause of the mishap. According to initial reports, the AN-32 aircraft went down within the Air Force Station premises, triggering a fire after the crash.

The personnel who lost their lives in the crash were identified as Squadron Leader Prashant Singh, Flight Lieutenant Shubham Kumar, Sergeant Jitendra Sharma, Agniveervayu Khemaram Kumawat and Agniveervayu Danish Alam.

"An IAF AN-32 aircraft met with an accident during a routine sortie today at approximately 1000h at Jorhat, Assam. Crash site management and initial inquiries are on at this time. IAF deeply regrets the loss of lives and stands firmly with the bereaved families in this time of grief," a post from the IAF stated. Emergency



Security personnel and others stand near damaged remains of a transport aircraft of the IAF that crashed while landing in Jorhat district, Assam

PTI

response teams were immediately deployed to the site to control the blaze and assess the situation.

Popularly called old workhorse of the IAF, the Russian origin AN-32 is a rugged, twin-engine turboprop military transport aircraft that serves as the "workhorse" of the Indian Air Force. First built in the Soviet Union specifically for Indian requirements, the IAF operates a fleet of about 100 of these aircraft.

The AN-32 is designed to excel in extreme environments, functioning perfectly in high-altitude airfields and hot tropical climates. It can

transport up to 7.5 tons of cargo, 50 passengers, or 42 paratroopers, and it is extensively used for supply drops in remote regions. The last AN-32 crash took place in 2019.

The latest accident comes a little over three months after another major IAF crash in Assam. On March 6, a Sukhoi-30MKI fighter aircraft on a training mission crashed in the hills of Karbi Anglong district after losing radar contact shortly after taking off from Jorhat. Both pilots on board, squadron leader Anuj and flight lieutenant Purvesh Duragkar, were killed in the crash.

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GOVINDPURI FIRE

Police probe role of masked woman spotted on CCTV

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police is investigating the role of a masked woman captured on CCTV entering a residential building in Delhi's Govindpuri moments before a devastating fire claimed three lives early Friday morning, officials said on Saturday.

According to investigators, CCTV footage from a camera installed in a parking area in Gali No. 1 of Tughlakabad Extension shows a woman, her face covered, entering the five-storey building around 2.23 am.

Police said the nearly 50-second footage shows the woman entering the premises, after which a bright glow or flash is visible from inside



the gate. She is then seen leaving the building and walking away. The fire was reported minutes later.

"The footage is being closely examined, and all possible angles are under investigation. The woman's identity has not yet been established, and police are

working to reconstruct the sequence of events leading to the fire," an official said.

The blaze killed Pankaj (28), his grandmother Sushila Devi (70), and his sister Soni (20). Two other family members, Pankaj's mother Guddi (50) and younger sister Moni (18), sustained

critical burn injuries and are undergoing treatment.

Police said a PCR call regarding the fire was received at 2.31 am. Firefighters and police rushed to the spot and launched a rescue operation, evacuating several residents trapped inside the smoke-filled building.

Initial inquiries had suggested that the fire may have been caused by a short circuit on the ground floor, where several parked two-wheelers caught fire. However, the CCTV footage prompted investigators to examine the possibility of foul play as well. Forensic experts and local police teams inspected the scene and are analysing technical and physical evidence collected from the building.

EOW arrests proclaimed offender in multi-crore real estate fraud case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Economic Offences Wing (EOW) of the Delhi Police arrested a proclaimed offender in Faridabad, Haryana, on Saturday. The individual had allegedly been evading arrest for several years in connection with a multi-crore real estate fraud case, officials said.

The accused, identified as Shiv Nandan Singh Yadav, was wanted in nine cheating cases registered in 2019 on the complaints of multiple investors who alleged they had been duped into investing in a housing project that never took shape. He was apprehended on Friday after remaining on the run for nearly seven years, police said.

According to investigators, the cases were registered following directions issued by the chief metropolitan magistrate of the



Shahdara district at Karkardooma Courts.

During the probe, the EOW found that all nine complaints involved a common pattern of alleged fraud and the same set of accused operating through M/s GRPL Globe Reality Pvt. Ltd.

Police said the company had launched a residential project, "Krishan Kunj Township", at Tilori Khadar village in Greater Faridabad in 2013. Through advertisements and promotional campaigns, the company allegedly persuaded investors to purchase residential plots in the proposed township.

The project was advertised as a residential colony

comprising 496 plots spread across approximately 10.26 acres of land. However, the investigation revealed that the company and its directors allegedly misrepresented facts about the project and did not have adequate legal title to the land required for its development.

After collecting substantial amounts from investors, the accused allegedly failed to deliver the promised plots and abandoned the project, causing significant financial losses to buyers, police said.

Yadav had been absconding since 2019 and repeatedly evaded legal proceedings, officials said. In 2023, a court declared him a proclaimed offender in all nine cases after he remained untraceable despite repeated efforts to locate him.

Police said further investigation is underway to trace other accused persons and recover the proceeds of the alleged fraud.

NDMC offers 10% rebate on property tax payments made by June 30

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) on Saturday announced a 10 per cent rebate on property tax for the financial year 2026-27 for taxpayers who clear their dues on or before June 30.

"All property owners of NDMC area are encouraged to avail themselves of this beneficial scheme by making timely payment of their Property Tax and thereby enjoy substantial savings through the rebate offered by NDMC," according to a statement.

The rebate scheme has been a recurring feature of NDMC's property tax collection drive in recent years and is aimed at encouraging early compliance and improving revenue collection. The council had offered a similar 10 per cent rebate



last year for payments made before June 30.

The announcement comes amid changes in the property tax regime in the NDMC area. Earlier this year, Parliament cleared amendments enabling the implementation of a uniform Unit Area Method for property tax assessment across the NDMC jurisdiction.

The move will replace the rateable value-based system for the remaining proper-

ties and bring greater uniformity in tax calculation.

The NDMC, in its statement, appealed to taxpayers to avoid a last-minute rush and deposit their dues well before the deadline to avail of the concession.

Taxpayers requiring assistance may contact the NDMC Tax Department during office hours or visit the council's website for further details, the statement said.

Two mobile technicians arrested for unlocking stolen phones for resale

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Two mobile software technicians were arrested on Saturday for allegedly receiving stolen mobile phones and using advanced software tools to unlock them for resale, according to officials.

The accused, Mohd Jalal (29) of Loni in Ghaziabad district, Uttar Pradesh, and Imran (27) of Rajpur Khurd Extension, Delhi, allegedly ran a mobile repair and software servicing shop in Gaffar Market, Karol Bagh.

Police said the two operated 'KGN Software & Mobile Repairing Institute' and were involved in unlocking stolen smartphones for resale in the grey market.

Based on specific inputs, the police raided the shop. They recovered 45 intact



Android smartphones, 22 mobile phone bodies, a laptop, and a Chinese-made AMP tool reportedly used to bypass factory reset protection and other security features.

"The accused failed to produce satisfactory ownership documents for the recovered devices. They were apprehended on Friday, and the electronic equipment was seized," a

police officer said. During questioning, the accused allegedly admitted to using specialised software and electronic tools to alter security settings of mobile phones obtained through suspicious sources, making it difficult for owners to trace their devices, police said.

Preliminary checks have linked seven of the recovered phones to theft and loss cases in Delhi, Haryana,

and Uttar Pradesh, including incidents reported at Madhu Vihar, New Ashok Nagar, Mandawali, Ghazipur, Panipat, and Muzaffarnagar, highlighting the extent of the operation. IMEI analysis and coordination with police units in multiple states to identify their rightful owners and establish links with other theft cases, officials said.

Efforts are ongoing to trace the source of the stolen phones and identify other members of the network, including suppliers and receivers involved in the illegal trade, officials added. The police said the recovery could help solve multiple mobile phone theft cases reported across Delhi and neighbouring states, making the investigation significant for several pending cases. Further investigation is underway.

Dwarka dog shelter to be ready by November: MCD officials

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi's dog shelter at Dwarka Sector-29, having a capacity to accommodate around 1,500 stray dogs, is likely to be completed by November this year, with other spaces also being identified for developing such shelters.

The status of the projects was reviewed during a meeting held at the Delhi Secretariat on Friday, attended by officials of the MCD, the Delhi Development Authority (DDA), the Animal Husbandry Department and the Public

Works Department (PWD), to assess compliance with the Supreme Court's directions on stray dog management.

"We reviewed the compliance status of the directions issued by the Supreme Court and the progress of various infrastructure projects. The Dwarka dog shelter is under development; it will accommodate around 1,500 dogs and will be completed likely by November this year," a senior Municipal Corporation of Delhi official said.

He said that a five-acre MCD-owned land at Mukundpur is under consideration for the development of an integrated Animal Birth



Control (ABC) centre, dog shelter and dog crematorium in accordance with the Standard Operating Procedure issued by the Animal Welfare Board of

India (AWBI) and the top court's directions.

"Space has also been identified at Bela Road for development of a dog shelter, while the department is in

the process of identifying additional land at government veterinary hospitals and dispensaries under the Animal Husbandry Department for establishing more dog shelters," the official said.

The civic body is developing the shelters to accommodate stray dogs picked up from educational institutions, hospitals, medical colleges, sports complexes, bus stands and depots, railway stations and other public spaces, including religious places, children's parks, airports, helipads, tourist sites and recreational areas, in line with the court's directions.

Sales director held for ramming SUV into traffic policeman

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A sales director of a private company has been arrested for allegedly ramming his SUV into a traffic policeman and fleeing after being asked to stop for a traffic violation in Sarai Jullena, police said on Saturday.

The Crime Branch arrested the accused, 31-year-old Md Mubashshir Abbas, a Jamia Nagar resident, on June 12 following a two-day manhunt. Officials said the offending SUV used in the incident has also been recovered.

Police said the incident occurred around 9:45 am on June 10 when Head Constable Rahul Kumar of the Traffic Circle, New Friends' Colony, was regulating traffic at the Sarai Jullena red light.

According to police, a black SUV was seen approaching at high speed from the Jamia Nagar side, driving on the wrong side of the road.

When Rahul Kumar signalled the driver to stop, the accused allegedly accelerated



ed the vehicle, struck the traffic policeman, and fled towards Mata Mandir Marg.

Fellow police personnel rushed the injured head constable to Fortis Hospital.

Based on his statement and medical examination, police registered a case at the New Friends' Colony police station under relevant provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Motor Vehicles Act.

The incident, captured on CCTV, drew widespread attention on social media and triggered public outrage. Investigators analysed CCTV footage from multiple locations along the vehicle's route and developed technical and human intelligence to identify the accused.

Police said Abbas made sustained efforts to evade

arrest by frequently changing his location and repeatedly switching his mobile phone on and off. However, investigators tracked him down and apprehended him from his workplace in Connaught Place, on Thursday.

During interrogation, the accused allegedly disclosed that he was on his way to his workplace in Connaught Place and was running late. To avoid heavy traffic congestion near Sarai Jullena, he chose to drive on the wrong side of the road.

When traffic personnel attempted to stop him, he allegedly tried to evade checking and accelerated the vehicle. In the process, he intentionally struck the traffic policeman, causing injuries, and fled without stopping to help the victim, police said.

Investigators said Abbas later concealed the vehicle after learning that police teams were searching for him. Acting on his disclosure, the Crime Branch recovered the SUV from the Jamia Nagar area.

The Pioneer Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

I, No.10136855A L/NK Naresh, R/o- Vill & PO- Sultanpur, Teh & Dist- Hansi, Haryana- 125033, have changed my Son's name from Nitin to Nitin Kumar, vide affidavit dated 13/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Kumari Manasvee Diwaker, D/o- JC-NYA 15566231L N/Sub Virendra Diwakar, R/o- 59 E.I Bazaar Agra Cantt, U.P.- 282001 have changed my name from Kumari Mansavee Diwaker to Manasvi Diwaker, vide affidavit dated 13/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.

I, Dyaram, Father of No.16031215H RFN Harinder, R/o- Vill- Bandhwari, Post- Kadarpur, Teh- Sohna, Dist- Gurgaon, Haryana- 122001, have changed my name from Dyaram to Dayaram, vide affidavit dated 13/06/2026 before Notary Public Delhi.



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डीन (प्रशासन) / Dean (Admin)
CBC 21255/11/0001/2627

ग्रेटर नोएडा औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण
प्लॉट संख्या—01, सेक्टर—नॉलेज पार्क—4 ग्रेटर नोएडा सिटी,
जिला—गौतमबुद्ध नगर (३०३०)

सार्वजनिक सूचना

ग्रेटर नोएडा औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण के अन्तर्गत M/s Nav Durga Buildcon Pvt. Ltd., भूखण्ड संख्या—LS-09, Sector-36, Greater Noida को दिनांक 20.05.2023 को मानचित्र स्वीकृति प्रदान की गयी थी। तदोपरांत विकासकर्ता द्वारा (Commercial Project) का अधिभोग प्रमाण-पत्र हेतु ऑनलाइन के माध्यम से आवेदन संख्या—CC-10974 दिनांक 25.09.2025 है। तत्क्रम में UP-Apartment Act-2010, As Amendment in 2016, Section-4 Sub Section-B के अन्तर्गत परियोजना के आवंटियों से आपत्ति/सुझाव आमंत्रित किये जाने का प्रावधान है। इस सम्बन्ध में विकासकर्ता द्वारा प्रस्तुत स्वीकृति मानचित्र एवं Declarations as per UP Apartment Act-2010 का परीक्षण किसी भी कार्यदिवस में सुबह 9:30 से सायं 6:00 बजे के मध्य निविदन विभाग में तथा प्राधिकरण की वेबसाइट पर किया जा सकता है।

अतः उपरोक्त परियोजना के आवंटियों द्वारा Sanction Map एवं Declarations as per UP Apartment Act-2010 के सम्बन्ध में सूचना प्रकाशित करने के 30 दिनों के अन्दर आपत्ति/सुझाव आमंत्रित की जाती है। उपरोक्त के लिहाज से अपनी आपत्ति Email ld-gmplaning@gnida.in पर अवधान लिखित रूप में अपने आवेदन पत्र, नाम, पता एवं दूरभाष नम्बर के साथ कार्यलय समय व कार्यदिवस में ग्रेटर नोएडा प्राधिकरण के मुख्य प्रशासनिक कार्यलय, भूखण्ड संख्या—1, नॉलेज पार्क—4, ग्रेटर नोएडा में स्थित महाप्रबन्धक (निविदन/वास्तु) को सम्बोधित करते हुए सूचना प्रकाशित होने के 30 दिनों के अन्दर जमा कराया जा सकती है।

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ग्रेटर नोएडा औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण

PUBLIC NOTICE

I, Sushela Devi, W/o Late Sh. Markenday Rai, R/o I-19, Near Chand Market, Krishan Vihar, Sultan Puri, C Block, North West Delhi, Delhi-110086, hereby declare that I have changed my name from Sushila Rai to Sushela Devi for all purposes. Further, my wrong date of birth is 14-05-1954 and my correct date of birth is 04-05-1956. Henceforth, I shall be known as Sushela Devi with the corrected date of birth 04-05-1956 for all purposes.

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PUBLIC NOTICE

The Public at large is hereby notified that Mahalakshmi Buildcon, G/o Mrs. SAROJ RANI intend to purchase a Property No.160, Measuring Area 347.9 Sq.Mtrs. Gyan Khand-I, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh-201014, from Mrs. Ritu Kukreja alias Ria Goli wife of Mr. Nakul Goli R/o R/o 75, Sector-15A, Noida, Uttar Pradesh-201301, who represent Herself absolute owner of the property.It is therefore, Notified that anybody claiming any rights, title, interest, share or lien over the aforesaid property may file such claim or objection to the undersigned within a period of 03 days from the date of Publication of this notice. Otherwise, it will be presumed that the said property is free from all encumbrances, charges and/or lien, etc. and I am free to purchase the said property from the above named seller.

Mahalakshmi Buildcon,
C/o Mrs. SAROJ RANI 202, Gyan Khand-I,
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OFFICE OF THE MUNICIPAL CORPORATION, BHOPAL (M.P.)

GARDEN SECTION

SECTION 1

Notice Inviting e-Tenders

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Dated-13.06.2026

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1.	2026 UAD 504437.2	Plantation Aerocity work at ward 75 (10000 plants) including 3 years Maintenance	77,33,293/-	58,000/-	10,000/-	1275 DAYS
2.	2026 UAD 504271.2	Plantation work at Adhampur khanti (20000 plants) with 3 year maintenance.	1,60,88,092/-	80,440/-	12,500/-	1275 DAYS
3.	2026 UAD 504334.2	Plantation work at Airport plantation site (10000 plants) and Bairagarh bus depo (5000 plants) with 3 year maintenance	1,18,07,200/-	59,036/-	12,500/-	1275 DAYS

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2. The Bid Document can be purchased only online

Executive Engineer

Municipal Corporation Bhopal

District Bhopal

T.N.315/026/027

Govt will ensure consumers remain protected, says Sood

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Addressing concerns regarding the recent power purchase adjustment cost revision, Power Minister Ashish Sood on Saturday said the Delhi Government will ensure consumers remain protected amid a global fuel cost surge.

Sood said that the Power Purchase Adjustment Cost (PPAC) is a statutory mechanism provided under the country's electricity laws and is not a new arrangement. "The provision enables electricity distribution companies to adjust for fluctuations in fuel and power procurement costs every month," Sood said.

The power minister said that as the last tariff order was passed by the DERC on 30.09.2021, the PPAC charged by the discoms is the difference between the purchase price of power as of 30.09.2021 and the price of power during the months of the current year. It means PPAC recovered currently by



discoms reflects the increase of power cost during the last around five years.

According to the minister, the adjustment has become necessary due to an 'unprecedented' rise in global fuel prices triggered by the ongoing West Asia crisis and other international factors.

"The electricity laws of the country already permit power companies to adjust for the rising cost of fuel used to generate electricity. Due to the situation in West Asia and other prevailing circumstances, fuel costs have risen sharply, leading to a 31

per cent increase in power procurement costs during the past month," Sood further said.

He added that despite this substantial increase in generation costs, timely intervention by the Delhi government ensured that the burden on consumers remained minimal.

"Even though power procurement costs rose by 31 per cent, the Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission (DERC) has allowed only an average increase of 2.4 per cent in PPAC. Earlier, the PPAC had been capped at 14.5 per

cent till March 31," Sood said. With the latest revision, it stands at approximately 17.5-17.9 per cent.

This demonstrates our commitment to protecting consumers from the full impact of rising global energy prices, he added. The utility bills are set to go up after the DERC on Friday permitted the city's three power distribution companies, BSES Rajdhani Power Limited (BRPL), BSES Yamuna Power Limited (BYPL) and Tata Power Delhi Distribution Limited (TPDDL) to recover FPPA for April 2026.

FPPAS is applied as a percentage of total energy and fixed costs and is dependent on fuel prices. Recently, there has been a significant increase in coal prices due to higher imports and transport costs. In May, BRPL, BYPL and TPDDL had sought relaxation on the recovery of FPPAS, which is capped at 10 per cent from the DERC. The discoms had urged the DERC to increase the FPPAS recovery limit for April.

Govt to organise Maa Yamuna Riverbank cleanliness drive across 28 ghats today

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government will organise the 'Maa Yamuna Riverbank Cleanliness Drive' across 28 ghats of the Yamuna River on Sunday, June 14. Organised under the message 'Ek Sankalp — Swachh Yamuna' (One Resolve — Clean Yamuna), the campaign will be an important initiative towards restoring the Yamuna to its former glory, cleaning the riverbanks, increasing public awareness about environmental conservation, and transforming public participation into a broad-based people's movement.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta will personally lead the cleanliness drive at Thokar No. 14, Geeta Colony Ghat. Ministers of the Delhi Government and other dignitaries will also participate in the campaign.

According to a press statement issued by the chief minister's office, the protection and cleanliness of the Yamuna are not only the



responsibility of the government but also the duty of every citizen. The campaign is being organised with the objective of taking this message to the people and encouraging collective participation.

The cleanliness of the Yamuna is not a one-day programme but a continuous public movement that requires the participation of every section of society, she said. Delhi Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta will be present at the Old Railway Bridge and Deputy Speaker Mohan Singh Bisht at Dedh Pushta, Sonia Vihar.

Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh will lead the

campaign at Hathi Ghat on the ITO Downstream Western Bank.

Around 500 social, religious, educational and voluntary organisations, along with volunteers and Delhi residents, are expected to participate in the campaign, the officials said.

The campaign will be conducted simultaneously at several prominent locations, including Chilla Village Ghat, Nizamuddin Ghat, Thokar No. 14 Geeta Colony Ghat, Thokar No. 18 Gandhi Nagar Ghat, Purana Lohe Pul Ghat, Signature Bridge-Wazirabad Ghat (Eastern Bank), Dedh Pushta Ghat (Sonia Vihar), Chautha Pushta Ghat (Sonia

Vihar), Kartavya Kunj Ghat (West Bank), Hathi Ghat near the ITO Old Railway Bridge, Ram Ghat, Kali Ghat, Shyam Ghat, Yamuna Bank, Yamuneshwar Ghat, Wazirabad Yamuna Biodiversity Park (Right Bank), Railway Bridge Yamuna Bank, ITO Downstream Western Bank-1, ITO Downstream Western Bank-2, ITO Upstream Right Bank, Sarai Kale Khan R/B, Thokar No. 13, Kunderiya Ghat, Nigam Bodh Ghat, Eastern Bank Downstream Wazirabad, and Kalindi Kunj Downstream (Eastern Bank), among other key locations.

During the campaign, citizens will be encouraged to take a pledge that they will not immerse religious offerings, flowers, garlands or idols in the river, will not use polythene or single-use plastic, will not throw old clothes, waste or any other garbage into the Yamuna, will keep the riverbanks clean and will encourage others to contribute towards the cleanliness of the Yamuna.

Intellectually challenged woman assaulted in Trilokpuri, case registered

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Police has launched an investigation after finding an intellectually challenged woman injured in the Trilokpuri area; multiple teams have been formed to identify and apprehend the accused, officials said on Saturday.

According to police, a PCR call was received at the Mayur Vihar police station around 6:30 am on June 12 regarding an injured woman lying near Trilokpuri in East Delhi.

Police said they did not find the injured woman or the complainant there.

When police contacted the caller, they learned he was a rickshaw puller who had already left the area after informing authorities.

During local inquiries, police found that an ambulance had shifted the injured woman to Guru Teg Bahadur (GTB) Hospital.

The victim was later identified as an intellectually challenged vagrant woman frequently seen roaming around the Block 27 area of Trilokpuri.

Police said her medico-legal case (MLC) report indicated physical assault, as the woman had swelling and superficial injury marks on her face.

Doctors told investigators that she is conscious but currently unable to provide a coherent statement due to her intellectual disability.

Following the incident, Crime and Forensic Science Laboratory (FSL) teams were called to inspect the scene and collect evidence. Police also conducted extensive local inquiries in the area.

Delhi court declines interim relief to Indian Polo Association

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Paving the way for the eviction of Jaipur Polo Ground in the Race Course area of the national Capital, a Delhi court declined to grant interim protection to the Indian Polo Association (IPA) against the Centre's order directing it to vacate the ground.

The order dated June 12 was posted on the court website on Saturday as officials of the Land and Development Office under the Union Housing and Urban Affairs Ministry took



Security guards are deployed near the Jaipur Polo Ground in Delhi's Race Course area

physical possession of the 15.20-acre Jaipur Polo Ground. Additional Sessions Judge Dhirender Rana was hearing an application filed by the IPA under Section 9(3) of the Public Premises (Eviction of Unauthorised Occupants)

Act, 1971, seeking a stay on the enforcement and execution of the eviction order by the central government.

In its order, the court said, "A similar kind of request was moved before the Learned Principal District and Sessions Judge, PHC and Delhi High Court, and no relief was granted to the appellant. Therefore, keeping in view judicial discipline and propriety, I am not inclined to stay the execution of the impugned order even till next date".

The court, however, directed the Union government to file replies to the appeal and

the stay application and listed the matter before the vacation judge on June 17.

The dispute pertains to the Jaipur Polo Ground situated in Lutyens' Delhi. The Centre has informed the courts that the land occupied by the polo ground and nearby establishments, including the Delhi Gymkhana Club, is proposed to be taken over for public purposes.

Appearing for the Union government, its standing counsel Ashish Dixit sought time to file replies to the appeal as well as the stay application.



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IN FOCUS



People gather at a snow site near Rohtang Pass in Manali, Himachal Pradesh on Saturday

PTI

Congress launches anti-paper leak campaign; Rahul to kickstart student conventions



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

The Congress on Saturday announced the first phase of a nationwide campaign against the alleged paper leaks and examination irregularities, with Rahul Gandhi scheduled to address a series of student conventions, starting from Kota on June 17.

The movement will seek to unite students beyond political affiliations and provide a platform for affected youth to share their experiences and demand accountability for "repeated examination failures and paper leak scandals", the party said.

In a statement, AICC general Secretary (organisation) K C Venugopal said, "The Congress party will therefore seek a comprehensive discussion in Parliament on the crisis confronting India's youth and advocate legislative measures to protect their interests, rights and future."

He said LoP Rahul Gandhi, who has emerged as the "most consistent and credible advocate" for India's students and youth, will conduct a series of large student conventions starting with Kota (June

17), Allahabad (July 10), Patna (July 11) and Delhi (July 14), bringing together students, aspirants, youth organisations, educators and all those directly affected by the alleged examination scandals. "The campaign will highlight the hardships faced by millions of young Indians whose futures are being repeatedly jeopardised by paper leaks, rising examination costs and the government's failure to ensure a fair and transparent recruitment and education system," Venugopal said.

As part of this nationwide campaign, the party will reiterate Gandhi's call to mobilise students through extensive outreach by National Students' Union of India (NSUI), Youth Congress, Pradesh Congress Committees, District Congress Committees and local units across the country, he said. Physical and digital invitations, campus outreach, interactions at coaching centres, universities, schools and youth hubs, social media campaigns, live screenings and direct engagement with students will be undertaken on a massive scale, according to Venugopal.

Delhi Police issues notice ordering joint foot patrolling on weekends

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ NEW DELHI

In a move to ease traffic woes and strengthen law and order, Delhi Police has issued a circular mandating joint foot patrolling by district and traffic police personnel on weekends and two additional days every week from 5 pm to 8 pm. According to a circular issued by Delhi Police Commissioner Satish Golchha, district and traffic DCPs (deputy commissioner of police) to carry out joint foot patrols every Saturday and Sunday, and on two additional days each week from 5 pm to 8 pm to improve Delhi police mechanisms and foster better coordination with local communities.

This comes after the Lieutenant Governor TS Sandhu directed Delhi police commissioner issue directions to improve direct public interaction, regulate traffic, remove temporary obstructions and encroachments, and address local issues in a time-bound manner. Sandhu has been emphasising visible, proactive, and interactive policing as the strongest deterrent against crime and traffic violations since he took over.

The circular issued by the Commissioner of Police, Delhi, Satish Golchha, addressed to all Special CPs, Jt. CPs and DCPs, etc., seek to ensure joint foot patrolling by District Police and Traffic Police officers on Saturdays, Sundays and two additional



days every week from 1700 hrs to 2000 hrs. To minimise time spent on the ground, the police have been directed to minimise office work and in-house meetings between 5 pm and 8 pm. This three-hour window will now be dedicated entirely to field duties, allowing personnel to focus on patrolling, surveillance and public engagement during peak evening hours.

As per the circular, the District and Traffic Police teams will also conduct dedicated patrols on four days each week to clear road obstructions, remove encroachments that cause traffic snarls, and reduce delays across major corridors and residential areas.

Senior officers have also been tasked with stepping out of their offices to interact directly with Residents' Welfare Associations (RWAs) and Market Traders' Associations (MTAs) in their respective jurisdictions. These on-the-ground meetings are intended to collaboratively identify and address local security con-

cerns and recurring traffic issues.

All DCPs shall monitor implementation personally. ACPs shall ensure effective execution in their respective subdivisions. DCP (Traffic) and DCP (District) shall maintain close coordination for joint action on recurring problem areas. Compliance reports shall be submitted through the respective DCPs to the Special CP/Law & Order/Zones and the Special CP/Traffic Management Division. The objective of the exercise shall be to ensure direct field supervision and immediate corrective action on the ground. No office work, meeting, conference, or indoor review should be scheduled during the aforesaid time, as far as possible.

The entire period shall be devoted exclusively to field presence, public interaction, on-spot supervision, and immediate corrective action. District and Traffic teams should identify and remove temporary encroachments and general obstructions. They should address traffic

bottlenecks and ensure smooth vehicular movement. They should take appropriate action against illegal parking and misuse of road space. They should inspect vulnerable points, public places, markets, and congestion-prone stretches.

The compliance report, due every Monday, shall be submitted by each district and Traffic to the Special CP/Law & Order/Zones and the Special CP/Traffic Management Division. Photographs and videography of the joint patrolling and action taken shall also be undertaken and compiled, a senior police officer said.

Police sources said the guidelines are part of an ongoing effort to make policing more proactive and citizen-centric. Increased foot presence, they believe, will act as a deterrent to crime, while the focused traffic drives will help improve mobility in a city that continues to grapple with congestion.

The measures come at a time when both safety perceptions and traffic management remain high-priority concerns for Delhi residents. With the new field-centric approach, the Delhi Police expects to register a visible improvement in both domains in the coming weeks. "Any lapse in compliance, a casual approach, non-participation by supervisory officers, or failure to submit reports on time shall be viewed seriously," said the police official.

Triumph: 515 cadets, including nine women, commissioned at IMA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Dehradun

Deep familial pride and emotion marked the Indian Military Academy's (IMA) Spring Term 2026 Passing Out Parade on Saturday as 515 officer cadets, including nine women, were commissioned into the Indian Army.

The traditional pipping ceremony transformed the academy grounds into a scene of celebration, with families gathering on the lawns to pin the new ranks on the shoulders of their sons and daughters.

For several families, the parade marked the culmination of generations of mili-

tary service and sacrifice.

The batch also marked a significant milestone with the commissioning of nine women officer cadets, an important moment for the institution that has trained generations of Army officers since 1932.

Among them was Shanan Dhaka, who has been posted to eastern Ladakh.

"Coming from a military family, joining the Army was not just a career choice but a way of life," Dhaka said, noting that both her father and grandfather served in the Army.

"I would tell everyone to dream big and keep working hard. One day, all your hard-



work will pay off and you will achieve what you are aiming for," she said.

Her father urged parents to encourage their daughters to join the armed forces.

"As a father, I would encourage every girl to join

the armed forces. It is a respected profession through which you can serve the country and fulfill your aspirations," he said.

The parade also celebrated exceptional merit. Academy Cadet Adjutant

NTA launches digital training programme for examination officials

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

The National Testing Agency (NTA) has launched a dedicated digital training programme for examination officials on the iGOT Karmayogi Bharat platform to strengthen supervision and invigilation of its examinations, including NEET-UG. Titled 'Pariksha Karmayogi: Capacity-Building Programme for Examination Officials', the programme has been designed to strengthen the capacity of examination functionaries and to ensure the smooth, secure and standardised conduct of offline, pen-and-paper based examinations, the NTA said in a statement on Saturday.

The course is intended for examination functionaries, in particular Centre Superintendents and Invigilators, who are involved in the conduct of the NTA examinations, including the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test NEET (Undergraduate), the statement said.

The programme comprises four modules that together cover the complete examination lifecycle.

The first module introduces the course and the role of examination functionaries in maintaining fairness, transparency and integrity. The second covers preparedness before the examination, including centre readiness, security



arrangements and adherence to standard operating procedures.

The third module deals with examination-day operations across four stages -- before the examination, at the beginning of the examination, during the examination and after the examination. The fourth module serves as a quick reference guide, offering a concise recap of key instructions and responsibilities.

Hosted on the iGOT Karmayogi Bharat platform, the course enables standardised, self-paced learning and assessment-based certification for examination personnel across the country. The initiative aims to enhance procedural compliance, operational efficiency and accountability at examination centres, the statement said.

It further said that well-trained personnel are critical to the smooth and fair conduct of large-scale national examinations. By establishing uniform examination administration standards, the programme reinforces NTA's commitment to excellence and integrity in its examinations.

India flays 'lethal' action on mariners

For the Settebello, US aircraft reportedly fired directly into the engine room after the crew did not follow instructions. India has firmly opposed the use of deadly force against commercial ships. After speaking with Rubio, Jaishankar posted on X: "I reiterated India's strong protest at the attacks by the US Navy in the Gulf that killed three Indian mariners. Such lethal actions against commercial shipping are not justified." Earlier, New Delhi called in the US chargé d'affaires, Jason Meeks, to express its "deepest concerns." The Shipping Ministry has warned Indian seafarers working in dangerous waters, and the Indian Navy has helped with rescue and damage control. The current standoff began after the US-Iran conflict escalated in 2026. After US and Israeli strikes on Iranian targets in late February, Iran put restrictions on shipping through the Strait of Hormuz. On April 13, the US answered by setting up a naval blockade on Iranian ports and ships suspected of carrying sanctioned Iranian oil. The Strait of Hormuz is the world's most important oil route, located between Iran in the north and Oman and the UAE in the south. Any trouble here affects global energy markets. The US blockade is meant to stop Iran from exporting oil and making money during the conflict, while Iran uses its location to its advantage. Many targeted ships are part of the 'shadow fleet', older tankers flying flags of convenience like Palau or Guinea-Bissau that carry Iranian oil despite sanctions. Indian seafarers make up a large share of the global maritime workforce and often work on these ships for higher pay, despite the job's risks.

Families in states such as Uttar Pradesh, Himachal Pradesh, and Andhra Pradesh are mourning the loss of breadwinners who left home to work at sea. Opposition parties have criticised the government's handling of the issue, while maritime unions have called for better protection of Indian crew on tankers operating in conflict zones.

This incident comes at a delicate moment for India-US relations. The two countries have strong strategic ties through the Quad, defence cooperation, and trade. Still, protecting Indian citizens is a top priority for New Delhi. Jaishankar's direct talks with Rubio show India's commitment to addressing the issue at the highest level while seeking to avoid further conflict.

The United States says its actions are defensive and meant to enforce international sanctions and

keep shipping lanes open. US officials argue that ships which do not follow orders and ignore warnings put US forces and regional stability at risk. Behind the public posturing, quiet diplomacy continues. There are indications of possible US-Iran interim understandings that could ease the blockade and reopen safe passage through the Strait in exchange for concessions on nuclear and regional issues. As the world watches oil markets closely, keeping navigation safe in the Strait of Hormuz is both a strategic and humanitarian need.

UP Govt forms SIT in Ram Temple trust row

The SIT comprises Vijay Vishwas Pant, IAS, Divisional Commissioner, Lucknow; Kiran S. IPS, Inspector General of Police; and Neel Ratan, Special Secretary, Finance Department.

The controversy surfaced earlier this month when Samajwadi Party President Akhilesh Yadav claimed that reports had emerged suggesting crores of rupees from donations made to the Ram Temple were missing and urged the court to take suo motu cognisance of the matter. Congress also demanded an independent probe, with Uttar Pradesh Congress Chief Ajay Rai seeking an inquiry headed by a sitting high court judge. Responding to the allegations, Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust general secretary Champat Rai had said that internal audits were underway and no evidence supporting the claims had emerged so far. He had said representatives of the trust and the State Bank of India were involved in periodic audits and that nothing noteworthy had come to light during the ongoing exercise.

Trust member Mahant Dinendra Das had also expressed confidence in the trust's functioning and said any inquiry ordered by the Government would be acceptable. Ram Temple Construction Committee Chairman Nripendra Mishra, however, distanced himself from the controversy, saying his responsibility was limited to monitoring construction-related work, and declined to comment on allegations concerning donations and financial irregularities.

The controversy subsequently escalated, with Akhilesh Yadav reiterating his allegations, former BJP MP Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh claiming he was aware of alleged misuse of donations but declining to reveal details, and senior BJP leader Rajneesh Singh writing to Prime Minister Narendra Modi seeking public disclosure of the

FROM PAGE - 1

trust's finances, assets, donations, expenditures, bank accounts and land transactions.

Rajneesh Singh said devotees who had contributed to the construction of the temple had a right to know how donations, including cash, ornaments and other valuables, were being utilised. Responding to the controversy, Uttar Pradesh minister Surya Pratap Shahi had said the trust had already initiated an inquiry and would take action in accordance with its rules and regulations, while maintaining that the matter primarily fell within the trust's jurisdiction.

Govt takes possession of Jaipur Polo Ground

On Saturday, the Central Government officials pasted a notice on the front wall of the historic Jaipur Polo Ground, saying, "This land is the property of the Land & Development Office (L&DO), Government of India." "Any kind of unauthorised occupation, encroachment, construction, or any other illegal activity on this land is a punishable offence under the law. "Persons engaging in such acts shall be subject to penal and legal action in accordance with the applicable laws," the notice stated.

In its order posted online on Saturday, the court said, "A similar kind of request was moved before the Learned Principal District and Sessions Judge, PHC and Delhi High Court, and no relief was granted to the appellant. Therefore, keeping in view judicial discipline and propriety, I am not inclined to stay the execution of the impugned order even till next date". The court, however, directed the Union government to file replies to the appeal and the stay application and listed the matter before the vacation judge on June 17. "As the matter is *sub judice* and ongoing, the Association does not propose to comment further at this stage," said IPA counsel, Major (Retd) Nirvikar Singh.

The acquisition of the Jaipur Polo Ground is part of a broader, synchronised campaign by the Central government to scrutinise and reclaim expansive public land parcels held by legacy institutions, with parallel eviction proceedings currently targeting the neighbouring Delhi Gymkhana Club and the Delhi Race Club.

The administrative push began on May 20, 2026, when the L&DO issued an eviction order directing the IPA to hand over the sprawling premises located in the high-security Race

Course area. The Centre contends that the lease for the land expired in 1993, rendering the IPA's continued presence unauthorised.

While the Government has kept specific redevelopment blueprints confidential, it defended its decision in court by stating the land is required for a "larger public purpose and benefit," including the strengthening of defence infrastructure and other vital public security functions. Nearly a century after Maharaja Sawai Man Singh II of Jaipur gifted a part of his Delhi estate to the Delhi Polo Club, the historic Jaipur Polo Ground finds itself at the centre of a legal battle over its future. Named after the legendary ruler and polo player, the 15.2-acre venue in Delhi's Race Course area has long been regarded as one of India's most prestigious and oldest polo grounds. For generations, it has hosted some of the country's biggest polo tournaments and remained closely associated with a sporting tradition that traces its roots to India's princely era. According to the IPA, the Central Public Works Department (CPWD) signed a 20-year lease for the property in 1951 and polo activities continued at the venue. When the lease expired in 1971, it was extended from time to time on the same terms and conditions until the end of 1982, according to the association. A major change followed in 1983 when the Delhi Polo Club was dissolved and the IPA, recognised as the national governing body for the sport, took over the management and possession of the venue.

The association says government communications issued in 1983 and 1984 recorded the transition and extended the lease arrangement in its favour. According to the IPA, a 1991 communication described the Jaipur Polo Ground as a historic venue that was used for polo since New Delhi was founded. The communication recommended renewing the lease, noting that proposals to shift activities linked to the Delhi Race Club could take time and that relocation could be discussed later. The association further cites a November 30, 1992, communication which, it says, reaffirmed the decision to renew the lease and stated that from April 1, 1993, extensions would be granted on a yearly basis until the ground shifted to an alternative site. The IPA says it continues to pay ground rent and remains in possession of the venue.

The legal battle escalated earlier in the week when the dispute reached the Delhi High Court. On June 8, Justice Neena Bansal Krishna expressed sharp environmental concerns over the loss of central Delhi's open spaces, noting

orally that "Delhi will suffocate" and asking the government counsel, "All of us will suffocate and die. For all the years these have existed, the Government never felt the need for the land?"

Despite these observations, the High Court refrained from granting an explicit stay, recording the Centre's assurance that no coercive steps would be taken until June 12, and directed the appropriate district court to urgently decide on the IPA's stay application. On Friday, June 12, Vacation Judge Dharendra Rana of the Patiala House Courts officially declined the IPA's request to halt the eviction process under the Public Premises (Eviction of Unauthorised Occupants) Act, citing judicial discipline and the fact that higher courts had not granted ad-interim relief. With the expiration of the June 12 deadline, central authorities moved swiftly the following morning to secure the perimeter.

21-year-old caught impersonating...

Circle Officer Pankaj Pant confirmed that a complaint has been received and a case is being registered.

The driver and the two individuals accompanying Verma are currently under questioning. Further legal action will be determined based on the outcome of the investigation.

The Army said this operation showed the alertness of military authorities and veterans. They added that pretending to be military personnel and using military insignia or ID documents without permission are serious crimes and will be dealt with strictly under the law.

Modi-Trump to meet during G7 Summit...

This will be the first meeting between Modi and Trump since the latter assumed office for his second term. Discussions are likely to cover defence and security cooperation, trade, technology, energy, and Indo-Pacific stability.

Modi's week-long tour includes stops in France for the G7-related events and bilateral talks, followed by a visit to Slovakia. The itinerary reflects India's focus on strengthening ties with key European partners. The Ministry of External Affairs has described the visit as an opportunity to further deepen India's strategic, economic, and cultural partnerships with both nations.



TMC crisis deepens as MP Sudip Bandyopadhyay may join rebels

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH

New Delhi/Kolkata

Senior Trinamool Congress (TMC) MP Sudip Bandyopadhyay arrived in Delhi on Saturday and met Union Minister Bhupender Yadav, along with rebel MP Satabdi Roy.

This move has fueled speculation that Bandyopadhyay, once seen as one of Mamata Banerjee's closest allies, is joining the party's dissident group. Bandyopadhyay, who represents Kolkata Uttar and was previously TMC's Lok Sabha leader, came to the capital as reports of behind-the-scenes talks surfaced.

Videos of him travelling with Satabdi Roy and entering Bhupender Yadav's home, the BJP's Bengal in-charge, have spread widely online. This comes just weeks after TMC's heavy defeat in the West Bengal Assembly elections, sparking internal unrest. The current crisis began after TMC's heavy defeat in the April 2026 Assembly elections. The BJP won a landslide, taking 207-208 seats and ending TMC's 15-year rule.

TMC was left with only 80 seats, and Mamata Banerjee lost her own seat. Suwendu Adhikari, who left TMC years ago, became Chief Minister. The loss revealed serious divisions within the party. Reports highlighted frustration over claims of family control, governance problems, and the rising influence of Mamata's nephew, Abhishek Banerjee.

The rebellion started at the State level.

A fight over the Leader of the Opposition post led to claims that Abhishek Banerjee's nomination letter had fake signatures.



Expelled MLA Ritabrata Banerjee and others filed a complaint, leading to an FIR. On June 3, 58 of TMC's 80 MLAs supported Ritabrata as Leader of the Opposition.

The Assembly Speaker accepted this, letting the rebels set up a parallel group. They said they were still loyal to Mamata but opposed 'family rule.'

The rift has now reached Parliament. A group of 19-20 TMC Lok Sabha MPs, led by Kakoli Ghosh Dastidar, says it represents the majority of the party's parliamentary wing.

They have written to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla seeking recognition as a separate group, separate seating, and the right to support the BJP-led NDA from outside without formally merging. Prominent names associated with the rebel camp include Satabdi Roy, Saayoni Ghosh, Yusuf Pathan and others.

The rebels argue that they have crossed the two-thirds threshold needed to avoid immediate disqualification. Under Bandyopadhyay's move is a big setback for the TMC leadership.

As a longtime ally of Mamata, he lends weight to claims that dissent is widespread. However, party loyalists have rejected talk of a split. Leaders like Kalyan Banerjee have accused the rebels of being 'bought' by the BJP and have threatened action under the anti-defection law.

They insist the party is still united under Mamata Banerjee and say the rebels' numbers are exaggerated or based on fake support. The next few days will be crucial.

The Speaker's decision on June 15 could make the parliamentary split official. More high-profile exits could further weaken TMC.

With by-polls expected soon and rebels calling themselves the 'real TMC' and saying they are open to working with the NDA, Mamata Banerjee is facing one of the toughest challenges of her career.

Swift political developments with the TMC have drawn attention in Kolkata and Delhi, with all eyes now on whether Sudip Bandyopadhyay's visit to Delhi marks the beginning.

NDA Govt working towards youth-led development: PM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Saturday said the NDA Government is strongly working towards youth-led development and one of the "defining features of the last 12 years" has been Indian youth's confidence in pursuing their aspirations.

Modi also said India's youth are making their mark across various sectors, from science and technology to manufacturing, space, semiconductors and drones.

The prime minister said it is heartening to see young Indians contributing to areas that will shape the future of the nation and the world.

"The NDA Government is one that is strongly working towards youth-led development. One of the defining features of the last 12 years has been the confidence



with which India's youth have pursued their aspirations," he said in a post on X. The Modi Government has completed 12 years in power.

The prime minister said through initiatives such as Startup India, Digital India, Skill India and Atal Innovation Mission, an ecosystem has emerged that encourages innovation, entrepreneurship and enterprise.

"Today, India is among the world's leading start-up destinations, and many of these success stories are being scripted by our Yuva Shakti and that

too from smaller towns and villages," he said. Modi further said Indian youth have also brought immense glory to the nation in the field of sports and in numerous international competitions, adding that young Indian athletes have consistently enhanced national pride.

"At the same time, a stronger sporting ecosystem, better infrastructure and greater support for athletes are creating new opportunities for young talent and encouraging them to pursue sports," he said.

Cities key to realising developed India vision by 2047: PK Mishra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New Delhi

Indian cities must be economically productive, environmentally sustainable, socially inclusive, technologically advanced and institutionally resilient to realise the vision of a developed nation by 2047, PK Mishra, Principal Secretary to Prime Minister Narendra Modi, said on Saturday.

Addressing the golden jubilee celebrations of the National Institute of Urban Affairs (NIUA), Mishra said urban development must be at the core of India's transfor-



mation as the country moves towards becoming a developed nation.

"The aspiration of Viksit Bharat is not only to build a larger economy but to build a nation that is more prepared, more inclusive, and more capable of navigating uncertainties with confidence.

"India's development pathway must therefore move beyond resilience towards building adaptive and anti-fragile systems that not only withstand disruptions, but also become stronger through change in the midst of uncertainty," Mishra said.

He also said that as cities remain at the forefront of climate-related stresses, future urban development must focus on proactive planning, nature-based solutions, green infrastructure and sustainable urban systems to build resilient, inclusive and climate-sensitive cities.

India successfully tests indigenous multi-layered BMD system

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New delhi

India has successfully demonstrated its indigenous Multi-layered Ballistic Missile Defence (BMD) and achieved a major milestone by engaging the incoming targets. The systems are designed and developed with latest technologies to address the emerging missile threats emanating from distances ranging from 2,000 km to 5,000 km.

With the latest three consecutive tests on June 10 and 11, it India has entered the elite group of nations having BMD capability to engage up to long range Ballistic Missiles including Intermediate Range Ballistic Missile (IRBM).

The other countries have this niched capability include the US, UK, China, France and Russia.

The maiden flight-test of the Naval Anti-Ship Missile-Medium Range (NASM-MR), meanwhile, was also carried out successfully, the defence ministry said here on Saturday.

Giving details, it said the Defence Research and Development Organisation (DRDO) has successfully demonstrated multiple crucial technologies bolstering the nation's defence capabilities against different types of enemy threats.

Three consecutive flight-tests were conducted on June 10 and 11 to demonstrate multi-layered defence against long range ballistic missiles and anti-ship capability at



medium range. Defence Minister Rajnath Singh congratulated the DRDO on successfully demonstrating these crucial technologies.

"The DRDO has successfully demonstrated multiple crucial technologies bolstering the nation's defence capabilities against different types of enemy threats. Three consecutive flight-tests were successfully conducted to demonstrate multi-layered defence against long-range ballistic missiles and Anti-ship capability at medium range," he wrote on social media.

Rajnath Singh said the successful demonstration have positioned India among a select group of countries with advanced ballistic missile defence capabilities.

"These tests have put India in elite group of nations having Ballistics Missile Defence Capabilities to engage Ballistic Missiles up to ICBMs," he said.

The interceptor missiles are both exo-atmospheric and endo-atmospheric, and would soon be headed for trials as the flight tests were a success, it was learnt.

Emerging technology has altered definition of warfare: Rajnath

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

Hyderabad

Asserting that recruits to the armed forces must be mentally prepared for the evolving nature of modern conflict, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh on Saturday said major powers no longer hold an edge on the battlefield as even smaller forces can inflict significant damage using specialised tactics.

Addressing the Combined Graduation Parade (CGP) at the Air Force Academy at Dundigal near here, Singh also said emerging technologies have altered the very



Defence Minister Rajnath Singh arrives to review and address the Combined Graduation Parade (CGP) at the Air Force Academy in Dundigal, Medchal-Malkajigiri district, Telangana

definition of warfare.

"Earlier, it seemed that the big powers had a decisive edge on the battlefield. But

now, comparatively, even small powers can cause heavy losses with their small but dangerous weapons and

Congress-led Government in Himachal failed to transform opportunities into achievements: Nadda

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

Shimla

Congress-led Government in Himachal Pradesh failed to transform opportunities into achievements despite unprecedented central assistance, Union Minister for Health and Family Welfare JP Nadda said on Saturday.

Interacting with the media persons here, he said that the ruling Congress failed on both fronts of development and good governance and massive public support in the recent local body elections in the State is a clear public referendum against the Congress Government.

Taking a dig at Chief Minister Sukhvinder Singh



Union Minister JP Nadda addressing a press conference in Shimla, Himachal Pradesh on Saturday

Sukhu, Nadda said that it appears as though the office of the chief minister itself is being run as 'additional charge,' with the State's actual reins controlled

remotely from Delhi rather than from Shimla.

"Before coming to power, the Congress had raised the slogan of 'systemic change,' and today the State is gripped by an atmosphere of administrative disarray, indecision, and policy chaos", he said.

"There is hardly any other instance in the country where key positions like Chief Secretary and Director General of Police are being managed on an 'additional charge' basis," Nadda said.

Nadda, who is also the Union Chemicals and Fertilizers Minister, pointed out that serious allegations are being levelled against senior bureaucrats and officials are publicly trading accusations, yet accountability is nowhere to be found.

This situation highlights the Congress Government's administrative failure and leadership crisis, Nadda alleged. Listing support rendered to the State by the Centre, Nadda claimed Himachal Pradesh received additional assistance amounting to ₹6,537 under the Special Assistance Scheme, through the NDRF, and for externally aided projects in the 2024-25 financial year.

National Highway projects worth over ₹40,000 crore are currently underway in the State, he said, adding that a record allocation of ₹2,911 crore has been made for the railway sector, and work is progressing on four major rail projects costing ₹13,168 crore.

Nation Focus



MODI ARRIVES IN FRANCE FOR FIRST LEG OF 2-NATION VISIT

Prime Minister Narendra Modi arrived here in France on Saturday where he is scheduled to hold talks with French President Emmanuel Macron and also attend the G-7 Summit. Modi was received at the airport by France's Education Minister Edouard Geffray, Minister of Higher Education, Research and Space Philippe Baptiste, French Ambassador to India Thierry Mathou, Nice Mayor Eric Ciotti among other dignitaries.

"Landed in Nice. In addition to Nice, this France visit includes programmes in Evian and Paris. There will be bilateral and multilateral engagements, which will be aimed at improving India's friendships with key developmental partners," Modi said in a social media post after his arrival.



A vehicle of the ED is parked outside the residence of TMC MLA Madan Mitra during a raid as part of a money laundering investigation into municipality recruitment irregularities in Kolkata, West Bengal

ED RAIDS TMC MLA MADAN MITRA IN RECRUITMENT SCAM CASE

The Enforcement Directorate on Saturday raided TMC MLA Madan Mitra as part of a money laundering investigation linked to an alleged municipality recruitment scam, officials said. They said a total of seven premises linked to Mitra, a former minister in the Mamata Banerjee cabinet, are being searched. Mitra represents the Kamarhati assembly seat in West Bengal's North 24 Parganas district. It is alleged that Mitra received bribes in the form of cash and gold through middlemen in relation to the appointment of undeserving candidates for various posts to different municipalities, including Kamarhati municipality, ED officials said.

Lieutenant General Dhiraj Seth to be next Army Chief

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

New delhi

The Government on Saturday announced that Lieutenant General Dhiraj Seth, will be the next Army Chief after incumbent General Upendra Dwivedi retires on June 30. Seth is currently the Vice Chief.

The incoming Chief is an alumnus of the National Defence Academy, Khadakwasla, and was commissioned into the Armoured Corps in December 1986. Over a distinguished military career spanning nearly four decades, he has had extensive experi-

ence across the operational, strategic, capability development and institutional domains, contributing significantly to the Indian Army's combat effectiveness and long-term transformation.

The General Officer has commanded at every level in diverse operational environments. His command assignments include an Armoured Regiment in the Desert Sector, an Armoured Brigade in the Western Theatre, and a Counter-Insurgency Force in Jammu & Kashmir.

As a Lieutenant General, he commanded the Sudarshan



Lieutenant General Dhiraj Seth, Vice Chief of the Army Staff, is seen. The Government of India appoints him as the next Chief of the Army Staff with effect from June 30, 2026

Chakra Corps, one of the Indian Army's premier strike formations. He subsequently served as General Officer Commanding, Delhi Area, overseeing key national and international military engagements and ceremonial responsibilities.

On elevation to Army Commander, the officer commanded South Western Command and Southern Command, earning the rare distinction of commanding two operational Army Commands and providing strategic oversight across critical theaters for over a period of two and half years.

He has held several key staff and strategic appointments that have significantly influenced operational planning, force management and capability development.

Widely recognised for his contributions to force modernisation, the General Officer has tenanted pivotal appointments in the Strategic Planning and Capability Development verticals of the Army Headquarters, shaping its modernisation trajectory, capability roadmap and long-term force structuring initiatives. His contributions have been instrumental in aligning oper-

ational requirements with emerging technologies and future battlefield imperatives.

An accomplished military professional, Lieutenant General Dhiraj Seth has consistently excelled in professional military education, securing top positions in courses of instruction.

He is a graduate of the Higher Command Course and the National Defence College, and has also attended the prestigious Command & Staff Course in Paris, reflecting his broad strategic outlook and understanding of contemporary military affairs.





States Focus



Strength, not truth, is what world respects: Mohan Bhagwat

RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat on Saturday stressed the importance of strength, saying that if you are strong, "no one will say anything even if you seize Venezuela" - a veiled reference to the US action against the South American nation under former president Nicolas Maduro.

Bhagwat remarked while speaking at an event here as part of the RSS centenary celebrations. The RSS chief said Hindus had to become strong to protect themselves, as the world heard only those who had strength. "The world will hear you only if you are strong. It will not hear you if you are true. If you are strong, no one will object even if you tread the path of falsehood. Even if you go and seize Venezuela, nobody will say anything because you are strong. That is how the world is," he said.

(PTI)



Industry heads must work with research institutes: Jitendra Singh

There is a need for deeper collaboration among research institutions, industry and startups to accelerate the translation of scientific knowledge into market-ready solutions and national development outcomes, Union minister Jitendra Singh said on Saturday.

He said industry leaders should actively engage with research institutions and participate in shaping the country's scientific agenda. "The objective is not merely to generate knowledge but to create technologies, enterprises and solutions that contribute to employment generation, industrial competitiveness and improved quality of life," Singh said.

(PTI)

Kerala Police probes VPVV Techno for printing fake US documents in Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kochi/New Delhi

Kerala Police has registered two cases against a Nagpur-based company VPVV Techno Construction Pvt. Ltd for printing fake documents of US defence purchase agreement and US President's approvals on purchasing defence equipment from India. These fake documents were printed from a Press in Ramesh Park, East Delhi by the company promoters Venkita Venkat, Aqueel Ahamed, Police sources said.

The company VPVV Techno Constructions is facing a probe for cheating investors by showing fake US contracts. The company also published Indo-US Pacific Peace Treaty and circulated among many Indian businessmen in Delhi, Mumbai, Kerala, Karnataka and Tamil



Nadu, claiming they got a weapon manufacturing contract from United States worth more than ₹80,000 crore and collected more than ₹750 crore from many investors.

The company's other directors Hitesh Kumar, known as Doctor Sahib and Rahul Rajeev Nair, Rajan Pradeep Kumar Prabhakaran and Vinod Rama Warriar Kumar is

also in the police radar for cheating many investors by printing fake US documents. The company promoters claimed that US Government has approved them as "principal developer" of defence equipment to be manufactured from India and exported to US.

These directors have created a web of more than 15 benami companies,

mostly registered in Nagpur, said Police.

Kerala Police believes Hitesh Kumar known as 'Doctor Sahib' is the kingpin of this fake company. Police has registered another case against him for gaining anticipatory bail from Kerala High Court using fake identity. Registry is also probing on this incident, said police officers, adding that Venkita Venkat and other accused are now out on bail.

Meanwhile, cheated investors said that they will approach Kerala High Court seeking CBI probe. The fraud by the VPVV and its promoters was tipped off to Indian agencies by FBI. The FBI found that the Nagpur based company has printed "Q Clearance Bag", which is signed by US President from an East Delhi Press, along with many US documents.

Assam Cabinet halts Aadhaar issuance for those above 18 years

TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma on Saturday said the Cabinet has decided that Aadhaar cards would not be issued to those aged over 18 years to ensure illegal immigrants don't acquire the document.

In exceptional cases, the District Commissioner will have to send a proposal to the state Government seeking permission for issuing the card, he said at a press conference here after chairing a cabinet meeting. The Government will then decide whether the applicant is eligible for the card, the Chief Minister said.

Remarking that Aadhaar card issuance has reached a

saturation point in the State, Sarma said, "In some districts, it has crossed the 100 per cent mark, and we must ascertain who these people are who are taking the additional Aadhaar cards." The step is being taken to ensure that no illegal Bangladeshis get Aadhaar cards, he said.

Aadhaar cards will, however, continue to be issued to people from the Tea Tribe community, the Scheduled Tribes, the Scheduled Castes and the differently abled, as many are yet to receive the cards. "The ban will, however, be absolute from April 1, 2027, and people from these communities above the age of 18 will also stop receiving it from that date," the Chief Minister said.



Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma addressing a press conference at Lok Sewa Bhawan in Guwahati, Assam on Saturday

PTI

Aadhaar cards, however, will continue to be issued to those below the age of 18.

Sarma had earlier said the State Government would be "very strict" in issuing Aadhaar cards, and it would not be easy to get the docu-

ment in Assam. Last year, he had said the Assam Government was mulling stricter rules for the issuance of Aadhaar cards for adults as part of its efforts to curb illegal immigration from Bangladesh.

The Supreme Court had said in a ruling on May 4 that the issuance of new Aadhaar cards only to citizens up to the age of six years require legislative intervention and appropriate amendments in the existing legal framework.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joymalya Bagchi gave the ruling after hearing a public interest litigation (PIL) seeking direction to the Unique Identification Authority of India (UIDAI) to issue new

Rahul's approach does not strengthen INDIA bloc: Pinarayi Vijayan

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kozhikode (Kerala)

Left veteran Pinarayi Vijayan on Saturday criticised Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, saying his political approach does not strengthen the INDIA alliance and often ends up helping the BJP.

Responding to a question about Rahul Gandhi's reported remark at an INDIA alliance meeting that he would not hug Vijayan due to their political rivalry in Kerala, the former CM said he was not concerned about who hugs whom.

"But we all saw the photograph of Rahul Gandhi hugging Narendra Modi. My

objection is not to the act of hugging Modi itself. Rather, his remarks represent a particular political message. It reflects Rahul Gandhi's approach and how he views the INDIA alliance," Vijayan said.

The senior CPI(M) leader said the matter required detailed discussion and that he would not go into it at length now. He said the INDIA alliance had reached a particular stage today.

"It is not only us, but also leaders such as Akhilesh Yadav and Tejashwi Yadav, along with other major non-Congress parties, who raised objections during the meeting and spoke against the Congress position," he said.



He added that people could see where the DMK stands now.

"The current situation has been created by the Congress party's approach, particularly by Rahul

Gandhi's approach. The reality is that this approach does not strengthen the INDIA alliance. As I have said before, it often ends up helping the BJP. Through such actions, Rahul Gandhi is

creating a situation where he effectively becomes a facilitator of the BJP's interests," Vijayan said.

During the Assembly election campaign, both Vijayan and Gandhi had targeted each other in their speeches.

Meanwhile, CPI(M) General Secretary MA Baby said that, given the political and social realities in Kerala, it would not have been possible for Rahul Gandhi to embrace Pinarayi Vijayan.

Baby said that, as CPI(M) General Secretary, he had written to Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on the issue. Portions of the letter were also reported in the media.

"What I pointed out was that, considering the specific political circumstances in different States, it is quite natural that parties within the INDIA bloc may find themselves politically opposed to one another in certain States. The CPI(M) had contributed significantly to the formation of the INDIA bloc, and we recognised this reality from the very beginning," he said.

He said that even when parties criticise one another because of unavoidable political circumstances in particular States, certain standards of political decency and dignity must be maintained.

Pharmacy cashier shot 13 times in Chandigarh daylight murder

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

Two masked men shot dead a 45-year-old pharmacy cashier in broad daylight in the Sector 11 here on Saturday, police said.

In CCTV footage of the incident, the two men were standing near the cash counter of the chemist shop. When one of them took out a semi-automatic pistol and fired thirteen rounds at the victim, Janki Das, standing near the cash counter, from very close range.

Das was a native of Himachal Pradesh and was currently living in Dhanas here. The assailants fled from the crime spot on a motorcycle as their third accomplice was waiting outside, the police said.

A few other customers are also seen present inside the shop at the time of the incident. Notably, the main market area of Sector 11 has several chemist shops that

see heavy footfall daily, as the place where the incident took place lies adjoining PGIMER here.

An eyewitness told reporters near the crime spot that he was sitting outside the shop when suddenly he and some others outside heard the sound of shots being fired.

People shouted "catch them-catch them" as soon as the accused rushed out, but they fired in the air and escaped on the bike, the eyewitness said.

He said despite the 'police naka' (check barrier) being barely a few metres away from where the incident took place, the accused managed to escape from the spot.

After the incident, the chemists' shop in the area downed their shutters on Saturday.

Briefing reporters outside the incident site, Chandigarh Deputy Inspector General of Police, Sumer Pratap Singh said the incident took place around 2.30 pm.



Abhishek Banerjee's Kalighat residence searched by police before dawn

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ Kolkata/New Delhi

A police raid before dawn on Saturday increased political tensions in West Bengal. Police, supported by central forces, searched TMC MP Abhishek Banerjee's home for several hours. Officials said they were looking for his close aide, who is connected to an alleged financial fraud.

Officers from Salboni Police Station in Paschim Medinipur and Kolkata Police led the operation. As they searched for Banerjee's personal assistant, Sumit Roy, a confrontation broke out and lasted several hours. Mamata Banerjee arrived at the scene,

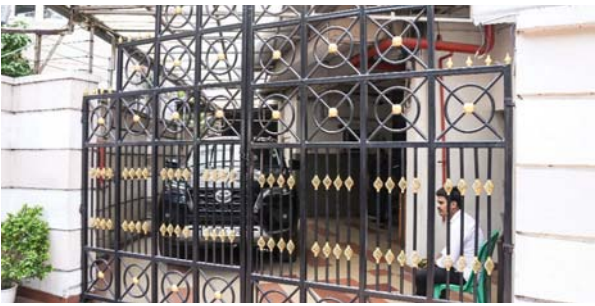
adding to the already tense political situation.

Police were looking for Roy, who is wanted in a financial fraud and land case at Salboni Police Station. Police sources said Roy's phone was last traced to Banerjee's home, prompting the urgent search. When officers arrived, security at the gate resisted, leading to a standoff. Police then broke the locks and searched the house thoroughly into the morning.

Eyewitnesses and party insiders described a tense atmosphere and raised voices during the search. Police did not find Sumit Roy or make any major seizures. Abhishek Banerjee, who was present,

told reporters, "They broke open the locks to search the house. I am not the investigating agency. The agency searched. So, question them, not me," and said he recorded the search. He stayed at the house for much of the operation, talking with police officials and asking for details about the case. His presence was searched at a political event, with a senior leader at his family home during the operation. He said the search followed procedure.

"The operation was based on specific leads, including the last known location of the accused's phone," a district officer said. Roy is accused of financial irregularities and



The residence of TMC General Secretary Abhishek Banerjee during a police operation in pursuit of his close aide in an alleged financial fraud in Kalighat, Kolkata on Saturday

PTI

possible extortion related to electoral promises, with investigators following money trails from a former TMC MLA's interrogation. TMC leaders called the raid a clear

case of political vendetta. Party sources said the raid was meant to intimidate a leader who is already facing several summonses from the CID and Enforcement

LG Manoj Sinha urges Kashmiri Pandits to set up industries, institutions in J&K

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Jammu

The Lieutenant Governor, Manoj Sinha on Saturday called upon distinguished members of the Kashmiri Pandit Community to set up industries, academic and cultural institutions in Jammu Kashmir that will become the immortal story of their heritage and provide opportunities to generations to come. He emphasised that the Kashmiri Pandit Community's contribution is needed across industry, education, arts and spirituality.

Addressing the Global Kashmiri Pandit Conclave at Srinagar, LG Manoj Sinha said the return of the Kashmiri Pandit community

reflects that after 2019, a new Jammu and Kashmir has been born.

"The strength of this new Jammu Kashmir reflects your resolve. It's hope reflects your vision. Jammu Kashmir, which witnessed the massacres, pain, and displacement of the Kashmiri Pandit community, has been transformed into a centre of reconstruction by Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

The conclave was attended by distinguished personalities of the Kashmiri Pandit community from India and abroad to celebrate the community's journey of resilience, renaissance, and return.

LG Sinha said, "I often say that history is written by those who rise

again after suffering and confronting countless challenges. Having earned global recognition, you are now returning to your roots. This dignified return is also the resolve of the Prime Minister. I salute your courage. I honour your steadfastness. I appreciate your achievements, and I express the commitment that together we will ensure a future brighter than the past and that the pride of the Kashmiri Pandit community will shine again for the welfare of all humanity."

Speaking on the occasion, the Lieutenant Governor said the Global Kashmiri Pandit Conclave celebrates the community's patience and resilience and honours their achievements and, above all, lays



the foundation for the return of the community members.

"A moment of transformation is here. Those once uprooted from

their homeland return, and this homecoming is the truest victory. The presence of business leaders, corporate heads, technology entre-

preneurs, and cultural icons sends a powerful message of confidence in the peace of Jammu Kashmir, and trust in the administrative stability under Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

Sinha said, the journey of the Kashmiri Pandit Community has been scarred by genocide, exile and struggle. The world once witnessed their wounds and now triumph. The community chose a different path. They refused to be defined by wounds and struggle. Instead, they transformed that pain into strength," the Lieutenant Governor said.

The Lieutenant Governor also observed that the world remembers the 1990s, when the Kashmiri Pandit community faced unimaginable brutality and endured mas-

sacres and, overnight, families were forced to leave everything behind and live in exile in their own country.

"Lives marked by pain and struggle gave the Kashmiri Pandit community only two choices-despair or rebuilding. They chose creation, rebuilding and selfless service and in doing so, the community made history. Carrying the weight of a massacre, they never turned away from their purpose.

Today, I am proud that the Kashmiri Pandit community is celebrated for reaching new heights of success. The world honours their talent, leadership, and contributions to humanity," the Lieutenant Governor said.



The Modi years takeaway is a compounded governance philosophy

HITESH JAIN

When Prime Minister Narendra Modi was sworn in for a third consecutive term on June 9, 2024, the ceremony attracted a usual pageantry of commentary. The opposition made comparisons to Nehru, questioned the Prime Minister's mandate, attempted to poke holes in electoral propriety and debated coalition arithmetic. What received less attention was the democratic significance of the moment. India had, for the first time in decades, returned the same leader to office three times in a row. This return had not occurred as a result of the absence of an opposition, but through the persistence of electoral preference.

This is a reality that was and remains one that is worth sitting with. India is not a country that hands out political longevity with ease. Recent elections, fought ferociously across states, are a burning example of this. India has always had a restless electorate, combine this with a now-raucous press, a federal structure that distributes power restrainedly and a democratic culture that has on several occasions punished incumbent leaders who confused being in office with life-long entitlement. What results is a battleground that very few would dare to enter, let alone repeatedly, and with the intention to conquer. For any leader to survive this environment for over a decade, that too while attempting historic, one may even say audacious, structural reforms, warrants a justification that goes beyond

just personality or effective communication.

When examined carefully, it is clear that the explanation lies in governance.

Prime Minister Modi's tenure as India's leader will historically be characterised by the fact that he led the government to choose a more challenging path, even when it faced the constant temptation of resting on electoral victories and avoiding hazards in order to safeguard political futures. The tendency to give in to such temptations would be classified as a rational political strategy, given that it does not meddle with the status quo. This is, however, also the reason why so many developing countries stay developing for so long.

Thus, what distinguished the past decade in India was the sustained willingness to attempt reforms in domains that had resisted change for generations. These reforms, while argued to be politically profitable in the short term, were timely and essential because the cost of their deferral was becoming near catastrophic. Direct benefit transfers to citizens eliminated layers of intermediaries that had been funnelling public resources for decades. The push for financial inclusion through Jan Dhan accounts brought millions of citizens into the formal economy. The construction of rural sanitation infrastructure at large addressed a public health crisis that India had long acknowledged, consciously ignored and consistently failed to resolve, given the monumen-



tal effort that would be required to effect change.

These reforms were not glamorous. They were overwhelmingly domestic and thus did not attract the kind of international attention that other economic reforms, such as liberalisation in 1991, had gained. Their core architecture, however, remains common. These reforms identified foundational failures, sought to build the institutional capacity required to address them and executed these ambitions at a scale that actually resulted in outcomes. The ability to not only foresee a vision, but importantly, to see this vision to its end, whether through delivery or coor-

ordinated execution, is a combination that is rarer in governments than most citizens realise.

Prime Minister Modi's focus on digital governance deserves particular attention, given that it represents the acceptance of the developing world. India's UPI payments infrastructure and the 'India Stack' are models that are now studied by researchers and policymakers across the globe. The Aadhaar biometric identity system, despite all the debates it generated about privacy and exclusion, created a foundational layer that made other key interventions, such as subsidy delivery, welfare targeting and tax compliance, more efficient and stream-

lined. India thus built a digital public infrastructure that most developed economies are still trying to retrofit into their systems.

Our robust digital public infrastructure is of importance also because it systematically challenged the deeply seated notion that large, complex democracies, struggling with poverty and institutional fragility, cannot execute technologically sophisticated systems at scale. Prime Minister Modi's vision for India's digital infrastructure is evidence against that assumption. Through these innovations, possible only with political will, bureaucratic coordination across ministries and sustained investment over years,

India finally benefits from a temporary, technologically adept model of governance that previous administrations shunned as being too grandiose for a country like India.

India's repositioning on the global stage is another significant reform. The country has shifted from a posture of relative passivity in international affairs to one of strategic calculation, thus balancing sparring countries and challenging international affairs with considerable diplomatic sophistication. Resultantly, India now projects a form of soft power that enhances the idea of India as a model for the Global South. Whether one agrees with the Government's foreign policy or not, it is unarguable that its approach represents a coherent strategic vision.

If there are any takeaways from the Prime Minister's tenure, it is that politics, at its best, is not a job. It is a vocation that demands unfailing commitment to people, ideas and the stubborn willingness to change lives. What separates this vocation from a mere occupation is precisely what is often overlooked in assessments of Prime Ministerial tenure. This is the importance of consistency. The Prime Minister's governing philosophy and belief that the State's job is to build systems that deliver and ensure development is one that has compounded over time. This consistency is a thread that runs across the Government's efforts, whether to reform foreign policy, ensure women's empowerment, effect infrastructure delivery, carry out education reform or allow

financial inclusion to better the livelihoods of marginalised communities.

Longevity in office is not, by itself, a virtue. India has no shortage of leaders who occupied office for extended periods and left behind only decaying institutions, suppressed oppositions and economies that worked for a chosen few. The test is thus not duration, but the transformation that any duration brings about. By that measure, the question to ask of Prime Minister Modi's time in office until now is whether India emerges from it with stronger institutional capacity, broader economic participation and a more credible position in the world than it entered with?

Any naysayer would be left with little option but to answer in the affirmative. Despite a seemingly uneven record, as is reasonably expected after a decade of complex and often deficient governance in a country of India's scale and diversity, the Government's attainment of improved infrastructure, digital inclusion and favourable global positioning, remains undisputed. For a country that spent decades watching its potential outpace its execution, these changes represent a fundamental shift that has altered India's permanent trajectory.

History will record years. What matters more is who believed in India and who strived to ensure that those years translated into a transformation story.

The writer is Managing Partner at Parinam Law Associates

Sitharaman visits New Mangalore Port; reviews infrastructure



Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman offers prayers at Sri Hosa Marigudi Temple in Udupi district, Karnataka on Saturday

PTI

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mangaluru

Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Saturday visited the New Mangalore Port and reviewed its operations, infrastructure and ongoing activities.

She is on a two-day visit to Karnataka and is scheduled to

be in Bengaluru on Sunday. "Nirmala Sitharaman visited the New Mangalore Port in Panambur, Mangaluru, and reviewed its operations, infrastructure and ongoing activities. The port plays a vital role in Karnataka's trade, logistics and coastal development," her office posted on X. She later interacted with

representatives of trade bodies, MSMEs and industry in Mangaluru, according to her office.

Member of Parliament Brijesh Chowta, Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs Chairman Vivek Chaturvedi, and CBIC member Yogendra Garg were also present on the occasion, it added.

Ex-RCom official Gautam Doshi sent to 5-day ED custody

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court on Saturday sent former Reliance Communications (RCom) senior executive Gautam Bhailal Doshi to five days of Enforcement Directorate custody in a money laundering case linked to the alleged diversion of loan funds worth over ₹40,000 crore.

Special Judge Gaurav Rao was hearing the agency's plea seeking Doshi's custody for 14 days. Doshi was produced at the judge's residence at around 8:15 am after he was arrested and taken to Delhi from Bombay on transit remand.

In its order, the court said, "Considering the submissions of ED, the nature of the allegations and to unearth the complete conspiracy as well as establish the complete fund trail, their recovery, role of other individuals involved, I deem it fit to



grant 5 days' custody of the accused to the ED."

The ED had sought 14 days' custodial interrogation of Doshi under provisions of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), contending that his custody was required to unearth the "complete conspiracy" behind the alleged diversion and layering of loan funds.

After hearing arguments from both sides, the court remanded Doshi to ED custody till June 18.

According to the ED, the investigation has revealed a fund trail involving diversion of loan funds from Reliance ADA Group entities to foreign remittances, offshore companies and foreign bank accounts.

The agency alleged that loans availed from banks were not utilised for their intended purposes and were instead invested in mutual funds and transferred to group companies.

The ED told the court that

Doshi occupied a position of "substantial authority and control" within the Reliance ADA Group and was closely associated with its financial, corporate and offshore operations.

It is alleged that Doshi functioned as one of the Group Managing Directors of the Reliance ADA Group, was a director of Reliance Telecom Ltd during the relevant period and also served as a member of its audit committee.

The probe agency further claimed that key information relating to financial operations was regularly escalated to Doshi and functioned under his supervision.

"The investigation so far has established a fund trail showing diversion of loan funds from RAAG to foreign remittances, foreign banks and offshore companies. The funds so availed from certain banks were not utilised for the intended

purpose," the court said.

Seeking his custody, the ED said Doshi needs to be confronted with seized emails, electronic records, financial documents and witness statements to identify the ultimate beneficiaries of the alleged proceeds of crime and trace domestic as well as overseas assets.

The defence opposed the ED's remand plea, arguing that no justifiable grounds existed either for Doshi's arrest or for granting custodial remand.

Senior defence counsel submitted that Doshi had cooperated throughout the investigation and had appeared before the agency after recording his statement under Section 50 of the PMLA on January 27 this year.

The defence also cited Doshi's advanced age — around 74 years — and his medical ailments while opposing the ED's demand for 14-day custody.

Ranchi airport posts ₹87.56 cr net profit in FY 2025-26 as passenger traffic hits 27 lakh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ranchi

The Birsa Munda Airport generated a net profit of ₹87.56 crore in the 2025-26 financial year, while passenger traffic reached 27 lakh during the fiscal, its director Vinod Kumar said on Saturday.

He said the airport's remarkable progress in passenger traffic, amenities, financial performance, and infrastructural development reflects the economic progress of Jharkhand. "In FY 2023-24, the airport earned a profit of ₹49.21 crore, which increased to ₹64.60 crore in FY 2024-25. It further rose to ₹87.56 crore in the financial year of 2025-26. This achievement



reflects continuous improvement in operational efficiency and revenue generation capacity," Kumar said. About passenger traffic,

he said the airport handled about 27 lakh passengers in 2025-26, a significant increase from 6.5 lakh in 2014-15. "This growth symbolises

the flourishing economic activities, trade, tourism, and improved air connectivity in Jharkhand," Kumar added. Several important devel-

opment projects have been completed at the airport in recent years, which include the construction of a new air traffic control (ATC) tower, installation of DVOR and ILS systems, apron expansion, passenger boarding bridges, expansion of the security area, and modernisation of passenger facilities.

"These projects have further strengthened the airport's capacity, safety, and operational efficiency," its director said. Kumar said the airport will organise 'Yatri Suvidha Divas' on June 15.

A series of programmes will be organised to promote passenger convenience, public awareness,

social responsibility, environmental conservation, and the enrichment of local culture on the occasion, he said.

To promote environmental conservation, a tree plantation and sapling distribution drive will also be conducted.

"To showcase Jharkhand's rich cultural heritage, folk dances, local art, and handicraft exhibitions will be organised. Painting and quiz competitions will be held for children, while blood donation camps, free health check-up camps for passengers and stakeholders, and free eye check-up camps for taxi and auto drivers will also be organised," Kumar added.

Trust only true currency for insolvency professionals: Official

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Corporate Affairs Secretary Deepti Gaur Mukherjee on Saturday emphasised the importance of the code of conduct for insolvency professionals and said their financial intellect will be useless if there is no "ethical anchor".

Trust is the only true currency, and the Code of Conduct under the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Code (IBC) is non-negotiable, she said. The secretary was speaking at the convoca-



Corporate Affairs Secretary Deepti Gaur Mukherjee

tion ceremony of 6th Batch of Post Graduate Insolvency Programme (PGIP) and a conference on a decade of insolvency reforms in the national Capital. The course is offered by

the Indian Institute of Corporate Affairs (IICA).

"All your financial intellect, your intellect and strategic thinking are completely useless if you don't have an ethical anchor," Mukherjee said.

According to her, the spirit of IBC is important, and the insolvency professionals should never misrepresent facts.

IBC provides a framework for a market-linked and time-bound resolution of stressed assets. The Code is implemented by the Corporate Affairs Ministry.

Coal Minister Reddy seeks probe into missing SCCL coal



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Coal Minister G Kishan Reddy has written to the Telangana government, flagging reports that 40 lakh tonnes of coal worth about ₹1,600 crore is missing and urging an urgent inquiry to ascertain the facts and safeguards at Singerani Collieries Company Ltd (SCCL), already strained by unpaid dues of over ₹51,500 crore.

In a letter dated June 10, 2026, to Telangana Chief Minister A Revanth Reddy, the Union Minister said that "a news item published across various newspapers relating to the disappearance of 40 lakh tonnes of coal worth ₹1600 crore, resulting in significant financial loss to the company.

"Given SCCL's current financial position due to unpaid dues exceeding ₹51,500 crore from the Telangana Government, these allegations could further hamper the financial stability of SCCL."

The Singerani Collieries Company Ltd (SCCL) is jointly owned by the Government of Telangana and the Centre on a 51:49 equity basis. Reddy said that such

allegations, if not examined with alacrity and if not addressed promptly, may undermine SCCL's financial position and impede its future growth and sustainability.

"I therefore urge that the facts in the matter may be ascertained and inquired into urgently to assess whether the alleged irregularities have an element of truth and also to see whether there are adequate safeguards mechanisms and internal controls for effective functioning of SCCL," Reddy said in the letter.

The minister said that while conducting the assessment, the State should consider deploying technology-based monitoring tools and instituting periodic reviews to detect weaknesses early and address them promptly.

He added that such measures would close systemic gaps, prevent recurrence, and bolster SCCL's efficiency, transparency and credibility.

The minister also sought the chief minister's personal intervention to ensure the smooth operation of the company and safeguard the welfare of all personnel engaged with SCCL, directly or indirectly.



The Federation of Bengal Hoteliers (FBH) warmly welcomed Dr Sankar Ghosh, Minister in Charge of Tourism, Government of West Bengal at Bagdogra Airport upon his arrival from Kolkata after assuming office. FBH President Krishnendu Choudhury and Assistant Secretary Ujjal Ghosh were present to receive the minister. During the interaction, Dr Ghosh assured the Federation of the Government's full support for hoteliers and all stakeholders of tourism service providers

PIONEER PHOTO

FROM THE

WORLD

CONGO

Clashes erupt in Kinshasa

Violent clashes erupted in Congo's capital, Kinshasa, during a rally against a proposed constitutional change that opponents say could pave the way for President Felix Tshisekedi to seek a third term. The demonstration, organised by the Opposition coalition C64, was dispersed by police with tear gas after protesters clashed with pro-Government supporters outside Parliament. Congo is plagued by multiple crises, including an Ebola outbreak and an escalation of the decades-long conflict with the Rwanda-backed M23 rebels, one of more than 100 armed groups vying for control in the eastern provinces. Tshisekedi, 62, has been in office since 2019, and is due to complete his second five-year term in 2028. He has said he would be willing to seek a third term if approved by voters in a referendum.

CHINA

US scholar held for spying

An American scholar who writes about Myanmar and Chinese foreign policy was arrested by authorities in China on suspicion of spying, China's foreign ministry said. The scholar, Min Zin, was suspected of "engaging in espionage activities that endanger China's national security," said China's Ministry of Foreign Affairs spokesman Lin Jian. It is uncommon for Beijing to arrest a U.S. citizen on national security allegations. The case comes just a month after U.S. President Donald Trump met with Chinese President Xi Jinping in Beijing as the two countries aim to reset a tumultuous relationship. A Burmese activist who knows Min Zin said he disappeared June 3 after going to Kunming, in China's Yunnan province, for a conference. The activist, who spoke on condition of anonymity out of fear of Government retribution and arrest, said Min Zin had visited China multiple times before.

China opposes US move to list top firms as military companies

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Beijing

China said on Saturday it firmly opposed the US adding several prominent Chinese businesses to its list of military companies, and that the move ignored the consensus reached during US President Donald Trump's summit with Chinese leader Xi Jinping last month. The Pentagon on Monday added several non-state-owned Chinese companies, including electric vehicle maker BYD, tech giants Alibaba and Baidu to its list that seeks to identify Chinese companies it deems to have ties to the Chinese military, preventing them from landing US defence

US-Iran peace deal may be finalised within 24 hours: Pak

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif on Saturday said a US-Iran peace deal could be finalised within the next 24 hours, raising hopes of a diplomatic breakthrough after months of conflict and negotiations. "We are closer to a peace deal than ever before. With finalisation likely expected in the next 24 hours, Pakistan is preparing for the electronic signing of the peace deal immediately after, followed by technical level talks next week," Sharif said in a post on X. He thanked the US and Iran for their "ongoing commitment" during the negotiations and expressed appreciation for support from coun-



A woman walking past an anti-American mural on the wall of the former US Embassy, now a museum in Tehran, Iran

tries in the region. "We are confident that this historic peace deal will form a strong foundation for lasting peace," he said in the post in which he tagged US President Donald Trump, Vice President

JD Vance, Secretary of State Marco Rubio, Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian and the country's Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi. There was no immediate confirmation from the White

Lebanese troops withdraw from southern base amid Israeli advance

BASSEM MROUE ■ Beirut

The Lebanese army on Saturday withdrew its troops from a base in a southern Lebanese village after Israeli troops advanced in an area nearby, a military official said. The departure from the army barracks in Kfar Tebnit came as the Israeli military issued an evacuation warning for about 20 locations, including the southern city of Nabatiyeh and nearby villages. Lebanon's State-run National News Agency reported airstrikes on Saturday on different villages near Nabatiyeh, including one that killed two people in Deir al-Zahrani. It added that Nabatiyeh was subjected to artillery shelling on Saturday. A senior Lebanese military official told The Associated Press that the Lebanese army moved its forces from the Kfar Tebnit barracks following an incursion by Israeli forces into the area. The official, who did not elaborate, spoke on condition of anonymity in line with regulations. Israeli troops were likely trying to capture the strategic Ali Taher hill on the edge of Kfar Tebnit that overlooks large parts of Nabatiyeh and some of the roads that link the city with nearby villages. Israeli troops held the Ali Taher hill for 18 years until they withdrew from Lebanon in May 2000. In late May, Israeli troops captured a nearby strategic mountain topped with the Crusader-built Beaufort Castle in the deepest incursion into the country since 2000. The push on the edge of Kfar



Tebnit came a day after Pakistan's prime minister said that the United States and Iran have agreed to wording of an agreement aimed at ending their war in the Middle East and that mediators are working with both sides to finalise a deal. Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi told Iranian State TV on Friday that both sides were working toward signing an initial agreement declaring an end to the war "on all fronts, including Lebanon." Senior Hezbollah official Hussein Haj Hassan told Al Jazeera TV that they have been informed by Iranian officials that Lebanon will be part of a future ceasefire deal between the US and Iran. Iran is Hezbollah's main backer, supplying the group with different types of weapons over the past four decades as well as billions of dollars. Attacks by Israel and Hezbollah have continued despite a ceasefire that went

into effect on April 17 and was renewed several times but remains a ceasefire in name only. Israel continues to occupy large swaths of southern Lebanon while battling Hezbollah fighters, causing civilian casualties and damage to infrastructure. Hezbollah, which is not part of the ceasefire agreement between Israel and Lebanon, has launched frequent rocket and drone attacks. The latest Israel-Hezbollah war began on March 2, when Hezbollah fired rockets into northern Israel two days after the US and Israel began their attacks on Iran. More than 3,700 people have been killed in Lebanon in the latest fighting, according to the Lebanese Health Ministry. Also, 30 Israeli soldiers and a defence contractor have been killed in or near southern Lebanon, and two civilians have been killed in northern Israel, according to Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's office. (AP)

House or Iranian authorities regarding Sharif's latest assertion on the timing of the agreement. Sharif's remarks came a day after he said the US and Iran had agreed on the text of a peace deal and that Pakistan was working closely with both sides to finalise the next steps. "Setting aside the noise, we can confirm that a final, agreed upon text of the peace deal has been reached and Pakistan is now working closely with both sides to finalise the next steps," he had said on Friday. Earlier, Araghchi had suggested progress in the negotiations, saying the "Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding has never been closer". "Pending its

finalisation, the media should refrain from entering speculation about its content. In line with our responsible and transparent approach, all details will be shared with the public in due course," Araghchi said in a social media post, without providing further details. Iranian officials have indicated that an agreement is close, but have also said the memorandum of understanding remains under review. Trump said on Friday that the United States was close to signing a deal with Iran to wind down the conflict and that a memorandum of understanding could be signed in the coming days. Meanwhile, Vance cautioned against what he

described as "a lot of fake information" circulating about a potential deal. "The Iranians are not receiving any cash, and no funds are being released for simply signing a deal or attending a meeting," Vance said in a social media post. He said on Friday economic benefits for Iran would depend on it fulfilling its obligations under the proposed arrangement. "This deal has the potential to remake the region and lead to lasting peace," Vance said, while urging caution over unconfirmed media reports and anonymous social media claims. The conflict, which began on February 28, has rattled global markets, tested regional alliances and inten-

sified diplomatic efforts to secure a negotiated settlement. Pakistan's Ministry of Foreign Affairs separately said in a post that Deputy Prime Minister Ishaq Dar spoke with Swiss Foreign Minister Ignazio Cassis on Saturday. According to Islamabad, the two ministers welcomed what they described as encouraging progress towards "an understanding between Washington and Tehran" and "expressed hope that ongoing efforts would contribute to peace and stability in the region". Pakistan has emerged as a key mediator in the US-Iran negotiations, facilitating contacts between Washington and Tehran and hosting diplomatic efforts aimed at ending the conflict. (PTI)

Trump accuses Iran of attacking Indian ships

SAGAR KULKARNI ■ Washington

US President Donald Trump accused Iran of carrying out drone attacks against Indian ships leaving the Strait of Hormuz, describing the alleged action as "totally unacceptable", while Tehran rejected the charge as "baseless". Three vessels with Indian crew came under attack off the Oman coast this week. One of them resulted in the death of three Indian seafarers on Wednesday. "Their (Iran's) totally rebuffed Drone attack last night against Indian Ships leaving the Hormuz Strait is TOTALLY UNACCEPTABLE," Trump claimed in a post on



Truth Social on Friday. In the same post, Trump also accused Iran of leaking the terms of the peace deal to the media that had nothing to do with the points under

discussion. Iran vehemently rejected Trump's allegation. "The US president's accusation against Iran regarding an Indian vessel in the Strait of Hormuz is simply base-

less," the Iranian Embassy in India said in a social media post late Friday night. "It is an attempt to divert public attention from the brutal fact that the US has attacked 3 Indian vessels in less than a week and killed 3 innocent Indian sailors. That's pathetic!" it said. Trump's remarks came after India summoned the Charge d'Affaires of the US Embassy in New Delhi to protest against US attacks on commercial ships carrying Indian nationals near the Oman coast. India has described the attacks on commercial vessels as "deeply worrisome" and it has strongly taken up the matter with the US. (PTI)

Funeral for slain Supreme leader Ayatollah Khamenei set for July

MUNIR AHMED ■ Islamabad

Iran's State-run news agency said on Saturday funeral processions for its former Supreme Leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, would be held in July, as mediators say an agreement to end the war is close. The funeral, burial, and farewell ceremonies for Khamenei would take place between July 4 and 9, Iran's state-run television, IRIB, reported. Khamenei was killed in the opening salvo of the war that Israel and the United States launched against Iran in late February. He has since been replaced by his son, Mojtaba, who is seen as even less compromising. Funeral ceremonies for Khamenei are expected to begin in Tehran, and the procession will move to Qom, a stronghold of many senior Shiite clerics, and then to Mashhad, his birthplace, where he'll be buried at the Imam Reza Shrine, considered the holiest place among



Shiite devotees. Funerals for Khamenei's daughter and son-in-law, killed in the February strike, will also be held on the same day. Khamenei dramatically remoulded the Islamic Republic since he took the reins after the death of Ayatollah Ruhollah Khomeini in 1989. Khomeini was the fiery, charismatic ideologue who led the overthrow of the Shah and installed rule by Shiite Muslim clerics tasked with spreading religious purity. (PTI)

Downed Iranian drones targeting ships in Hormuz: US Centcom

SAGAR KULKARNI ■ Washington

The US Navy said it has downed multiple one-way attack drones launched by Iran to target commercial ships transiting the Strait of Hormuz. "Iran launched multiple one-way attack drones in an attempt to strike commercial ships transiting the Strait of Hormuz," the US Central Command said in a post on X late Friday evening.



Ukrainian drone strike kills 1 in southern Russia

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Kyiv

A Ukrainian drone attack killed one person and injured three in Russia's southern Krasnodar region, local officials said Saturday, as part of Kyiv's campaign of strikes on military and energy targets deep inside Russia. Drone debris sparked a fire at a sea terminal, local Gov Veniamin Kondratyev said. He did not give details, but Russian news outlets reported that a Black Sea export terminal transporting terminal crude oil, petroleum products and liquefied gas in the village of Volna was damaged. Ukraine's General Staff did not comment on the Krasnodar strike Saturday, but said that its forces had hit an oil



preparation and pumping station overnight in Russia's Volgograd region, as well as Russian-occupied areas in Ukraine's Donetsk and Zaporizhzhia regions. The attack comes after Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said

his country's forces had struck several military and energy infrastructure sites deep inside Russia, including a military factory that he said supplied components for Russian drones and missiles. He said Wednesday that Ukrainian FP-5 Flamingo

long-range missiles had hit the facility in Cheboksary, in the Chuvashiya region, more than 900 kilometres from the front line. More than four years since the start of Russia's full-scale invasion of Ukraine, the more than 1,000-kilometre front line has remained largely static as swarms of drones hinder advances. As a result, both sides have increasingly relied on long-range strikes. Last week, Russian President Vladimir Putin vowed to strengthen air defences after Ukrainian attacks set ablaze an oil terminal in St Petersburg and also hit a nearby naval base, casting a cloud over a showcase economic forum in his hometown.

17 people killed by gunmen in northwestern Nigeria

DYEPKAZAH SHIBAYAN ■ Abuja

Gunmen killed at least 17 farmers and wounded at least 13 others as they worked in their fields in northwestern Nigeria, a local official and a resident said. The attack occurred on Friday in the town of Goron Namaye in the Maradun area of Zamfara state. No group has claimed responsibility but attacks by armed gangs have increased in recent months. "The farmers were working on their lands when the bandits suddenly attacked and killed 17 of them," Shehu Musa, a resident of Maradun, told The Associated Press on Saturday, adding that the wounded were being treated at a hospital. The attack was a result of the refusal of the Zamfara state



Government to negotiate with the gunmen, Sanusi Dosara, chairman of the Maradun local Government, said in a statement. Dosara appealed on Government forces to dismantle the Bayan-Ruwa enclave in the Maradun forest, where the gunmen were hiding. On Thursday, gunmen abducted 39 people in Magamin Diddi, a community in Maradun, while residents were meeting with the parents of a suspected bandit leader in an effort to negotiate peace and address kidnappings. An insurgency in northeastern Nigeria, coupled with ransom kidnappings, has killed thousands of people and displaced millions over the years, according to the United Nations, despite repeated promises by President Bola Tinubu to curb the crisis. (AP)

11 Indian sailors convicted; ship fined \$5.3 million for cocaine trafficking in Nigeria

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Lagos

Eleven Indian sailors have been convicted and their merchant vessel fined \$5.3 million by a court in Nigeria for cocaine trafficking. They were arrested around six months ago by operatives of the National Drug Law Enforcement Agency (NDLEA) for allegedly importing 31.5 kilograms of cocaine from the Marshall Islands into Nigeria through the Apapa seaport in Lagos, the agency said in a statement on Thursday. The master of the vessel and 10 other crew members were convicted under the NDLEA Act by Justice Joseph Chukwujekwu Aneke, it said. The vessel was ordered to pay restitution of \$5.3 million to the Nigerian Government. The three principal officers were directed to pay \$100,000 each, while the remaining



crew members were ordered to pay \$50,000 each. Each defendant was also fined 100,000 Naira. NDLEA Chairman Brig Gen Mohamed Buba Marwa (ret'd) said the conviction sent a "resounding message" to drug trafficking networks that "Nigeria is no longer a safe corridor for cocaine or any other illicit substance," the NDLEA statement read.

1 killed in Texas mass shooting; gunman dead

SEEMA HAKHU KACHRU
■ Houston

One person was killed and 10 others injured in a mass shooting in Texas, where the suspect was later found dead following a standoff with law enforcement, authorities said.

The shooting took place in the West Texas oil city of Midland. After receiving emergency calls about the active shooting, officers arrived at the scene, only to be ambushed by the shooter, who unleashed a heavy volley of fire at them, as well as at bystanders and civilian motorists.

Multiple officers were pinned down behind their patrol vehicles and had to be rescued using an armoured



vehicle. The suspect subsequently retreated and barricaded himself inside an abandoned veterinary clinic.

The Texas Department of Public Safety (DPS) officially identified the gunman as 45-year-old Victor Mata Villarreal, a fugitive actively

wanted for the attempted capital murder of a peace officer following a separate high-speed shootout with police earlier in the week.

Following the shooting, a multi-agency force implemented lockdowns and shelter-in-place orders for

neighbouring commercial properties. Eyewitnesses described a chaotic scene, reporting hearing over 40 gunshots and observing heavily armed tactical units move into position.

After an intense, multi-hour tactical standoff, law enforcement deployed remote drones and tactical robots where the suspect had barricaded himself.

Villarreal was located deceased inside the clinic in the afternoon.

No law enforcement officers were injured during the operation, police said. During an official briefing later in the day, Midland Mayor Lori Blong said that law enforcement deployed specialised robotic units and surveillance drones

inside the structure, utilising live internal footage to locate and confirm that the shooter was dead.

Late Friday, the City of Midland officially identified the sole civilian fatality as 62-year-old Edward Randall Scott, a resident of Midland and a long-time municipal employee. Ten other people suffered injuries during the shooting spree. Hospital briefings confirmed that five victims have been discharged, four are stable following surgery, and one remains in critical condition.

Reacting to the shooting, Texas Governor Greg Abbott issued an official statement extending condolences and backing local first responders. "Cecilia and I are deeply

saddened by the senseless act of violence in Midland," Abbott said.

"We are praying for the victims, their families, and the entire community.

I have been briefed on the matter and commend the swift response from the Midland Police Department, Department of Public Safety and all assisting law enforcement agencies."

According to regional authorities, the immediate active threat had ended; however, the jurisdiction was transitioning into a multi-agency forensic and investigative phase led by the Texas Rangers to determine the suspect's exact timeline and motive. (AP)

Women injured after shark attack at Sydney beach



ROD MCGUIRK ■ Melbourne

A 3.5-metre (11-foot) shark critically injured a woman off a popular Sydney beach on Saturday, and she managed to grab onto a lifeguard's paddleboard before they made it to shore.

The 35-year-old suffered serious leg and arm injuries in the attack at 11:15 am off Coogee Beach, a police statement said.

"I saw the shark come out of the water, and just the size of it shocked me," lifeguard Charlie Verco told Sydney's The Sunday Telegraph newspaper. He was in the area on his 5.5-metre (18-foot) paddleboard and was the first rescuer to the scene.

"I kept paddling towards her, and the shark took her underwater, and I was going, What do I do now?" A couple of seconds later, she popped up again," Verco said. He said

the woman was too weak to climb onto the board, but he managed to grab her by the arm, and they headed toward the beach. Other bystanders reached the pair and helped them back to shore. An off-duty hospital doctor, Ian Ferguson, was spending the morning at the beach with his young family when he said he heard screaming and saw a "big cloud of blood in the water." Ferguson and others applied tourniquets to her wounds after she reached the beach. She had a 30-centimetre (12-inch) wide bite on her thigh, the flesh had been removed, and bone was exposed, Ferguson told the newspaper. She had a similar wound to her arm, he said.

The victim was taken to a rugby field near the beach, from where she was flown by helicopter to a hospital. Police described her condition as critical. (AP)

21 terrorists killed by Pakistani forces

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Peshawar

Security forces killed 21 terrorists in a series of intelligence-based operations in the Khyber Pakhtunkhwa province in northwest Pakistan over the last three days, the military's media wing said on Saturday.

Among those killed in North Waziristan district over the last 72 hours were four ring leaders belonging to Fitna-al-Khawarij, wanted for their involvement in numerous terrorist activities, including killing of security forces' personnel and innocent civilians, the media wing said.

Fitna-al-Khawarij is a term that the state uses for the banned Tehreek-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP).

"A total of 48 khawarij have been killed since last week in the highly skilful and precise operations," a statement from the media wing said. Weapons and ammunition have also been recovered



from those killed, it said. Sanitisation operations would continue to eliminate remaining holed up terrorists in the area under the relentless Counter Terrorism campaign by security forces and law enforcement agencies.

In late May, security forces killed 11 terrorists in the Datta Khel area of North Waziristan and in June first week, after a suicide attack was foiled

in Miranshah, section 144 was imposed in that area.

According to the Pakistan Institute for Conflict and Security Studies (PICSS), after two consecutive months of improvement, Pakistan's security situation deteriorated sharply in May 2026, driven primarily by escalating terrorist violence in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Balochistan.

1 dead, 22 injured as storm collapses church tent in Virginia

HALLIE GOLDEN
■ New York

A large tent collapsed during a Virginia church's 20th anniversary celebration on Friday evening, killing one person and injuring nearly two dozen others, officials said.

Heavy rain, lightning and strong winds tore through Moneta, a small community about 200 kilometres southwest of Richmond, as the EastLake Community Church was holding an outdoor service, Shelley Basinger, a spokesperson for Bedford County, said in a statement.

The group was in the process of leaving the event tent when it collapsed, according to Abbey Johnston, acting chief of Bedford County Fire and Rescue Eleven people were taken to the hospital and 11 others had minor injuries and were treated at the scene, Basinger said.

"Initially, I'm told it was a very chaotic scene, trying to account for the individuals," Johnston told reporters.

Officials rushed to rescue everyone inside the tent behind the church and move them to safety as the strong thunderstorm raged on, she said.

Troy Keaton, the non-denominational church's senior pastor, said he had just walked up to the stage to tell the group to go to their cars when a gust of



wind picked up the tent.

"Sadly one of our dear brothers suffered a fatal injury," he said in a statement on social media. "Our hearts are broken for his precious family."

The tent had seating for 1,500 people, according to officials, but it was not immediately clear how many were inside when it collapsed.

No details were provided about the conditions of the people in the hospital.

Officials are gathering evidence as they investigate the collapse, Johnston said.

The tent had passed an inspection by the county's building inspections division three days earlier, according to Basinger Governor Abigail Spanberger said her team has been in close contact with the response crew on the ground.

"I am praying for the EastLake Community Church and all who are impacted, and we will continue to support the community during this difficult time," she said in a statement on social media. (AP)

Congressman Thanedar condemns anti-India rhetoric in Texas

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

US Congressman Shri Thanedar condemned anti-India rhetoric in Frisco, a city in Texas, asserting that immigrants have made the US stronger.

According to reports, speakers at a public hearing made references to the "Indian takeover" of Frisco and the targeting of the Indian-American community during debates on immigration and H-1B visas.

"This is a disgusting act of hate. Racism has no place in our country," Thanedar, a Congressman from Michigan, said. Recently, a video of a man tearing the Indian flag in Frisco also went viral on social media.

"I came to America in search of the American dream. I was lucky enough to get an education, build businesses, create thousands of good jobs, and now serve my community in Congress," Thanedar said in response to the anti-India rhetoric in Frisco and other parts of Texas. (PTI)



India, Nepal discusses rail connectivity

SHIRISH B PRADHAN
■ Kathmandu

India and Nepal have held discussions on cross-border railway links, including passenger train services on the Janakpur-Ayodhya section, and bilateral cooperation in the sector, an official statement said.

The discussions between the two countries were part of the 10th Project Steering Committee and the 8th Joint Working Group meetings held here on June 11 and 12, the Indian Embassy in Kathmandu said.

The standard operating procedures for the commencement of passenger train services on the



Janakpur-Ayodhya section was one of the focus points during the engagement between the two sides.

Nepal's Janakpur — believed to be the birthplace of Lord Ram's wife Sita — is 220 kms southeast of Kathmandu and about 500-odd km east of Ayodhya and devotees from both sides visit the two places regularly in

large numbers. The meetings also discussed the Final Location Survey (FLS) report of Raxaul-Kathmandu broad gauge railway link; the implementation of the Jaynagar-Bijalpura-Bardibas and Jogbani-Biratnagar broad-gauge railway lines being developed with Indian assistance, the Embassy statement said. (PTI)

US Congress honours late Indian-American tech leader Sivaramakrishnan Somasegar

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

The US Congress paid tribute to Indian-American entrepreneur late Sivaramakrishnan Somasegar for his contributions to the growth of Microsoft and the technology sector in the US.

Somasegar, popular as 'Soma' among colleagues, passed away on May 19, at the age of 59. "Soma was an incredible technologist, entrepreneur, leader, and friend in our Community," Suzan DelBene, Congresswoman from Washington state's first district, said in the US Congress



earlier this week. Born and raised in southern India, Soma came to the United States to attend Louisiana State University.

In 1989, he began his

career at Microsoft and played a critical role in Windows NT, one of the most important projects in the company's history.

"Through his remarkable management skills, dedication, and work ethic, he rose to senior leadership at Microsoft, ultimately serving as Senior Vice President until 2015," DelBene said, recalling her time with him at Microsoft. She said after leaving Microsoft, Soma devoted himself to supporting the next generation of entrepreneurs as a managing director at Madrona Venture Group, where he guided countless startups

and helped strengthen the region's innovation ecosystem. "Beyond his professional achievements, Soma was deeply committed to his community. As the proud cofounder of the Seattle Orcas, he helped bring professional cricket to the Pacific Northwest and shared his love of the sport with many in our region," she said.

"Mr Speaker, I ask my colleagues to join me in honouring and remembering Soma's remarkable legacy. His family, friends, and colleagues will cherish his kindness and wisdom for years to come," DelBene said. (PTI)

Senate Democrats block bipartisan bills to counter US President's Trump

STEVEN SLOAN
■ Washington

President Donald Trump's name remained on the facade of the Kennedy Center early Saturday despite a court-ordered deadline to remove references to Trump from the building and other aspects of the iconic performing arts venue's operations.

Scaffolding was erected around a section of the building that includes Trump's name, but shortly after midnight, the Kennedy Center asked a judge to extend the deadline until noon Eastern Time on



People waiting for President Donald Trump's name to be removed from the John F Kennedy Center for the Performing Arts in Washington AP

Saturday because of thunderstorms that had swept through the Washington area, causing a delay.

In the filing, the Kennedy Center offered assurance that

the "removal work is presently ongoing" and would "conclude in the early hours of the morning." A few hours later, workers begin covering the scaffolding with tarps. (AP)

US military strike killed leader of Tren de Aragua gang with help from Venezuela, says Trump

WILL WEISSERT ■ Washington

President Donald Trump said that a "swift and lethal kinetic" US strike has killed Hector Rusthenford Guerrero Flores, whom he called "the infamous leader" of the Tren de Aragua gang.

Tren de Aragua has been labelled by the United States as a terrorist organisation. Guerrero Flores was charged in a New York federal court with racketeering conspiracy and other crimes, including lending support to terrorists in crimes that stretched more than a decade, authorities announced in December.

Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth posted on X that the strike occurred earlier in the week on a Tren de Aragua compound in Venezuela. US Attorney Jay Clayton

said at the time that the gang is responsible for countless acts of violence, extortion and drug trafficking in North America, South America and Europe. Trump nominated Clayton to be director of national intelligence.

The US State Department had offered rewards of up to \$5 million for information leading to Guerrero Flores' arrest.

In a post on his social media site, Trump wrote, "Tren de Aragua terrorists no longer have safe haven in Venezuela or anywhere else and, under my leadership, we will find these vicious murderers and drug lords anytime, anyplace, and send them to the depths of hell where they belong." Trump's post referred to Guerrero Flores by his alias, "Nino Guerrero." Hegseth said, "The operation underscores the shared

US and Venezuelan commitment to take the fight to narco-terrorists and deny them any safe haven in our hemisphere."

Venezuela's ministry of communications did not immediately respond to a request for comment on the operation.

Trump has taken a series of extraordinary actions against the gang, including a series of strikes on small boats his administration has accused of smuggling drugs to America. At least 207 people have been killed in boat strikes by the US military in the eastern Pacific Ocean and Caribbean Sea since the Trump administration began targeting those it calls "narcoterrorists" in early September.

Trump and administration officials have consistently blamed Tren de Aragua for being at the root of the violence and illicit drug



dealing that plague some US cities. The president spent months repeating the claim — contradicted by a declassified US intelligence assessment — that Tren de Aragua had operated under Venezuelan President Nicolas Maduro's control. The US whisked Maduro out of Venezuela to face

US drug charges in January.

Tren de Aragua originated more than a decade ago at an infamously lawless prison with hardened criminals in Venezuela's central state of Aragua. The gang has expanded in recent years as millions of Venezuelans migrated to other Latin American countries or

the US in search of better living conditions. Guerrero Flores returned to the prison in Aragua for murder and other convictions in 2013, when Venezuela's crisis began as corruption, mismanagement and a drop in crude prices wrecked the oil-dependent economy. Guerrero Flores and a few other inmates saw a profitable opportunity as the Government neglected prisons.

They assumed control and administration of the prison, establishing a system that controlled the entire inmate population through force and extortion. Over time, they transformed the facility into a sort of city that included a zoo, baseball field, casino and restaurants. Guerrero Flores had his own lavish suite.

The size of the gang is unclear. Countries with large populations

of Venezuelan migrants, including Peru and Colombia, have accused the group of being behind a spree of violence in the region. Still, unlike other criminal organizations from Colombia, Central America and Brazil, Tren de Aragua has no large-scale involvement in smuggling cocaine across international borders, according to InSight Crime, a think tank that tracks crime across Latin America.

In Venezuela, gang leaders have long been known to participate in various illegal activities.

Trump campaigned for a second term promising to crack down on immigration and crime. While polls show his favorability ratings have sagged on his handling of the economy, immigration remains Trump's strongest issue, according to the AP-NORC Center for Public Affairs Research. (AP)



BRIEFLY

England left with solitary football after training equipment theft



The England football team was dealt a telling blow after almost all of its training equipment, including players' boots and manager Thomas Tuchel's tactical gear, was reportedly stolen ahead of its World Cup opener against Croatia. "The Football Association (FA) is trying to ascertain what was stolen, with balls and boots among the items feared to have been taken, after vehicles transferring equipment to their Swope Soccer Village base in Kansas City were broken into," the BBC reported. The report also stated that police officers, who are in touch with the FA, are investigating the matter. According to information received, two arrests have been made in connection with the incident. "We are investigating a possible theft of equipment from a team vehicle that arrived in Kansas City with items missing this evening. The investigation is ongoing," a spokesman for Kansas Police was quoted as saying by the website.

(PTI)

Christie extends Bournemouth contract by three years



Scotland midfielder Ryan Christie is staying with Premier League club Bournemouth. The 31-year-old Christie signed a three-year contract extension through the 2028-29 season, Bournemouth announced Saturday ahead of Scotland's opening game in the World Cup. "Ryan has made a hugely important contribution to the football club since arriving here and we're delighted he has signed a new contract," said Tiago Pinto, the club's head of soccer operations. "He is a key part of the leadership group in the dressing room and has consistently shown his value to the team through his performances, experience and commitment." Christie has made 177 appearances across all competitions for Bournemouth, scoring 10 goals and setting up 17 more since joining from Celtic in August 2021. Last season, Christie made 26 Premier League appearances, scoring against both Crystal Palace and Manchester United, to help Bournemouth finish sixth - its best-ever finish and enough for its first qualification for European competition. "With the World Cup coming up, it felt like the perfect time to sign before heading away for that, and now I can fully focus on the future," Christie said in the team's announcement. Scotland, back in the World Cup for the first time in 28 years, faces Haiti on Saturday night in Massachusetts.

(AP)

Sindhu's title wait prolongs with semifinal loss in Australia Open

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Sydney

Double Olympic medallist PV Sindhu's wait for a BWF title continued as she bowed out in the semifinals of the Australian Badminton Open after a straight-game defeat to top seed Akane Yamaguchi of Japan, here on Saturday. The former world No. 1, who got a third seed here, put up a spirited fight in the opening game and even held a game point before going down 20-22, 12-21 to the world No. 3 Japanese in a 43-minute contest.

With Sindhu's exit, India's campaign in the tourna-



ment also came to an end in the BWF World Tour Super 500 tournament.

Sindhu matched Yamaguchi shot for shot in a closely-fought first game.

Both players enjoyed runs of six consecutive points each, but the Indian failed to convert her game point as Yamaguchi held her nerve to

take the opener.

The momentum shifted decisively in the second game. Yamaguchi raced ahead with an eight-point burst to go 13-6 up and maintained solid control throughout to seal the match without any fuss. The Japanese will now take on Thailand's Pornpawee Chochuwong in the women's singles title clash.

The defeat continued Sindhu's recent struggles against Yamaguchi.

Although the Indian still leads their head-to-head record 15-13, she has now lost five of their last six meetings.

Brazil coach faces more pressure than nation's president: Alisson

RONALD BLUM
■ East Rutherford (USA)

Alisson Becker feels for Carlo Ancelotti, the Italian expected to bring Brazil a record sixth World Cup title.

"His position perhaps has more pressure than being the president of the country," the Selecao's top goalkeeper said. Brazil is unbeaten in 20 World Cup openers since 1934, winning 17 going into Saturday night's match against African champion Morocco. Having conquered the globe with Pele, samba soccer and canary yellow jerseys, Brazil was once the nation others emulated.

No more. Brazil hasn't won the title since 2002 and has moved past the quarter-

finals just once since, a humiliating 7-1 defeat to Germany in the 2014 semis on home soil in Belo Horizonte.

"We're here to try to change history, try to put Brazil back to where it never should have left, which is at the top," striker Vinicius Junior said Friday through an interpreter. "We are at the same level as the other major teams." Morocco became the first African nation to reach the World Cup semis, losing 2-0 to France four years ago. The Atlas Lions won their continent's title controversially in January - they lost 1-0 to Senegal but were awarded a 3-0 forfeit victory because the Lions of Teranga left the



field for 15 minutes during stoppage time in protest of a penalty kick awarded to their opponent.

Brazil is ranked sixth in the world and Morocco seventh.

"In modern football, there is no - how we say? - small-

US open its home WC with win over Paraguay

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Inglewood (USA)

Folarin Balogun scored twice in the Americans' historic three-goal first half, and the US opened its first home World Cup in 32 years with its biggest win in the tournament, a dynamic 4-1 victory over Paraguay.

Christian Pulisic had an assist in a stellar first-half playmaking performance for the Americans, who enthralled their Southern California fans with an aggressive attack while streaking to a 3-0 halftime lead — the team's largest in any World Cup game.

Gio Reyna dipped another goal in the rying moments of



second-half injury time, giving the Americans four goals in a World Cup match for the first time.

The US scored only three goals combined in its four matches at the Qatar World Cup four years ago, and it had never scored more than three in a World Cup match. But the

Americans were a team transformed while playing in new coach Mauricio Pochettino's more creative system in front of a passionate, star-studded Los Angeles crowd of 70,492.

Mauricio scored in the second half for Paraguay, but La Albirroja fell too far behind early in their first World Cup

match in 16 years. After the US went ahead on an early own-goal created by Pulisic's play-making, Balogun scored in the 31st minute and again in the fifth minute of first-half injury time.

The New York-born, London-raised striker made his World Cup debut with the first multigoal performance from a US player in the tournament since 1930. Balogun chose to represent the US three years ago instead of staying in the English system, where he likely would have struggled to make the Three Lions' roster — and the 24-year-old Monaco professional has swiftly provided the top-level striker play historically lacking on US rosters.

FOLARIN BALOGUN SCORES 2 FOR US IN WORLD CUP DEBUT

Inglewood: Folarin Balogun could have played for any one of three countries. He chose the United States, and it paid off with a splashy World Cup debut on home soil. The 24-year-old striker scored two goals as the Americans opened with a 4-1 victory over Paraguay on Friday night in front of a rabid and star-studded red, white and blue-clad sold-out crowd of 70,492 at SoFi Stadium.

"I visualised my debut in the World Cup scoring, but the reality did surpass that," Balogun said. "A very

dreamy night."With retired England captain David Beckham looking on, Balogun became the first U.S. player to score multiple goals in a World Cup game since 1930. Back then, Bert Patenaude scored all three goals in a 3-0 U.S. win over Paraguay, the first hat trick in World Cup history. "The kid's insane," teammate Christian Pulisic said. "He's lethal right now. We're really lucky to have him." Balogun was born in the New York City borough of Brooklyn to Nigerian parents. (AP)

Spain back at full strength against Cape Verde

TALES AZZONI
■ Guadalajara (Mexico)

Spain will have a full squad available for its World Cup opener against Cape Verde on Monday with forward Victor Munoz returning to training a day after Lamine Yamal and Nico Williams also were back.

Spain was hit by injuries late last season and had to adjust its preparations in the run-up to soccer's biggest tournament. Mikel Merino and Fabian Ruiz also dealt with injury setbacks before returning to the squad. One player who did not make it in time was Barcelona midfielder Fermin Lopez, who has a fractured foot. The biggest concern



for Spain had been with Yamal, the young Barcelona winger who injured his left hamstring in a Spanish league game in April.

The 18-year-old Yamal is expected to lead the team as

it tries to win its second World Cup title. Spain won soccer's greatest prize in South Africa in 2010, when Yamal was 2 years old.

Williams hurt his hamstring while playing for

Athletic Bilbao in a league match in May. Both Williams and Yamal were out for the season with their clubs as they focused on recovering in time for the World Cup.

Munoz, who returned to practice on Friday, sustained a muscle injury while playing with Osasuna in May.

Spain coach Luis de la Fuente probably won't use Munoz, Yamal and Williams from the start against Cape Verde on Monday in Atlanta.

They are more likely to be fully fit for Spain's second game against Saudi Arabia on June 21, also in Atlanta. The team's final group match will be against South American powerhouse Uruguay on June 26 in Guadalajara, Mexico. (AP)

Ronaldo wants Portugal focused on good start

TALES AZZONI
■ New York

Portugal traveled to the United States with Cristiano Ronaldo saying the team needs to focus on getting off to a good start instead of thinking ahead about contending for its first World Cup title.

The Portuguese are among the favorites at the expanded 48-team tournament and the 41-year-old Ronaldo will be playing in his sixth World Cup, the most ever alongside rival Lionel Messi of Argentina.

"It is important to get off to a good start, do well in the first and second matches and then finish first in the group," Ronaldo told reporters in Portugal before the team's departure. "Then

we go match by match, but not with the expectations of winning it all. It has to be step by step. A good start is the most important thing."

Portugal will play its opening Group K match against Congo on Wednesday in Houston. The team then faces Uzbekistan on June 23, again in Houston, and finishes the group stage against Colombia on June 27 in Miami.

Ronaldo said it will be further in the tournament, "when things get tighter and the psychological and physical fatigue" come into play, "that we will know who the real champions are."

This is Portugal's ninth World Cup appearance. The team finished third in 1966 and fourth in 2006 - when Ronaldo made his World



Cup debut. In 2022, Portugal reached the quarterfinals but was upset by Morocco 1-0. Ronaldo, who won the European Championship with Portugal in 2016, said the team's preparation at home was intense and productive. He said he is feeling well physically and the whole squad is ready and hopeful ahead of its quest for a first

World Cup title. "It's a very good generation of players," said Ronaldo, who now plays in Saudi Arabia after spending most of professional career with Real Madrid and Manchester United. "But there are factors that we can't control. Winning or losing, which is the most important thing, depends on many factors. (AP)

Mexico coach's youth gamble sparks victory in opening match

CARLOS RODRIGUEZ
■ Mexico City

Mexico's dire performance at the last World Cup in Qatar served as a wake-up call for this year's event. The message was clear: El Tri needed new players if it wanted a different ending on home soil in 2026.

Four years after the national soccer team's disappointing group-stage exit — Mexico's earliest World Cup finish since 1978 — coach Javier Aguirre's youthful gamble is already showing promise.

El Tri opened this year's tournament with a convincing 2-0 victory over South Africa, fielding seven players who were making their



World Cup debuts - including forward Julian Quinones, who scored the first goal in only the ninth minute of the match. "We worked hard on our mental game so the size of the stage wouldn't affect us, and we were able to get

off to a good start," said midfielder Erik Lira, another player making his debut on soccer's biggest stage.

The 26-year-old Lira played a crucial role in the victory, forcing a key turnover that directly led to Mexico's first

goal. In addition to Quinones and Lira, Aguirre handed World Cup debuts to Alvaro Fidalgo, Raul Rangel, Israel Reyes, Brian Gutierrez, Armando Gonzalez and teenage sensation Gilberto Mora. Defender Johan Vasquez, who traveled to Qatar but didn't see any playing time, also made his tournament debut.

"It's the happiest day of my life. From the moment we walked out of the tunnel, Mateo (Chavez) and I felt like crying," said Gonzalez, who came on as a second-half substitute. "You dream about it as a kid, you imagine it, you see it on TV, but to actually make your debut is incredible." Fidalgo, a Spanish-born playmaker who became a

naturalised Mexican citizen earlier this year, echoed that pride.

"I can't describe it, maybe I'll be able to in a while. I don't think I'm fully aware of it yet," Fidalgo said. "I'm just happy to be playing my first World Cup match, and to do it with Mexico is a source of pride and an honor. From here on out, we're on the upswing."

With this rejuvenated core, Mexico will target a second victory when the team faces South Korea on Thursday in Guadalajara.

The Mexicans currently lead Group A on goal difference over the South Koreans, who opened their tournament with a 2-1 win over the Czech Republic.

Shooter Manu Bhaker calls Jaspal Rana's death an irreparable loss

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Ace Indian shooter Manu Bhaker on Saturday described the death of her mentor Jaspal Rana as an "irreparable loss," as the country's shooting fraternity mourned the untimely demise of one of the sport's most revered icons.

Rana, one of India's finest pistol shooters who successfully transitioned into coaching, guided Manu to her historic twin bronze medals at the 2024 Paris Olympics. He died at the age of 49 after battling cardiac complications. Rana was serving as the



high-performance coach of the Indian pistol team at the time of his death.

His illustrious competitive career spanned more than 15 years, with the crowning

achievement coming at the 2006 Asian Games, where he produced a sensational haul of three gold medals and a silver, while also equalling the then world record.

In a brief two-word post in Hindi on social media, Manu shared three photographs of herself with Jaspal and wrote, "Apurniya Kshati" (irreparable loss).

Manu, who is currently in Dehradun attending the national camp, was also present when Rana's mortal remains were brought to the city. On Friday evening, she was seen sitting alongside his father, N.S. Rana, and other family members.

Gill leads India to seven-wicket win over Afghanistan in 1st ODI

BHARAT SHARMA
■ Dharamsala

Pacer Gurnoor Brar impressed on his international debut before captain Shubman Gill played a regal knock to set up India's seven-wicket win over Afghanistan in the rain-hit series opener on Saturday. The game marked the start of India's preparations for the ODI World Cup in 2027, and the hosts ended up ticking most boxes after persistent rain delayed the game by four and 15 minutes and cut the game to a 25-over-a-side contest. Rahmanullah Gurbaz made a high-quality 102 off just 51 balls while debutants Brar and Harsh Dubey took three

wickets each as India bowled out Afghanistan for 194 after opting to field. Gill (84 not out off 66) carried his splendid form across three formats to help India ease to the target in 22.5 overs. KL Rahul (39 not out off 19) also played his part well considering the situation with his cameo, including a classy six over extra cover off Zia Ur Rahman. Gill's opening partner Rohit Sharma (16 off 16) was run out after Gill turned down his call for a risky single in the sixth over of the run chase. With his form and fitness in focus, Rohit was not at his best, but he did come up with a drive on the up and six off his trademark pull shot.



India's captain Shubman Gill, right, greets Afghanistan's Ibrahim Zadran after winning an ODI cricket match between India and Afghanistan in Dharamshala, Himachal Pradesh

Ishan Kishan (34 off 22) looked good in his ODI comeback at number three before being outdone by a Rashid Khan googly. Gill got the majority of his majestic boundaries against the spin trio of Rashid Khan, Mohammed Nabi and AM Ghazanfar after beginning with a soothing cover drive off pacer Zia Ur Rahman. Gill also took his Gujarat Titans teammate Rashid Khan to the cleaners, with six overs mid-wicket standing out. Not much time was lost once the skies cleared up, thanks to the recently installed subair drainage system here. Gurbaz, a proven performer in T20 cricket, came out to bat

in the shortened game with a clear mindset, something he attributed to rival coach Gautam Gambhir's tips after the one-off Test in Mullanpur. For the record, Gurbaz was an important member of the KKR side that won IPL in 2024. The ball was doing a bit in the air early on, but Gurbaz went on the offensive from the word go, cutting Arshdeep for a four before stepping out to dispatch the left-arm pacer down the ground for a maximum. The 6 feet 5 inch tall Brar (3/27 in 4.5 overs), who had been a net bowler with the Indian team for a long time prior to getting his ODI cap from captain Shubman Gill on Saturday, consistently

clocked 145kmph plus in his first over and got the ball to shape away. His first couple of balls swung away from a full length before pulled his length back to induce an error from opener Ibrahim Zadran who mistimed his aerial hit to be caught at mid-off, giving the Punjab fast bowler instant success in international cricket. Afghanistan were reduced to 16 for two when Arshdeep had Sediquallah Atal trapped in front off a ball that did not do much. It became 26 for three when Rahmat Shah mistimed his pull off Arshdeep to be caught by another debutant Harsh Dubey running back-wards from his mid-wicket position. (PTI)

Pakistan skipper Fatima Sana survives injury scare



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Birmingham

Pakistan captain Fatima Sana had an injury scare during the team's practice session on Saturday afternoon ahead of their Women's T20 World Cup opening game against arch-rivals India. Fatima was hit on her right shin when a low bowler's back-drive from opener Ayesha Zafar hit her flush on the knee. She was in considerable pain and hobbled out of the ground with support from physio and fellow players. However to Pakistan team's relief, Fatima confirmed at the pre-match press conference that the hit wasn't a serious one and she is available for Sunday's game. "It was just a normal shot from Ayesha and I was hit below knee. But I think it is good now," Fatima told medi-apersons. Fatima though did not come back for the remainder of the session and the Pakistan team management was tight-lipped over her injury status.

BCCI not to intervene over foreign player availability in IPL

BHARAT SHARMA
■ Dharamsala

The BCCI has no plans to act as a bridge between overseas players and their respective teams over their availability for the IPL despite concerns being raised by franchises in the recently concluded edition. The BCCI has a ban in place for foreign recruits who pull out of the tournament after being bought in the auction but player availability over the two-month long IPL still remains an issue. The likes of Josh Hazlewood, Pat Cummins and Mitchell Starc were not available for the first half of the tournament due to niggles. Delhi Capitals were adversely impacted by Starc's

absence in the first half. After their play-offs campaign, Rajasthan Royals head coach Kumar Sangakkara had expressed his frustration over Sam Curran playing the T20 back home in the UK after ruling himself out of the IPL due to an injury. Punjab Kings co-owner Mohit Burman had said that BCCI and other boards need to align better on availability of foreign recruits. "We were told that Sam Curran had a season-ending injury, but I think I saw him playing for Surrey for two or three games now. So that was disappointing," Sangakkara had said. However, BCCI feels the contentious issue needs to be sorted between the player and his franchise as



"they are the custodians of the players." The Board also thinks the two-year ban in place for last minute withdrawal is a strong enough deterrent and the players are free to make their individual choice in consultation with the franchise. To put things in perspective, Archer made himself available for the entire tournament despite the ECB wanting to manage his workload, PTI has learned. No need for massive hike in auction purse. The current auction stands at Rs 125 crore but the players' contracts still can't compare to the ones in European football or NFL. **Post 2027, starting early in March best option** The BCCI plans to increase the number of games from 74 to 94 from the 2028 season onwards and that would require a bigger window. (PTI)

Women's T20 WC: India eye strong start against Pakistan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Birmingham

A well-balanced India will need openers Smriti Mandhana and Shafali Verma to fire from all cylinders against a tricky Pakistan to make a bright beginning to their campaign in the ICC Women's T20 World Cup on Sunday. Led by Harmanpreet Kaur, India are looking to add a second global title to their showcase after winning the 50-over version last year, and the head-to-head stats heavily favours them against cross-border rivals. India enjoy an overwhelming 13-3 lead in the shortest format, and, in fact, their previous meeting was in 2024 T20 World Cup in



Dubai, which India won by six wickets. From that day, India have grown into a more consistent and robust white ball unit, which is reflected in their ODI World Cup victory, and almost the same squad will lead India's quest for a T20 crown. India have been in reasonable form too in the run-up to the event. They have beaten Australia (2-1) and England (3-2) away from home, while drubbing Sri Lanka (5-0) at home,

underlining their all-weather abilities. However, they also received timely wake-up calls during their defeats to South Africa (4-1) and England (2-1) in away series. **Runs from openers mandatory** It revealed the need for India to have a stronger opening alliance between vice-captain Mandhana and her partner Shafali. After an 82 against the Aussies at Adelaide in February, Mandhana's next six outings produced 13, 12, 37, 0, 32 and 8. Shafali offers a similar story. After her 64 against South Africa at Johannesburg, the right-hander could only make 9, 4, 2, 22 and 11 in the next five

innings. India will require them in full flow against a Pakistan attack led by their effervescent skipper Fatima Sana. Sana has been in brilliant form of late as she averages over 50 with the bat and less than 25 with the ball in the last year or so. The 24-year-old had blasted the fastest fifty in the Women's T20Is off just 15 balls against Zimbabwe recently in Karachi, and she is certain to give some worries to the Indian bowling unit which does not have injured Amanjot Kaur and Kashvee Gautam. But Harmanpreet has returned to form with a couple of fifties against South Africa and England, which will be a big boost to the middle-order.

England crush Sri Lanka in Women's T20 World Cup

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Birmingham

England launched its home Women's Twenty20 World Cup in style by crushing Sri Lanka by 87 runs at Edgbaston. After making the highest total in tournament history — 219-1 — with 105 not out by opener Danni Wyatt-Hodge, England dismissed Sri Lanka for 132 on Friday. Left-arm pacer Freya Kemp took a career-best 4-21 including three wickets in one over that reduced Sri Lanka to 92-8. But it was England's record-setting batting that shone on a sunny evening in



front of 14,865 fans. Wyatt-Hodge and Amy Jones, who was pushed up the order to open, combined for 100 inside 10 overs. Jones was dropped on 12

ODI World Cup win showed India can cross the line: Muzumdar

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Birmingham

India's long-awaited ODI World Cup triumph last year has reinforced the belief that the team can finally get over the line in a global tournament, said head coach Anol Muzumdar as Harmanpreet Kaur and Co begin its quest for a maiden Women's T20 World Cup title. India ended years of heart-break by lifting the 50-over World Cup at home last year, having previously finished runners-up in the 2005 and 2017 ODI editions and the 2020 Women's T20 World Cup. Muzumdar said the historic triumph has instilled confidence within the squad ahead of its campaign opener



against Pakistan on Sunday. "It's a completely different format, isn't it? I mean, yes, we won the World Cup but that was in the ODIs, this is a

brand new format. So, I guess we are really looking forward for it," Muzumdar said when asked if there is extra pressure on the team. "One thing I can assure you that we would take a lot from that World Cup getting into this tournament because we know for a fact that we will cross the line." The Indian team has spent more than three weeks in the UK, including a three-match T20I series against England, and Muzumdar feels the players have adapted well to the conditions. "As far as acclimatisation is concerned, we've had three weeks over here now. We came on 23rd of May and we've got used to it now." Muzumdar also hailed Yastika Bhatia's return after the wicketkeeper-batter missed last year's ODI World Cup because of a serious knee injury suffered during the team's preparatory camp

in Visakhapatnam. "I think it was very unfortunate that Yastika missed out on the previous World Cup. It was just on the last day, last minute, probably the last over that was bowled in that camp." The left-hander has made a successful return to the T20I setup after more than two years away and has impressed at number 3, providing India with a valuable left-handed option in the middle order. "It was really unfortunate that in the last minute she had to miss out. It was a huge injury and the way she has come back, the way she has fought her way back in this team, it just tells you a little bit of an insight of how this team reacts to challenges.

The day you're not allowed to celebrate winning a Test is dark day: Swann

ANKIT SHRESTHA
■ Dharamsala

Former England spinner Graeme Swann has questioned ECB's imposition of midnight curfew on players, and termed Ben Stokes a victim of the culture more interested in policing than celebrating an achievement. Skipper Stokes landed in controversy after footage emerged from the post Lord's Test victory celebrations at a nightclub, where he and teammate Gus Atkinson were caught in a melee involving Saracens academy rugby player Totoa Auvaa. Swann, however, believes the focus has been misplaced, immediately after England outsmarted New

Zealand by 115 runs. "My thoughts are very mixed on this. The fact that there's a curfew put in place is... I'm a former player. You will never, ever convince me that a curfew is a good thing. It's ridiculous that they even did that in the first place," Swann told PTI. The former off-spinner said enforcement of curfew was done without taking the dressing-room realities into account. "I understand why they did it, because they're trying to paint a good picture to other people, to a PR side of it. That doesn't work. I think they'll learn a lesson, the ECB, from that, that we shouldn't have done that at all," he said. According to Swann, the ECB would have



been better served discussing team culture rather than imposing such blanket restrictions. "We should have come out, sat down and actually talked about what we're going to do as a culture and make sure we're moving forward. "But just to put a midnight curfew after winning a Test match, the day you're not allowed to celebrate winning a Test match for your country is a dark day," he said. Swann made it clear that

the issue lies with the rule rather than the player. "I don't think Ben Stokes has done anything wrong here, other than go against a rule that shouldn't have been implemented in the first place." While criticism of Stokes has centred on his responsibilities as captain, Swann was reluctant to pass judgement on the cascading events. "I don't know the story, what happened. No one knows the story. So, I'm not even going to comment on that." Instead, he returned to what he sees as the more fundamental issue. "Like I say, he celebrated winning the Test match. I have no issue with that whatsoever. I do have a massive issue with the team curfew

at midnight after winning a Test." The 47-year-old believes that players should be treated as adults and trusted to exercise common sense. "Before a Test, fine. You shouldn't drink before or during a game. As a professional athlete, you shouldn't be doing that. But that doesn't need writing down on a piece of paper for me." Swann also expressed concern over the growing culture of surveillance around professional athletes, questioning the motivations of those who filmed and circulated footage of England players. "Think of it from another angle. Think of who recorded that and think of who sent it to a newspaper trying to make money." (PTI)

Gwalior Shernis enter MPL T20 final

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Indore

Spinner Unnati Bagore's impressive six-wicket powered Gwalior Shernis into the final of the women's competition of the Madhya Pradesh League (MPL) T20 Scindia Cup 2026 after a dominant eight-wicket win over Bundelkhand Bulls. Bowling first, Bagora, who was playing just her second match of the tournament, produced a sensational spell in the all-important Eliminator, dismantling the Bundelkhand Bulls batting line-up. She claimed a remarkable six-wicket haul to

restrict the Bulls to just 93/9 in their 20 overs. Bundelkhand Bulls made a steady start as Yashashwini Bohare and Muskan Biswas added 37 runs for the opening wicket. Yashashwini was the first to depart after scoring 15 off 23 deliveries, while Muskan followed soon after with a patient 28 off 35 balls. However, the game turned dramatically once Bagora was introduced into the attack. The spinner completely shifted the momentum in favour of the Shernis, striking at regular intervals and triggering a collapse that left the Bulls reeling at 92/8.



Crochet sheds its past

Crochet feels like a living heirloom. Once a quiet domestic ritual, this handmade craft now boldly commands modern runways and bustling markets

SAKSHI PRIYA

Is crochet still in vogue? It is a question that sounds almost absurd when you picture the steady click of metal hooks defining the lazy afternoons of our childhoods. We all share memories of watching our nanis or mothers loop brightly colored yarn into patterns, often dismissing it as a quiet domestic routine. But look where we are now. That exact old school habit has somehow landed right in the middle of high fashion. We are way past those chunky, overly bright festival looks from the seventies. This new wave of the craft is wonderfully clean and surprisingly sharp, bringing a subtle, unforged elegance to daily outfits. Anyone watching those stunning woven designs dominate Balmain's Spring Summer 2026 runway can immediately see exactly how far

the aesthetic has evolved. The intricate threadwork proved a cultural shift where luxury is no longer about factory perfected monotony. It is an active craving for the raw, irregular touch of human hands. You see this exact same change happening right here on the crowded streets of New Delhi. It is popping up all over Janpath market, Dilli Haat, sitting perfectly inside the boutique shops of Shahpur Jat, and taking over practically every online store you scroll through. Inside shop 80B at Janpath Market, Siddharth Saini handles these threads with a grounded reality. He notes that the pieces filling his shop begin simply as raw, natural raffia. Artisans crochet this fiber entirely by hand, slowly working the material into the structured totes, everyday slings, and delicate clutches on display. "Crochet is different, crochet is hand," Saini says about pieces that take his sources a day or two to complete. He has sustained this business for eight years, leaning on a loyal clientele. To hear him speak is to understand the fragile survival of artistic communities. We routinely witness the forced silence of traditional masters, leaving brilliant

creators with zero stage left to stand on. But Saini's steady sales reveal a deeper truth. People are exhausted by the soullessly uniform. They want a tangible piece of the maker. That craving crosses over into our homes, where woven throws soften modern architecture. But the most fascinating corner of this revival lives on our screens. Social media artists everywhere are sculpting botanical arrangements from yarn, turning a traditional craft into a digital economy. "People are buying them in bulk for Valentine's Day and birthdays now," notes one creator online. Buyers want the gesture of a flower, but hate watching a costly bouquet wither into trash. This stays. It introduces a beautiful paradox into modern romance. Is the fragile life of a real rose a profound statement of love, or does the hand spun blossom carry more emotional weight? Human affection might fade, but that yarn rose sits on a dresser for decades, untouched by time. So, we return to where we started. **Is crochet still in vogue?** Without a doubt, it is everywhere. Look around and you see it woven into everyday life. You spot it dangling as quirky key-



An outdoor rack displays stunning handmade crochet totes. The front piece highlights intricate navy and white geometric patterns, perfectly finished with long, elegant tassels that drape beautifully from the bottom hemline.

A bustling street stall displays an array of bohemian woven crafts. Intricate macrame mirrors with sweeping fringes hang alongside vividly coloured crochet dreamcatchers, highlighting local artistry.

chains on college backpacks, or in those breezy tops girls wear to Sunday cafes. It's the sturdy bags you see people carrying on their metro commute, and even those familiar woven mats sitting on our dining tables. We've basically dusted off this age-old skill, slapped a 'vintage' label on it, and completely reinvented how it fits into our world today. This craft never actually left us. It just quietly changed shape and stayed a permanent part of our culture. Crochet is doing incredibly well, holding onto the threads of our past and weaving them perfectly into the present.

YARN WONDERS



Crochet bouquet



Crochet doll



Crochet Bag Accessories



Crochet EarPods Cover



Chrochet baskets



Dharmendra: Hero of Hearts

TEAM VIVA

Music easily pulls a room full of people back in time. That is exactly what happened at Gurugram's Eternal Oasis when the opening lines of "Pal Pal Dil Ke Paas" filled the hall. It was an evening about Dharmendra. Writer-director Nidhikant Pandey painted an intimate portrait of a young boy from Punjab who fought to find his place in Bombay — a man who built his career through grit, devotion to his family, and genuine humility. A man who showed up, who loved his family, who never changed even when everything around him did. The script looked way past his handsome features and shy smile. Instead, it highlighted how hard the actor actually worked to make a name for himself, his deep love for his family, and his completely genuine nature. Singer Devanand Jha handled the music for the evening. With Adhir Das on the tabla and Jeetu Nadaan on the keyboard, Jha hit every note of those golden-era

tracks, getting the whole auditorium to sing along. Any strict theatre rules went entirely out the window when Pandey grabbed a mic to sing "Yeh Dosti." The auditorium suddenly felt like a loud, crowded living room party. Producer Sohaila Kapur even stood up from the front row to sing along, bringing a fantastic burst of unplanned joy to the stage. For Eternal Oasis founder Umesh Mathur, hosting this event felt like a perfect milestone for the center. Following packed houses in New Delhi and Canada, this staging ended with a roaring standing ovation. It proved that a true artist never fades; they live permanently inside millions of devoted fans' hearts, a reminder that the legend of Dharmendra remains a deeply personal, beating rhythm for us all.



A TIMELESS MUSICAL TRIBUTE HONORING THE LEGEND, DHARMENDRA'S ICONIC JOURNEY



Summer blooms on our balconies

Indian summers crush us. Make your balcony a cool sanctuary with heat-surviving plants

TEAM VIVA

Every year, Indian cities buckle under relentless heat. Summers here are brutal. They were never meant to strip away joy and color. Even in the fire, plants survive. Flowers bloom like crazy. Urban architecture makes it harder. Not every plant can handle trapped heat inside concrete walls. But a few will survive. They will thrive. The Snake plant is stubborn. Neglect it and it still thrives. It stores water and tolerates intense heat. The ZZ plant and Aloe Vera work well in modern apartments that turn into furnaces. If you want lush tropical height, the

Areca Palm delivers. The Money plant cascades down. It softens sharp walls and purifies the air around these concrete spaces. Then come the flowers. Mogra, that sweet Arabian jasmine, heats up humid evenings with heavy perfume and pulls you right back to childhood nights. Bright Bougainvillea pinks and bold Hibiscus faces cheer everything up and keep your balcony full of life. Watch a new leaf unfurl. Catch that scent on a hot breeze. Nature waits for nobody. It pushes through cracks

and grows wild in brick and steel. Growing these plants teaches patience. They turn a cramped grey ledge into a living space for the soul. A balcony filled with life separates surviving Indian summer from actually living through it. Urban living means you do not give up nature. Pick the right plants and compact spaces become vibrant, breathable pockets of serenity. These green sanctuaries hold memories of summers growing up.

BALCONY GARDENS COOL CONCRETE HEAT, BRING NATURE BACK, TEACH PATIENCE, AND HELP YOU LIVE THROUGH INDIAN SUMMER



When forced silence breaks out

SAKSHI PRIYA



PHOTOS: PANKAJ KUMAR

There is a quiet ache in being unseen, a feeling Aashima Mehrotra tackles head on in *Vanchana Ek Vritaant*, currently running at New Delhi's India Habitat Centre. Society often ignores its true talents, leaving gifted creators with zero stage left to stand on and forcing a silence on masters of their craft. Mehrotra channels this exact sense of cultural and personal loss, but refuses to let the narrative end in despair. Working with encaustic painting is stubbornly difficult. Heating beeswax and pigment requires intense patience, yet she handles it beautifully, sealing raw emotion into thick, tactile layers. Her central figure is a woman carrying the heavy weight of social exclusion. But rather than breaking under the pressure, this protagonist hardens into a symbol of fierce endurance. UNMAAD surrounds you in deep crimson. It is the messy, fevered feeling of desire, where ecstasy and unrest tangle together. Then you move to STEPS TOWARDS FUTURE and everything changes. There is something

Christopher Moore said about how kids see magic because they look for it, and that is what this acrylic piece does. It is stubborn about its optimism, wide eyed and real. The thematic range pushes even further. *Desires* maps out the chaotic intersection of personal ambition and societal expectations. Meanwhile, *Banaras* and *Circus 2* take you somewhere else entirely. Through the alleys of memory and imagination, she has turned everyday moments into stories that stick with you. Doing all this while working a demanding government job is serious work. Her work forces you to confront what you've been overlooking. The exhibition's on until June 15th. It works on you in a way that goes beyond the paintings themselves. There is something in here about loss and how it can open you up to something new.



Union Cabinet Minister for Culture and Tourism Gajendra Singh Shekhawat admires the artwork alongside contemporary visual artist Aashima Mehrotra during the inauguration of her solo exhibition at the Visual Art Gallery, India Habitat Centre, New Delhi



CINEMA



PHOTO: PANKAJ KUMAR

JATTA 4 RETURNS WITH AI LAUGHTER

TEAM VIVA

The laughter returned to Delhi this week, but it carried grief too. At the grand press conference for *Carry On Jatta 4*, Punjabi cinema's biggest comedy franchise, the cast spoke openly about loss, legacy, and the stubborn joy of making people laugh. Gippy Grewal, the franchise's driving force, recalled how the first film survived on friendship and grit: "When this film came to me, I really loved its script. We did not have a big budget, so I took help from my friends, formed a team, and produced the film myself." The team faced a harder test for part four: the death of Bhalla Sahab, a franchise cornerstone. "We felt it would be impossible to continue without him," Gippy said. "No one could replace his contribution." Yet they found a way — using AI to recreate a brief on-screen presence, after clearing it with Bhalla's family. Sargun Mehta, who entered the industry because of this film, called it "a proud and special moment." Binnu Dhillon promised "non-stop laughter," while Pukhraj Bhalla's debut — as Bhalla Sahab's son — added deep emotional weight. The film hits India on June 26. Comedy survives. So does memory. So here's the real question for you: when a franchise honors its past with technology and heart, does it strengthen the story or blur the line? Let the audience decide.

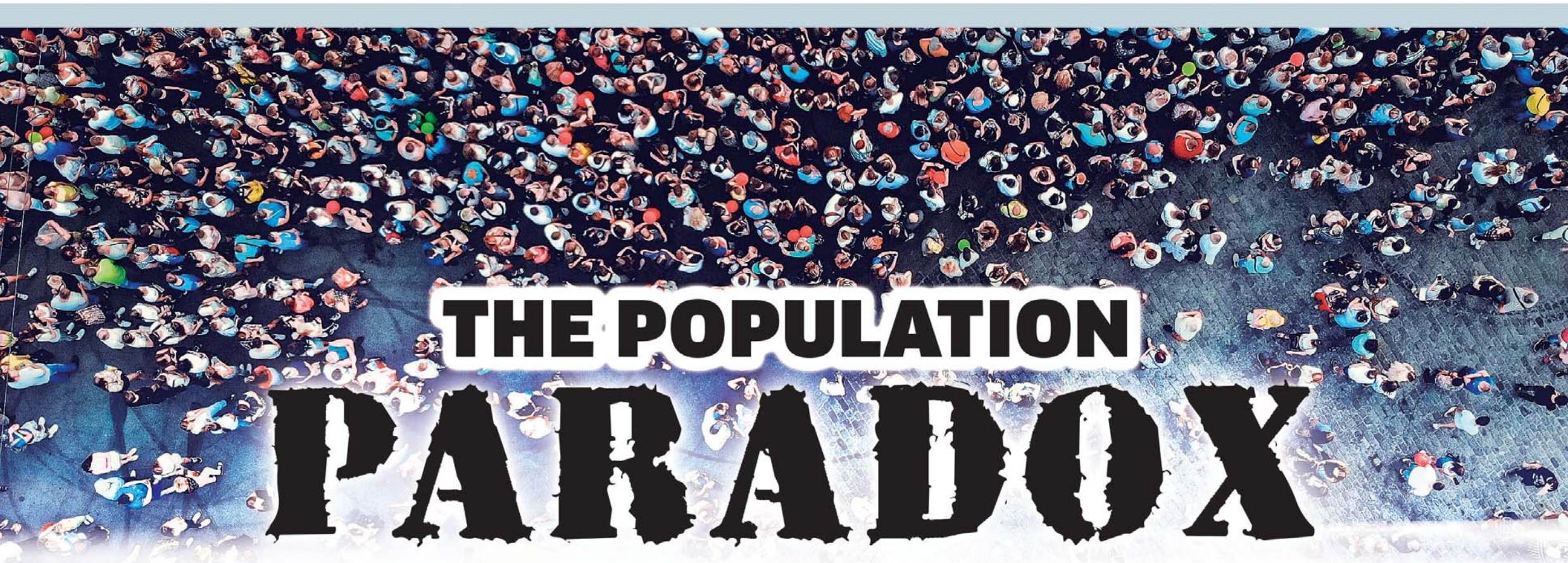
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The Pioneer AGENDA

Population, when unchecked, goes on doubling itself every 25 years or increases in a geometrical ratio
— Thomas Malthus



India faces a new demographic challenge as fertility rates fall below the replacement level of 2.1. While slower population growth may ease pressure on resources and public services, a sustained decline could bring serious economic consequences. An ageing population, a shrinking workforce and rising dependency ratios may strain healthcare and pension systems while weakening economic growth. Policymakers must now focus on boosting productivity, supporting families, increasing workforce participation and preparing for an older society

India's demographic advantage is waning rapidly



India's National Family Health Survey-6, released last week, confirmed what demographers have observed for a decade: India's total fertility rate has remained at 2.0, fractionally below the replacement level of 2.1. On the surface, this appears to be a milestone — population stabilisation, a maturing society and a demographic transition that is broadly complete. Look closer, however, and the picture is more complicated, more urgent and more consequential for policymakers than the headline suggests.

A country of two demographic realities

India is not experiencing a single demographic transition. It is experiencing several, at different speeds and in different directions, with radically different implications for planning and governance. Tamil Nadu's total fertility rate stands at 1.7 in NFHS-6 — the only southern state to record a decline from NFHS-5. Kerala remains at 1.8. Andhra Pradesh and Karnataka each record 1.8, while Telangana stands at 1.9. These states reached replacement fertility decades ago: Kerala in 1988, when the national TFR was still 4; Tamil Nadu in 1993; and Andhra Pradesh in 2004. Meanwhile, Bihar's fertility rate declined from 3.0 in NFHS-5 to 2.7 in NFHS-6. Uttar Pradesh and Jharkhand stand at 2.2. Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh are at 2.1 — at or just above replacement level — and both recorded slight increases from NFHS-5. This is not a uniform national transition. It is a southern transition that was completed two to three decades ahead of the Hindi heartland. The implications for delimitation, resource allocation, social security design and healthcare planning are profound.

The ageing South — a present challenge, not a future one

For South India, the ageing challenge is not approaching. It has arrived. Kerala's elderly population is projected to reach 20 per cent by 2026, against India's national average of 12 per cent — a demographic age structure that has taken developed countries decades to navigate, arriving in Kerala within this decade. A region built on a young, edu-

cated, mobile workforce now confronts rising elder dependency, and healthcare systems designed for infectious diseases are increasingly managing chronic conditions instead.

NFHS-6 makes this compounding visible in precise terms. Kerala has 46.7 per cent of women aged 15-49 who are overweight or obese — among the highest of any major state, alongside Andhra Pradesh at 47.9 per cent and Tamil Nadu at 44.2 per cent. These are the same states with the oldest populations. An ageing demographic carrying a high NCD burden — rising diabetes, cardiovascular disease and hypertension — requires hospitals and primary care oriented towards geriatric and chronic care, not the maternal and infectious disease architecture that served the last generation. Home healthcare is emerging as a partial response, but the trained caregiver workforce required to sustain it at scale remains inadequate. This trend will not remain confined to the South. NFHS-6 shows NCD risk factors rising nationally — rural men's high blood sugar at 19.7 per cent, and women's obesity climbing in every region. As other states develop, the question is whether their health and social security systems will be ready.

Did social investment drive fertility decline — or vice versa?

A common assumption is that states became richer and then chose smaller families. The evidence tells a more instructive story. Kerala's fertility transition is the counterintuitive case. The state achieved sub-replacement fertility in the late 1980s without the economic growth that typically accompanies it. Kerala's industrial base was weak, unemployment was high, and per capita income was modest when it crossed the replacement threshold.

What drove the transition was sustained social investment — female literacy, accessible healthcare and women's empowerment — not wealth. Social development drove fertility decline, which then reinforced economic development by expanding women's workforce participation and reducing household dependency burdens.

The broader pattern holds: where female education is higher and healthcare access more equitable, fertility rates are lower — consistently, across all communities and regions. South India did not become more developed and then have fewer children. It invested in its people — particularly its women and girls — and that investment produced development and demographic stability.

The demographic dividend: A closing window

India's demographic dividend - the economic advantage of a large working-age population relative to dependants - began around 2005. The window is projected to last until around 2055, peaking near 2041. The Economic Survey 2018-19 estimated that India needs to generate 55-60 lakh jobs every year over the next decade, at a labour force participation rate of 60%, to absorb new workforce entrants. The dividend converts into a drag if those entrants are undereducated, unhealthy or unable to find productive employment.

The window is at its widest now — investment in school quality, vocational training, primary healthcare and women's workforce participation must be the priority of this decade, not the next.

According to UNFPA's India Ageing Report 2023, India's elderly population will more than double by 2050 — from around 153 million to 347 million.

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Population growth: Contradictions & challenges



The central argument of this article is that despite declining fertility, as evidenced by NFHS data released last month, there is no threat of a declining population, at least for the next two to three decades. The real and immediate challenges of population trends come from a lack of investment in human capital and continuing differentials in fertility by region, religion, caste and class. The population of India in June 2026 is 1,475,693,542 (Worldometer, internet). This estimate is based on projections made by the UN. With this population size, India ranks first among all countries. As much as 17.79 per cent of the world's population lives in India. With a comparatively smaller share of the world's land area, India is one of the most densely populated countries in the world, with a density of 497 per km², which still seems likely to benefit from a

further reduction in the population growth rate.

It must be pointed out that this large population is still growing at the rate of 0.87 per cent per year, or more. The growth rate summarises the current status of the birth rate, death rate and net migration rate (immigrants minus emigrants). Sample Registration System data (SRS Bulletin 2026) show that in 2024 the difference between the birth rate and death rate in India was 11.9 per thousand population. Since the net rate of international migration in India (-440,456) is rather negligible, SRS figures suggest that India may still be growing at a rate of 1.19 per cent per year. For a developing country, this places a great burden on resources.

In May 2026, the fact sheet of the National Family Health Survey (NFHS-6) was released. It refers to the survey year 2023-24. The report shows that the Total Fertility Rate (TFR) of India has remained at 2.0 and, during the period between 2019-21 and 2023-24, it has not changed at all. In some instances, such as in the state of Jammu and Kashmir, it has actually increased. Demographically, a TFR of 2.0 indicates that if the present age-specific fertility rates remain unchanged, then an average woman is likely to produce 2.0 children in her lifetime. For technical reasons, a TFR of 2.1 is considered to be the "replacement level fertility", ie, a level that would lead to zero population growth only in the long run. However, due to a relatively younger age distribution, even at this level of TFR the overall population continues to grow for a generation or more, a phenomenon known as demographic momentum. Ironically, the Indian population presents a contrasting case of "below-replacement fertility" with a high rate of population growth, and both issues have to be tackled simultaneously.

The decline in fertility rates is caused by several factors. Some important ones are rising aspirations, improvements in socio-economic status, a decline in the infant mortality rate, and government policies aimed at meeting the unmet need for family planning. The latest data (NFHS-6) suggest that there has been an all-round improvement in socio-economic conditions, infant mortality has declined to a rather low level (around 24 per thousand live births), there has been an improvement in child mortality, and the government is committed to providing birth-control facilities to all those who do not wish to have an additional child or who wish to have a child after some interval. According to NFHS-6 data released last

month, 91.5 per cent of people have access to family planning methods if they want to stop childbearing or wish to have a child after some gap. Yet, even today, 20.1 per cent of women and 15.9 per cent of men marry below the legal minimum age of marriage. We need to act on this. Readers must be told that although overall fertility has moved below the replacement level, TMFR (fertility among married women) still requires intervention.

Although a population size above the optimum level leads to diseconomies of scale, the present scenario has some advantages too. Since the proportion of the elderly population (aged 60+ or 65+) has only recently begun to increase, while fertility started falling sometime in the late 1970s, from 2005 onwards we

TILL 2050 INDIA WILL HAVE DEMOGRAPHIC DIVIDEND, AFTER THAT DEMOGRAPHIC WINDOW WILL CLOSE AND INDIAN POPULATION WILL BECOME OLD

have had a situation in which the proportion of young people is declining but the proportion of older people has not yet increased significantly. In demographic language, this is called the demographic dividend. Until 2050, India will have the advantage of a demographic dividend, ie, a high proportion of people in the labour force. After that, the demographic window will close and the Indian population will become old, as is the case in most developed countries. Only then will it become stationary. Economists say that to reap the benefits of the demographic dividend, we need to invest in skill development among young people and make economic investments in creating jobs for them. Countries that lack economic and human capital but have a higher proportion of people in the labour force face a demographic nightmare, not a demographic dividend. Thus, a more pertinent question is: how do we prepare for an ageing population while still benefiting from the demographic dividend?

Moreover, there are many other challenges posed by population trends in India. There are significant differences in TFR by region, religion, caste and class. NFHS-6 data have not yet been analysed, but NFHS-5 data showed that states such as Uttar Pradesh and Bihar have much higher TFRs than southern states, especially Kerala. The political issue of people's representation is linked to the delimitation of seats based on the 2011 Census data.

CONTINUED ON >> PII

INDIA'S POPULATION CONTROL ATTEMPTS

Coercive Measures (1970s)

THE EMERGENCY: During the 1975-1977 Emergency, the Indian government implemented a forced sterilisation campaign under which over 8 million men and women underwent vasectomies and tubectomies. The backlash was severe. Since then, no federal government has attempted to repeat forced sterilisation.

Shift to Voluntary Family Planning (1990s - 2010s)

NATIONAL POPULATION POLICY (NPP) 2000: The government replaced forceful targets with the National Family Welfare Programme, which was redesigned to prioritise maternal health, child survival, and voluntary family planning choices.

MISSION PARIVAR VIKAS: Rolled out to focus on the 146 highest-fertility districts in states like Uttar Pradesh and Bihar. It widened the contraceptive basket (adding injectables and postpartum IUCDs) and compensated acceptors for loss of wages.

State-Level Incentives and Disincentives

TWO-CHILD NORMS: Several states (Rajasthan, Andhra Pradesh, and Uttar Pradesh) enacted policies barring individuals with more than two children from contesting local government elections or receiving certain state benefits.

RECENT REVERSAL: Some states are rolling back these two-child policies-such as Andhra Pradesh and Rajasthan-recognising that declining birth rates could lead to future economic and demographic challenges.

Demographic Realities & Current Focus

THE "NORTH-SOUTH" DIVIDE: States in the south (Kerala, Andhra Pradesh) have fertility rates well below replacement (around 1.4 to 1.8), causing local anxieties about an aging population. In contrast, northern states (eg, Bihar) still have slightly higher fertility due to lower female literacy.

INDIA'S JOURNEY TO BECOMING THE WORLD'S MOST POPULOUS COUNTRY

India's population has more than quadrupled since gaining Independence in 1947, growing from approximately 34 crore (340 million) people to over 147 crore (1.47 billion) in 2026. This monumental growth has reshaped the nation's economy, resources and governance, making India the world's most populous country. The growth trajectory can be divided into three distinct historical phases

Phase 1: The 'Population Explosion' (1951-1981)

HIGH FERTILITY, CRASHING MORTALITY: Independence brought massive investments in public health, sanitation, and food security through the Green Revolution.

THE SURGE: While the birth rate remained high, the death rate dropped sharply.

RAPID GROWTH: The population grew from 36.1 crore in 1951 to 68.3 crore in 1981, nearly doubling in just three decades.

THE PEAK: The decade of 1961-1971 recorded the highest decadal growth rate in India's history at 24.8 per cent.



FOR REPRESENTATIVE PURPOSES ONLY

PHASE 2: DECELERATION (1981-2011)

FLATTENING THE CURVE: Driven by rising female literacy, economic development, and robust national family welfare programmes, the annual growth rate peaked and began a steady decline.

THE BILLION MILESTONE: Despite a slowing percentage growth rate, the absolute population base was so large that the country crossed the 1 billion mark in 2001.

THE 2011 CENSUS: The population was officially recorded at 121 crore, showing a dropped decadal growth rate of 17.7 per cent.

PHASE 3: STABILISATION & REGIONAL ASYMMETRY (2011-PRESENT)

BELOW REPLACEMENT LEVEL: According to recent National Family Health Surveys (NFHS-5), India's Total Fertility Rate (TFR) has dropped to 2.0 children per woman. This sits below the standard population replacement level of 2.1.

TWO SPEEDS OF GROWTH: Clear regional divides have emerged. Southern states (like Kerala and Tamil Nadu) reached stabilisation early and are dealing with an aging demographic. Conversely, northern states (like Bihar and Uttar Pradesh) drive the current expansion due to a massive base of young adults.

THE DEMOGRAPHIC DIVIDEND: India is currently at a unique economic vantage point with a median age of approximately 29 years, meaning 68 per cent of its population is of working age.

“WE ALL SUPPORT A RULES-BASED INTERNATIONAL ORDER, RESPECT FOR SOVEREIGNTY, TERRITORIAL INTEGRITY, AND PEACEFUL RESOLUTION OF ALL ISSUES”
— NARENDRA MODI

Trump tests the soul of the Quad



KRIPA NAUTIYAL

When the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue — commonly known as the Quad — was revived in earnest in 2017, it was hailed as one of the most consequential strategic architectures of the 21st century. A coalition of four like-minded democracies — the United States, India, Japan and Australia — bound by shared values and a common concern about China's growing assertiveness in the Indo-Pacific, the Quad was meant to be the geopolitical cornerstone of a free and open maritime order. By 2021, it had been elevated to leaders' summits, producing ambitious agendas on vaccine distribution, climate, critical technologies and maritime security. The euphoria was genuine. The ambition, enormous. The question today is whether that promise has quietly been allowed to slip away.

Under President Donald Trump's second term, the Quad has not been abandoned outright, but it has been treated with a studied indifference that has done considerable damage. Since his return to the White House in 2025, Trump has refused to participate in a leaders' summit, leaving the Quad negatively impacted and degrading its geostrategic value. That single fact - the absence of the American President from the high table of the very grouping his own first term helped resurrect — speaks volumes about Washington's current strategic priorities.

A summit that never was

The most visible casualty of this neglect was the 2025 Quad Leaders' Summit. The summit was expected to take place in late 2025 with India as the host and President Trump in attendance, but ultimately did not happen, primarily due to heightened tensions between the US and India. Trump's decision not to attend appears to have had both policy and personal reasons. On the policy side, he demanded that New Delhi agree to a new US-India free trade agreement as a deliverable before his visit.

The consequences rippled far beyond a missed photo opportunity. Trump's snub was a setback not only for the Modi government but also for the wider partnership committed to a “free and open Indo-Pacific”, with the Quad now risking a loss of momentum. And as if to underscore the perverse priorities at play, Trump chose to visit Beijing rather than New Delhi, sending a message that shook the confidence of all three Quad partners simultaneously.

Tariffs as strategic wrecking balls

Perhaps no single policy has done more damage to the Quad's internal cohesion than Trump's sweeping tariff offensive against America's own allies. Trump imposed a 25 per cent tariff on Indian products, and an additional 25 per cent penalty tariff for India's purchases of Russian oil. For a partnership built on mutual respect and shared strategic purpose, these were not just trade measures — they were acts of strategic self-harm. Indian exports to the US fell by 37 per cent between May and September 2025, dropping from \$8.8 billion to \$5.5 billion over that period. A string of unexpected provocations from the White House vaporised New Delhi's trust in the United States.

Australia fared little better. Australian Trade Minister Don Farrell expressed Canberra's disappointment at Trump's imposition of a 10 per cent tariff, even though the United States has a trade surplus with Australia, calling the levy “unjustified”. Japan, meanwhile, faced a 24 per cent tariff on its exports. The irony is



galling: the United States was simultaneously demanding strategic alignment from its Quad partners while economically penalising them. Trust, once eroded, does not recover quickly.

The collateral effects were predictable. Indian Prime Minister Modi signed a long raft of new bilateral agreements with Japan, and his defence minister did likewise with Australia — suggesting that the non-US members of the Quad were quietly hedging, building resilience within the grouping independent of Washington. Modi's conspicuous bonhomie with Xi Jinping at the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation summit, described by Xi as a “Dragon-Elephant Tango”, was a pointed signal of how far Indian strategic patience had been stretched.

The China paradox

Here lies the central paradox of the Trump administration's approach to the Quad. The grouping exists primarily, albeit tacitly, as a mechanism to balance China's growing power in the Indo-Pacific. The Quad received only a single passing mention in Trump's National Security Strategy unveiled in late 2025, a marginalisation that would have been unthinkable two years ago. Beijing has noticed.

China's assessment of the Quad has evolved from viewing it as a potentially unified anti-China coalition to seeing it as a structurally uneven alignment held together primarily by concern over China rather than by deep internal unity, with Beijing increasingly doubting whether the four countries share the same long-term strategic vision or level of commitment. The redeployment of US forces and warships from the Asia Pacific to the Middle East has further deepened unease within the bloc. When Washington moved troops from Japan to the Middle East, Tokyo saw it as a removal of a direct check on Chinese power at a time when Beijing is conducting large-scale military activity in the region. The Quad's strategic logic rests on the credibility of American commitment. Every step that erodes that credibility gifts Beijing a strategic dividend.

Rubio's New Delhi visit: A lifeline or a band-aid?

It was in this context of accumulated mistrust and organisational drift that US Secretary of State Marco Rubio's recent visit to New Delhi in late May 2026 — the first visit by a sitting Secretary of State after assuming office — assumed outsized importance. The Quad Foreign Ministers' Meeting on May 26, 2026 did produce tangible outcomes, and Rubio's tone was notably constructive. He was emphatic that the Quad must evolve from what he termed a “talk shop” into a genuine “partnership of action”.

On maritime security, the most immediate strategic frontier, the announcements



SINCE HIS RETURN TO THE WHITE HOUSE IN 2025, TRUMP HAS REFUSED TO PARTICIPATE IN A LEADERS' SUMMIT, NEGATIVELY IMPACTING THE QUAD AND DEGRADING ITS GEOSTRATEGIC VALUE

were substantive. Rubio announced the launch of the Indo-Pacific Maritime Surveillance Cooperation Initiative, which will leverage each Quad country's maritime surveillance capabilities in the Indo-Pacific to enhance information sharing, and the expansion of the Indo-Pacific Maritime Domain Awareness Initiative, which provides near-real-time commercial maritime domain awareness data to countries throughout the Indo-Pacific. Rubio also confirmed that India would host the next edition of the Quad at Sea mission, a joint coast guard exercise aimed at improving maritime coordination among partner nations.

The coast guard dimension is particularly significant. India agreed to host the next iteration of the Quad-at-Sea Mission, which brings together coast guards from all four nations aboard a single vessel. This is a deliberate effort to give the Quad a non-militarised, practical face. The Indo-Pacific Maritime Surveillance Collaboration was described not as the militarisation of the Quad, but as a practical effort to share commercially available but expensive surveillance technologies with Indo-Pacific countries that currently lack access to them. Other outcomes included a Quad Critical Minerals Initiative Framework and a joint statement on Indo-Pacific energy security — all areas where practical cooperation can yield real regional dividends.

Will it be enough?

The honest answer is: not by itself. The ministerial-level meeting and the maritime initiatives are welcome, even necessary. But they cannot substitute for leadership-level political will from Washington. The lack of a leaders' summit under the second Trump administration, and lingering challenges in the relationship between the US and Indian governments, has left many observers uncer-

tain about the future of the Quad in a new era of geopolitical upheaval.

It was resurrected in 2017 precisely because the threat environment demanded it. This time around, the primary reason for potential decline would be more worrisome: Washington may no longer be a reliable strategic partner in the international system. That is a categorically different problem from the hesitancy of 2008. An alliance weakened by external pressure can be rebuilt; one hollowed out by the unreliability of its anchor power faces a more fundamental crisis of purpose. The Quad's three non-American members — India, Japan and Australia - have shown remarkable resilience, deepening bilateral ties among themselves and continuing to invest in the grouping even as Washington has been distracted. The Quad countries collectively account for about one-third of global GDP and nearly two billion people — a coalition with enormous latent potential. But potential, without the sustained political will of the world's foremost military and economic power, remains frustratingly latent.

The path forward

The Rubio visit and the New Delhi ministerial meeting have bought the Quad time. The maritime surveillance initiative is the right kind of practical, non-provocative cooperation that builds habits of interoperability and trust. The coast guard mission, in particular, signals that the Quad can operate meaningfully below the threshold of military confrontation — precisely the grey zone where China has been most active. But the Quad's partners need more. They need a leaders' summit. They need a US administration that does not treat tariffs on its own strategic partners as an acceptable instrument of coercion. They need Washington to consistently signal that its commitment to a free and open Indo-Pacific is not contingent on trade concessions or domestic political calculus.

The window is not yet closed. The four Quad nations remain united by a common vision for a free and open Indo-Pacific, underpinned by robust economic and energy systems. That vision is genuine and shared. What is missing — conspicuously, dangerously — is the American President's willingness to show up for it. Maritime surveillance initiatives and coast guard exercises matter. But in the final analysis, alliances are sustained not by technocratic deliverables alone, but by the signal they send to rivals and partners alike: that the great democracies of the Indo-Pacific stand together, at every level, and mean it.

The Quad is not yet dead. But it is being tested in ways its architects never anticipated — not by the adversaries, but by the indifference of its indispensable partner.

(The writer is a retired Additional Director General of the Indian Coast Guard)

FROM AGENDA COVER

India's demographic dividend is...

By 2046, the elderly will outnumber children under 14. One in five Indians will be over 60 by mid-century. The population aged 80 and above will grow by 279 per cent between 2022 and 2050, predominantly widowed women with significant care needs. The pension, healthcare, and long-term care infrastructure does not yet exist at adequate scale. Building it requires investment now, from a productive workforce now.

Japan's cautionary lesson

Japan offers the most instructive international reference. With nearly 30 per cent of its population aged 65 and older, Japan faces acute labour shortages across key sectors. Automation, flexible work, extended retirement ages, and immigration reform have partially compensated but not reversed the demographic drag. The IMF's assessment of Japan's experience is unambiguous: early adjustment for pensions, healthcare, and long-term care is critical. Countries that delay until demographic pressures are fully visible in daily life have already waited too long.

India has an advantage Japan did not: time. But South India's trajectory - Kerala's ageing profile, Tamil Nadu's sub-replacement fertility extending over decades — places it closer to Japan's position than national aggregate figures suggest. What

Japan experiences today, India's southern states will face within a generation.

What the evidence points toward

Several countries have experimented with financial incentives to raise birth rates. South Korea's TFR fell to 0.72 in 2023 despite decades of sustained spending — the lowest fertility rate recorded anywhere in the world. The evidence is consistent: incentives alone have not reversed structural fertility decline. The drivers of low fertility - female education, workforce participation, urbanisation, and the rising cost of child-rearing — are structural, not addressable through cash transfers at the margin. The more durable policy approach, grounded in India's history, is threefold. First, invest urgently in the quality and productivity of the working-age population India has - through public health, education, and skills - to fully realise the demographic dividend while the window remains open. Second, begin building the geriatric care, pension coverage, and chronic disease management infrastructure that South India already needs and the rest of India will require within two decades. Third, address the legitimate concerns around political representation that the fertility divergence creates through considered institutional design, ensuring states are not penalised for social progress that has benefited the nation.

The fertility debate raises important questions about India's demographic future. The answers lie in investing in the health,

education, and economic security of the people already here and in the policy architecture that converts a young, capable population into lasting national prosperity.

The writer is senior Fellow, Pahle India Foundation and Former Director, NITI Aayog

Population growth: Contradictions &...

Likewise, Muslims have the highest value of mean number of children (4.8) and Jains and Sikhs the least (2.0 and 2.5 respectively). So, the proportion of Muslims in the overall population of India is going to increase further and that of Jains and Sikhs is going to decrease. This explains why between 2001 and 2011 censuses Muslim population grew by 24.6 per cent while Jain population grew only by 5.4 per cent. There is evidence to believe that the 2027 census would not repeat the same experience. Since the modern politics world over is now based on identity, such facts will have critical implications for democratic politics.

The population does not grow at the same rate among different regions, religions, and classes. There is predictably an inverse relationship between fertility, and caste, status and class. USSR once faced the same situation (high fertility among Asian Muslims and low fertility among European Christians) and in spite of their commitment to communism, they decided to go for regionally

differentiated population policy. We need to learn from them. India requires reducing regional and social class demographic disparities in fertility and family planning practices.

Besides, India needs to manage urban sprawl and the ensuing infrastructure problems. In the beginning of the previous century only one-in-ten Indians lived in urban areas and the overall population was fluctuating. In year 2026, 37.61 per cent of the Indian population is living in urban areas. Sociologically, even the remaining rural population is subjected to high degree of “urbanism”. Consequently, the absolute population of urban areas is growing very fast and it will deteriorate the quality of urban infrastructure further.

In sum, the fear of declining population in India is only a myth. The urgent need is to reduce fertility further in those regions and sections of society where TFR continues to be high and prepare for bigger challenges such as demands to be created by ageing of population, lack of capital, fertility differentials, and urban expansion. A universal policy to incentivise fertility for the whole nation or a whole state would further aggravate the differentials and any such attempt on the part of the state must be critiqued carefully.

Arun Kumar Sharma is first professor in India to develop online courses on population and sociology and taught demography in IIT Kanpur. He is also a member of the Editorial Advisory Board of the ISS Journal Sociological Bulletin

WEEKLY MOON SIGN FORECAST | 14-20 JUNE

Steady Foundations, Meaningful Conversations and Renewed Confidence

Dr Shanker Adawal
Astrologer, Author & Researcher

This forecast is based on your Moon Sign (Janma Rashi), which often reflects day-to-day emotional and instinctive patterns more closely than general Sun-sign readings.

Weekly Overview

The week opens with the Moon in Taurus, encouraging steadiness, practical thinking and a measured pace. As the Moon moves into Gemini, conversations, movement and exchange of ideas gather momentum. Midweek brings the Moon into Cancer, increasing emotional awareness. By the weekend, Leo energy encourages confidence, visibility and self-expression.

Aries (Mesh): The week begins with attention turning toward finances, priorities or practical responsibilities that may have been pushed aside recently. A steady approach will produce better results than quick decisions. As the week progresses, conversations become more important and useful information may arrive through ordinary interactions. Midweek may bring greater emotional involvement in family or personal matters. By the weekend, confidence improves and creative energy returns.

Taurus (Vrishabh): With the Moon beginning the week in Taurus, there may be a stronger desire to move at your own pace rather than responding to outside expectations. People around you may seek your opinion or support. Midweek encourages communication, planning and movement, making it easier to resolve pending matters. As the Moon enters Cancer, attention may shift toward relationships and emotional understanding.

Gemini (Mithun): The opening days may feel quieter than expected, encouraging observation rather than immediate action. Once the Moon enters Gemini, activity naturally increases and discussions begin moving forward. This can be a useful period for meetings, learning and reconnecting with people. Midweek may bring greater emotional sensitivity than usual, particularly where family or close relationships are involved. By the weekend, clarity improves and confidence gradually returns.

Cancer (Karka): Friendships, social circles or group activities may attract attention early in the week. Some conversations could help you see a situation differently. Midweek becomes more significant as the Moon enters Cancer, increasing emotional awareness and strengthening intuition. You may find yourself paying greater attention to personal needs and long-term emotional priorities. By the weekend, communication becomes more direct and practical.

Leo (Simha): Professional matters or responsibilities may occupy your attention during the opening phase of the week. Others may look to you for guidance or direction. Midweek encourages networking, planning and broader discussions, particularly where future goals are concerned. As emotional matters gain importance later in the week, maintaining balance between work and personal life becomes necessary.

Virgo (Kanya): The week opens with a constructive tone, supporting learning, planning and practical progress. You may feel encouraged to look beyond immediate concerns and focus on longer-term objectives. Midweek brings useful exchanges and opportunities to clarify misunderstandings. Emotional matters may require more attention as the week moves forward.

Libra (Tula): Shared responsibilities, financial planning or unresolved practical matters may require attention at the beginning of the week. A calm and organised approach will help reduce pressure. Midweek supports communication and cooperation, making it easier to reach common ground with others. As emotional awareness increases later in the week, professional matters may become linked with personal expectations.

Scorpio (Vrishchik): Partnerships and one-to-one interactions may become an important theme during the opening days. Some situations may require understanding rather than immediate judgment. Midweek supports movement, communication and practical discussions that help bring greater clarity. Emotional matters may feel stronger once the Moon enters Cancer, encouraging reflection on personal priorities. By the weekend, attention shifts toward professional responsibilities, where confidence and steady effort are likely to bring positive results.

Sagittarius (Dhanu): Routine matters and daily responsibilities may shape the beginning of the week. This is a useful period for bringing structure to unfinished tasks. Midweek introduces greater movement and flexibility, making it easier to adjust plans where necessary. Emotional sensitivity may increase during the Cancer phase, particularly in matters involving trust or expectations. By the weekend, perspective broadens and enthusiasm returns. Travel, learning or future planning may attract attention.

Capricorn (Makar): The opening days support creativity, personal interests and meaningful engagement with people who share your outlook. Midweek brings a practical focus on responsibilities, organisation and communication. As the week progresses, relationships and partnerships may require greater attention, especially where expectations differ.

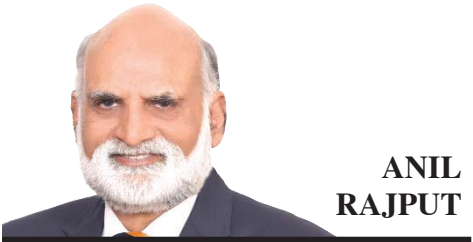
Aquarius (Kumbh): Home, family matters or personal comfort may influence decisions during the early part of the week. A steady pace will be more productive than trying to do everything at once. Midweek supports movement, communication and fresh ideas, particularly in work-related matters. As emotional awareness increases later in the week, routine responsibilities may feel heavier than expected. By the weekend, relationships and cooperation become more important. Listening carefully may help avoid unnecessary misunderstandings.

Pisces (Meen): The week begins with discussions, planning and practical movement. You may find yourself dealing with several small matters at the same time, requiring flexibility and patience. Midweek encourages useful communication and clearer thinking. As the Moon enters Cancer, creativity, intuition and emotional understanding become stronger. This can be a supportive period for personal interests and meaningful connections.

“EVERY TIME YOU EAT OR DRINK, YOU ARE
EITHER FEEDING DISEASE OR FIGHTING IT”
— HEATHER MORGAN

MAHARANA PRATAP JAYANTI

Remembering valour through the cuisine of Mewar



ANIL
RAJPUT

Maharana Pratap Jayanti is a remembrance of courage, honour, and the unbending spirit of Mewar. In the civilisational memory of Bharat, Maharana Pratap occupies a place of rare reverence because his life was shaped not by comfort or compromise, but by duty towards his land, his people, and his inherited values. He belonged to the Sisodia Rajput house of Mewar, a lineage that carried within it the ideals of sovereignty, sacrifice, restraint, and dignity. His name continues to evoke the rugged hills of the Aravallis, the soil of Haldighati, the loyalty of Chetak, the sacrifice of warriors, and the moral strength of a ruler who chose hardship over submission. His Jayanti, therefore, is more than an occasion of public tribute. It is a moment to reflect upon the ideals of self-respect, courage, and cultural pride that continue to inspire generations. These values also find reflection in the culinary traditions associated with the land of Mewar, where simple yet nourishing foods, shaped by a demanding landscape and a spirit of self-reliance, stand as reminders of the resilience and fortitude that Maharana Pratap came to embody.

Born in 1540 at Kumbhalgarh, Maharana Pratap inherited a kingdom that stood at the heart of one of the most difficult political periods in medieval Indian history. While Kumbhalgarh is not associated with one exclusive ceremonial dish, its location within the Mewar landscape allows the remembrance to be naturally connected with the sturdy grains, preserved foods, rustic breads, and nourishing preparations of the wider regional kitchen of Mewar and Rajasthan. Mewar was not merely a territory to be ruled, but a sacred responsibility to be protected. At a time when imperial expansion tested the autonomy of many kingdoms, Maharana Pratap refused to place convenience above honour. The Battle of Haldighati, fought in 1576, became the defining episode of his life, not only because of its military intensity but because of what it came to represent. The remembered story of the wounded Chetak carrying his master to safety, Jhala Maan's sacrifice, the support of the Bhil communities, and the continued resistance from the forests and hills of Mewar all became part of a larger memory of resilience. Maharana Pratap Jayanti honours this inheritance through processions, floral tributes, cultural programmes, and gatherings, yet the remembrance becomes deeply personal when it enters the home through food.

The occasion does not carry one fixed ritual menu followed uniformly across households, yet its spirit finds natural expression in the food culture of Mewar and the wider culinary traditions of Rajasthan. Rajput kitchens carried a distinctive balance of austerity and refinement. They fed warriors, families, travellers, guests, and communities in a landscape where heat, distance, scarcity, and mobility shaped daily life. Food in this tradition was never merely indulgence, but nourishment that sustained strength, hospitality offered with dignity, and memory preserved through practice.

Among the most iconic dishes associated with Rajasthan is dal baati churma, a preparation that

carries the character of the land. The baati is made from wheat flour kneaded with ghee, salt, and sometimes semolina or carom seeds, shaped into firm balls, and baked until the outer layer becomes crisp while the inside remains dense and nourishing. Once cooked, the baati is cracked open and enriched with ghee. It is served with panchmel dal, prepared from a combination of lentils such as moong, chana, urad, masoor, and toor, simmered until soft and tempered with cumin, asafoetida, garlic, red chilli, turmeric, and coriander. The sweet companion, churma, is made by crushing baati with ghee, jaggery or sugar, cardamom, and nuts. Together, the three create a meal that brings together grain, pulse, fat, and sweetness in a form that is both celebratory and sustaining.

Gatte ki sabzi, an iconic dish of the region, is prepared by kneading gram flour with spices, curd or oil, rolling the dough into cylinders, boiling them, and then simmering the pieces in a curd-based gravy fragrant with chilli, coriander, cumin, and turmeric. A richer festive variation, Govind gatte or shahi gatte, is often prepared by stuffing the gram flour dumplings with khoya, paneer, dry fruits, or nuts before cooking them in a creamy gravy. Ker sangri, one of Rajasthan's most distinctive dishes, combines desert berries and beans that are soaked, boiled, and cooked with mustard oil, red chilli, amchur, turmeric, coriander, and sometimes raisins. Its tangy and earthy flavour carries the wisdom of arid lands, where preservation and resourcefulness became essential to sustenance.

The breads served with these dishes deepen the connection with the soil of Rajasthan. Bajra roti, made from pearl millet flour, is shaped by hand, cooked on a hot griddle, and often finished over flame before being brushed with ghee. It is earthy, strong, and closely tied to rural food culture. Missi roti, prepared with wheat flour and gram flour, is flavoured with cumin, ajwain, chilli, coriander, and sometimes onion, making it a fragrant companion to curd gravies and dry vegetables. Makki roti also appears in seasonal meals and is often enjoyed with ghee, jaggery, or robust curries. These breads remind us that the food of Mewar was not confined to royal courts alone but was also rooted in fields, homes, camps, and journeys, where nourishment had to be practical and wholesome. Rajasthanian kitchens also transformed stored ingredients into preparations of remarkable flavour. Papad ki sabzi is made by simmering roasted or fried papad in a curd gravy tempered with cumin, asafoetida, red chilli, and coriander. Mangodi ki sabzi, prepared from sun-dried lentil dumplings, is cooked with onion, tomato, curd, and spices until the dumplings soften and absorb the flavour of the gravy.

Rabodi ki sabzi, made from dried sheets prepared with maize, buttermilk, or lentil mixtures according to local practice, carries the imprint of preservation, patience, and regional skill. Rajasthanian kadhi, made from curd and gram flour, is slow-cooked with turmeric, fenugreek, mustard seeds, and dried red chillies, and is sometimes enriched with pakoras for a festive meal. These dishes reveal a culinary tradition that knew how to prepare for uncertainty without losing refinement. Festive snacks add warmth to gatherings held around Maharana Pratap Jayanti. Pyaaz kachori, with its flaky crust and spiced onion filling, is prepared by stuffing dough with slow-cooked onions, fennel, coriander, chilli, and amchur before deep frying it until crisp. Mirchi vada, made with large green chillies filled with spiced potato and coated in gram flour batter, brings

heat and boldness to the table. Kalmi vada, prepared from soaked and coarsely ground chana dal mixed with spices and herbs, is fried until crisp outside and grainy within. Moong dal pakori, served with garlic chutney, green chutney, or curd, adds another familiar note of hospitality. These dishes create conversation, welcome guests, and allow remembrance to unfold through shared food.

Rajput cuisine also includes a proud non-vegetarian tradition shaped by royal kitchens, martial life, travel, and the need for bold, nourishing food. Laal maas remains one of Rajasthan's most celebrated meat dishes, prepared with mutton, curd, garlic, whole spices, and deep red chillies, especially Mathania chillies where available. Its heat and colour give it a distinctive personality. Safed maas offers contrast through a pale and rich gravy made with curd, cream, cashew, poppy seeds, cardamom, pepper, and sometimes almond paste. Maas ke sooley brings a refined grilled character, where meat is marinated with curd, ginger, garlic, spices, and tenderising ingredients before being roasted or grilled until smoky and succulent. From the lake-influenced culinary traditions of Rajasthan, machhli Jaisamandi brings another regional dimension, with fish marinated in green herbs, ginger, garlic, coriander, and mint before being cooked into a lively preparation. Together, these dishes reflect the range of Rajput culinary heritage, from intensity and strength to elegance and restraint.

Sweets complete the commemorative table by bringing warmth, affection, and celebration to the meal. Ghevar, made from a thin batter of flour, ghee, and water poured into hot ghee to create a honeycomb disc, is soaked in sugar syrup and often topped with rabri, saffron, and nuts. Malpua, prepared from flour, milk, fennel, and sometimes khoya or banana, is fried and dipped in syrup before being served with rabri. Mohanthal, made by slowly roasting gram flour in ghee and setting it with sugar syrup, cardamom, and nuts, carries the depth of a traditional sweet prepared with patience. Besan chakki or besan barfi adds a dense, fragrant sweetness that suits ceremonial meals and family gatherings. The sweeter side of Rajasthan also includes dishes that feel close to household memory. Lapsi, prepared by roasting broken wheat in ghee and cooking it with



jaggery or sugar, cardamom, and dry fruits, is simple, festive, and deeply comforting. Churma laddoo transforms crushed baati or roasted wheat flour into round sweets bound with ghee and jaggery, often enriched with nuts and poppy seeds. Mawa kachori, filled with sweetened mawa, nuts, and cardamom, fried until golden, and dipped in sugar syrup, adds a more indulgent Rajasthanian note. Rabri, made by reducing milk slowly until thick and layered, may be served on its own or with malpua and ghevar. Balushahi, crisp outside and soft within, completes the sweet section with the slow craft of traditional Indian confectionery.

The beverages that accompany such a meal are most meaningful when they remain rooted not only in Mewar's climate and memory, but also in the wider food culture of Rajasthan. Bajre ki raab or bajre ki raabdi, made with pearl millet flour and buttermilk or curd, reflects nourishment, pastoral life, and desert wisdom. It may be served warm or in a cooling form according to season and household practice. Imli ka amlana brings a tangy

Marwari note through tamarind, black salt, pepper, cardamom, and mint, refreshing the palate after rich food. Makhaniya lassi, especially associated with Jodhpur, offers a thicker and more indulgent drink with its creamy curd base and festive sweetness. Kanji vada,

made with fermented mustard-flavoured water and lentil vadas, brings sharpness, digestion, and regional character to a heritage spread. Khatti chaach, seasoned with roasted cumin, salt, and herbs, remains one of Rajasthan's most honest expressions of everyday cooling wisdom, balancing the weight of ghee-rich meals while reflecting the practical intelligence of the region.

Across households and communities, these dishes may appear in different combinations, yet they carry the same message of remembrance. A simple meal of dal baati churma, ker sangri, gatte ki sabzi, bajra roti, and lapsi can become a dignified vegetarian tribute. A more elaborate spread may include laal maas, safed maas, maas ke sooley, or machhli Jaisamandi, reflecting the martial and royal dimensions of Rajput food culture. Community gatherings may serve kachoris, vadas, sweets, and chaach, while families may prepare only a few dishes and still preserve the spirit of the day. The importance lies not in abundance alone, but in the meaning attached to the meal. When elders explain why bajra mattered, why preserved foods were valued, why ghee carried strength, why hospitality was linked with honour, and why Maharana Pratap chose hardship over surrender, cuisine becomes a form of education.

Ultimately, I believe the cuisine associated with Maharana Pratap Jayanti is far more than a regional spread. It is a living reminder of the values that shaped Mewar and continue to inspire Bharat. The dishes of Rajasthan carry stories of courage, discipline, resourcefulness, hospitality, and pride. They remind us that cultural memory survives most powerfully when it is lived within families, taught to children, and carried forward through ordinary acts of preparation and sharing. In preserving these culinary traditions, we preserve not only recipes but also the dignity of Rajput hospitality, the resilience of Mewar, and the spirit of a ruler who placed honour above comfort. It therefore becomes our collective responsibility to ensure that Maharana Pratap Jayanti continues to live not only in public tributes and historical memory, but also in kitchens where food is prepared with reverence, served with pride, and passed on to future generations as an inheritance of courage, culture, and civilisational strength.

(The writer is Secretary, Cuisine India Society)

Scoop without the guilt

TEAM AGENDA

Summer heat crushes us, but this homemade healthy ice cream brings joy without the guilt. Chef Ayushi Jain, Chef de Cuisine of Bakery and Pastry at IICA New Delhi, shares a refreshing recipe that captures the season. It is cooling, light, and made with real ingredients you can trust.

CHOCOLATE ICECREAM

CHEF'S TIPS

- Use high-quality dark couverture chocolate for a richer flavour.
- For a more intense chocolate taste, increase the cocoa powder slightly.
- **Storage:** Store frozen for up to 2 weeks in an airtight container.
- **Serving:** Let the ice cream sit for 5-10 minutes before scooping.

INGREDIENTS :	QUANTITY
Almonds	35 gm
Cashews	35 gm
Dates (seedless)	40 gm
Coco powder	15 gm
Dark couverture chocolate	80 gm
Oats	10 gm
Foxnut	15 gm
Almond Milk/ milk	270 ml
Salt	A pinch

METHOD

1. In a bowl, combine almonds, cashews, dates, oats, salt and cocoa powder.
2. Add warm milk and soak for 15-20 minutes.
3. Transfer the mixture to a blender and blend until smooth.
4. Pour into a freezer-safe container and mix in the chopped dark chocolate.
5. Cover and freeze for 9-10 hours, or until set.



BANANA AND PEANUT ICE CREAM

INGREDIENTS :

Peanut butter (Sugarfree)	65 gm
Banana (frozen)	3 no.
Cinnamon	1/8 tsp
Milk	80 ml
Roasted chopped peanuts (Optional)	40 gm
Vanilla essence	½ tsp

METHOD

1. Freeze sliced bananas for at least 5 hours. Blend with milk, cinnamon, vanilla essence and peanut butter until smooth and creamy.
2. Pour the mixture into a freezer-safe container and fold in the chopped peanuts
3. Cover and freeze for 9-10 hours, or until set.

CHEF'S TIPS

- Use very ripe bananas for natural sweetness and a creamier texture. ● **Storage:** Store frozen for up to 2 weeks in an airtight container. ● **Serving:** Allow the ice cream to stand at room temperature for 5-10 minutes before scooping for the best texture.

MANGO ICECREAM

CHEF'S TIPS

- Use ripe mangoes for the best flavor, Safeda mangoes work particularly well.
- Before blending, ensure the dates have softened sufficiently for a smooth texture.
- **Storage:** Store frozen for up to 2 weeks in an airtight container.
- **Serving:** Allow the ice cream to stand at room temperature for 5-10 minutes before scooping for the best texture.

INGREDIENTS

Almonds	10 gm
Cashews	10 gm
Dates (seedless)	20 gm
Chopped Mango	160 gm
Milk	270 ml
Oats	15 gm
Fox nut	15 gm

QUANTITY

10 gm
10 gm
20 gm
160 gm
270 ml
15 gm
15 gm

Where heritage & spices meet fine dining



GYANESHWAR DAYAL

In a Delhi-NCR dining scene increasingly dominated by trendy cafés and pan-Asian eateries, Masaldani stands out as a confident celebration of Indian cuisine. Located on the third floor of Central 50 in Sector 50, Noida, the restaurant opened in early 2026 and has quickly earned a reputation among diners seeking authentic regional Indian food served in an elegant fine-dining setting. The menu takes guests on a culinary journey across six distinct regions of India - Punjab, Rajasthan, Lucknow, Hyderabad, Bengal and South India. Rather than offering token representations, Masaldani showcases dishes that stay true to their roots while being presented with refinement and care.

Among the standout offerings is the Dal Makhani, rich, smoky and slow-cooked to perfection. The Awadhi

Biryani reflects the subtle elegance of Lucknow's royal kitchens, with fragrant rice, delicate spices and tender meat. Equally impressive is the fiery Laal Maas from Rajasthan, which balances heat and flavour with remarkable finesse. Diners have also praised the restaurant's mutton chapli kebab and a creative avocado preparation with peas and hara channa, highlighting the kitchen's ability to innovate without compromising authenticity.

The restaurant's interiors complement its culinary vision. Inspired by India's spice traditions, the décor features warm earthy tones, tasteful lighting and understated references to Indian heritage. The ambience is sophisticated yet welcoming, making it suitable for both intimate dinners and family celebrations. Generous spacing between tables adds to the sense of comfort and exclusivity.

Service is another strong point. The staff are attentive and knowledgeable without being intrusive. Several guests

have specifically commended team members for their professionalism and hospitality, noting that the service significantly enhanced their dining experience.

What makes Masaldani particularly appealing is its clear sense of identity. It does not attempt to follow fleeting food trends or cater to every palate. Instead, it remains firmly committed to showcasing India's rich culinary traditions through carefully crafted dishes, quality ingredients and thoughtful presentation.

In a competitive Noida restaurant landscape, that focus sets it apart. The generous portions, consistent quality and warm hospitality make it a place diners are eager to revisit. For anyone who believes Indian cuisine deserves the same fine-dining recognition accorded to the world's leading culinary traditions, Masaldani is a welcome addition and a destination well worth experiencing.

FROM SMOKY DAL MAKHANI AND FRAGRANT AWADHI BIRYANI TO FIERY LAAL MAAS, THE RESTAURANT OFFERS A REFINED FINE-DINING EXPERIENCE THAT HONOURS TRADITION WHILE EMBRACING INNOVATION



Do this instead of struggling to detach

The mind keeps dwelling on what people said or did and these things keep you bound to the cycle of cravings and aversions

GURUDEV SRI SRI RAVI SHANKAR

Why do you want to get over attachment? It is because you know it causes pain, and then you want to get detached. If it didn't bring you pain, you would never think of getting rid of attachment. Attachment gives pain because there is ignorance.

The mind keeps dwelling on what people said or did and these things keep you bound to the cycle of cravings and aversions. Detachments simply drop once Viveka rises in you. Do not try to get out of attachment. Your struggle to get out of attachment will make you more miserable. Instead, learn to be centered. Expand your understanding of life and of this creation. Then you will see that you do not need to make an effort to get rid of attachment. It will automatically go away. Young children are so attached to cotton candy. If you keep a sweet before them, they just want to grab and eat it. But when they grow older, the craving for sweets and toys drop off by itself. They do not have to make an effort to get detached from sweets.

Detachment is a very natural happening. When maturity blossoms in you, an expansion begins to dawn within you; that is when you stop getting stuck and entangled in small petty things in life.

Otherwise, when you are not well versed in detachment, if someone ill-treats or insults you, you get so hurt, you keep holding the grudge in your heart for a long time, sometimes even for months together. You tell yourself, 'I am never going to forget how that person treated me'. What is the use of getting stuck in petty things? Why do you want to harm yourself with such thoughts? We do this so often, and many times, we feel proud about keeping a grudge in our mind. This is foolishness. Here we need some Viveka.

Viveka is having the ability to differentiate between what is short-term and what is long-term; what is temporary and what is permanent; what is sustainable and what is perishable; and what is changing and what is unchanging. One needs to know this differentiation or discrimination. The lack of this sense of discrimination causes misery.

How does one develop Viveka? You need to expand your vision. Immerse the mind in spiritual knowledge. Know that everybody, every human being is like a bubble in the water. How long do we live on Earth? Just look at your own life. Suppose you live on this planet for 80 years. In that span, you will spend around 40 years sleeping. Don't think that the next 20 to 30 years is long enough. They will pass in a blink of an eye. Even our clothes have more shelf life than our body. The shoes we are wearing will last for more years than our body. We never pay attention to these hard facts of life. After the next 30 to 40 years, where will we be? What is life? Who are we? These questions should arise in us and when they do, that shows that our intellect is maturing. When we wake up and realise this fact, our whole life appears to be a dream. Life is going by very fast. Clouds come in the sky but how long do they stay? Know that everything is temporary, ephemeral. That is Viveka.

We get caught up in small things and bring misery both to ourselves and to others around us. You should observe



“THE REAL ART IS TO CONTINUE TO BE IN THE SPIRIT OF CELEBRATION YET ATTEND TO ALL THE DETAILS AND FIX WHATEVER NEEDS FIXING”

— GURUDEV

and accept that different people have different ways of talking, behaving, different approaches to doing things and expressing themselves. Do not think that because of this they do not have any love in their heart. It is just that you may not be able to see it, or that they may not be able to express it in a proper way. Just look at things from the other's perspective.

Bring a small shift in your way of thinking. Just know that when someone says something hurtful or mistreats you, they do it out of stress and ignorance. They are hurt somewhere within and that is why they behave like that. Why are you trying to hurt yourself because of the wounds they carry within? You need to expand your mind and see things from a broader perspective.

You can win over everyone and every situation with love. The key to a happy life is based on how we handle our own mind. This is why we all must regularly practice our *sadhana* (spiritual practices). You do not need to become a scholar to live this knowledge. Just meditate for a while every day. Implement and imbibe the knowledge in your life. You must learn how to calm your mind and relax, for a few moments every day. You will become happy and also bring happiness to the lives of others around us.

Detachment and attachment go hand in hand. Attachment is not bad in itself. Viveka or the knowledge of discrimination helps you decide when to be detached and when not to. Unless you detach, you cannot sleep. Unless you detach from other things, you cannot focus on one particular thing. When you focus on one thing, you are detached from everything else. For example, you practice attachment and detachment in the matter of eating. Suppose if you are too attached to eating, it may lead to compulsive overeating. And then, consider sleeping disorders like insomnia. Insomnia is also a result of lack of detachment. If you don't detach your mind from activities you had performed in the day, you cannot sleep at night. And when you wake up, you need to detach yourself from your resting position. So, attachment and detachment are part and parcel of life. When there is no detachment or very little detachment in

life, that can lead to problems.

Detachment and attachment also play a role in romantic relationships. Why do you think so many intimate relationships end? It is like two lines focusing on each other. And at some point, they would cross each other's paths. If you police your partner too much, and are only focused on each other, it is like the lines crossing each other and moving away. But if both the partners have a single goal of doing something big and something good, then it is like two parallel lines that can go on forever.

Viveka develops in a state of deep rest. When one has had a good rest and becomes free from stress, the intellect sharpens. One can never have an expanded vision of life if they are stressed. A stressed mind is always caught up in small, insignificant things. When you are de-stressed, your intellect shines, and it frees itself from prejudices. When there is no prejudice of any kind, no distraction in the mind, and the consciousness is cheerful, *Viveka* awakens. When you practice meditation, *Viveka* awakens within you, and it offers you a clear vision.

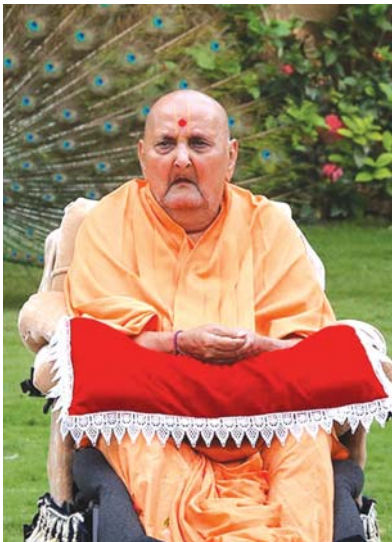
When you inculcate a clear vision, you see life as a game. You move through it by accepting and accommodating people and things. You realise the fact that nothing is static. Anybody can change at any time. Hence, it is futile to hold on to judgements. This is when you build the ability to embrace life in its totality, with all its colors, and with all its flaws.

Then, you gradually realise that everything is perfect the way it is. The understanding that all is perfect this moment will allow you to celebrate with hundred percent involvement. Does this mean that you also accept what is not perfect, and be complacent about everything? Certainly not.

The real art is to continue to be in the spirit of celebration yet attend to all the details and fix whatever needs fixing. This is how enlightened people act and behave. Take right actions wherever they are needed and know that all will be taken care of by a higher power. In this way, you will not be a source of complaints. You will turn into a source of joy. You will be manifesting the joy that you are.

Ancient Wisdom Through an Ancient Language in Modern Times

The fragrance of flowers, the call of peacocks, the glow of sacred fires, and the sound of Sanskrit mantras at dawn, Sarangpur feels less like a place and more like a forgotten chapter of India's spiritual past brought to life. Here, amidst a living gurukul tradition envisioned by Pramukh Swami Maharaj, ancient wisdom continues to inspire modern minds



DR SWAMI GYANANANDDAS

The road to Sarangpur winds through the quiet countryside of Gujarat. At first glance, Sarangpur appears to be just another small Indian village, unassuming and far removed from the bustle of modern cities. Yet, as one enters the vast campus of the BAPS Swaminarayan Mandir, the atmosphere changes dramatically. A sense of serenity descends. The air seems calmer, the pace slower, and the surroundings imbued with a timeless grace.

My visit to the BAPS Swaminarayan Sanskrit Mahavidyalay felt less like entering an educational institution and more like stepping into a living chapter of India's ancient heritage. Towering trees lined the pathways. Colorful flowers bloomed in carefully tended gardens. Peacocks, the national bird of India and affectionately known in Sanskrit as *saranga*, from which Sarangpur derives its name, wandered freely across the campus, their calls mingling with the chants of sacred verses. *Sadhus* in saffron robes, devotees engaged in *seva*, and young students dressed in traditional attire moved purposefully through the grounds, creating a scene that seemed transported from the era of the ancient gurukuls.

There was something profoundly moving about witnessing Sanskrit, not as a subject preserved in books, but as a living language spoken, studied, discussed, and cherished. The environment evoked the spirit of the Vedic age, where learning was not merely the accumulation of information but a holistic process of intellectual, moral, and spiritual refinement. In a world increasingly shaped by screens and algorithms, the experience was both refreshing and inspiring.



At the heart of this unique environment stands the BAPS Swaminarayan Sanskrit Mahavidyalay, an institution dedicated to preserving and advancing India's classical knowledge traditions. Established in 1973 as the *Yajñapurusa* Sanskrit Vidyalay, the Mahavidyalay has grown into a respected center for Sanskrit scholarship, attracting students from across India and around the world. Here, ancient wisdom is not treated as a relic of the past but as a living source of insight capable of enriching contemporary life.

The Mahavidyalay offers rigorous training in Sanskrit scriptures, philosophy, literature, linguistics, and traditional knowledge systems. Its purpose is not merely to produce scholars who can interpret ancient texts, but individuals capable of communicating their timeless relevance to modern society. Students immerse themselves in the study of sacred works while developing the analytical, linguistic, and research skills required for academic excellence.

A distinctive strength of the Mahavidyalay lies in its comprehensive language programme. Alongside Sanskrit, students receive training in Gujarati, Hindi, and English, enabling them to engage with a broad range of scholarly resources and communicate effectively across cultural and academic contexts. The curriculum emphasises all dimensions of language learning: reading, writing, listening, speaking, and critical interpretation, under the guidance of experienced instructors.

The institution's affiliation with Shree Somnath Sanskrit University enables qualified students to pursue undergraduate, postgraduate, doctoral, and diploma programs. Through its online learning initiatives, students from around the world can also access structured

Sanskrit education, extending the reach of this ancient language far beyond the boundaries of Sarangpur.

Research and academic engagement form an integral part of life at the Mahavidyalay. Regular *Sambhasana* seminars provide students and researchers with opportunities to present their ideas, participate in debates, engage in scholarly discussions, and refine their communication skills. These forums cultivate critical thinking while preparing students for the demands of academic research and public presentation.

Many students go on to present papers at national and international conferences, where they interact with leading scholars and contribute to contemporary discussions in Sanskrit studies and related disciplines. Such experiences strengthen their research abilities, broaden their intellectual horizons, and prepare them to participate confidently in global academic discourse.

The Mahavidyalay also welcomes visiting researchers, professors, and scholars from universities and research institutions across the world. Their presence enriches the academic environment and exposes students to diverse perspectives and emerging opportunities in Sanskrit studies internationally. For many young scholars, these interactions become windows into a global network of research, collaboration, and lifelong learning.

Yet, what leaves the deepest impression on a visitor is not simply the Mahavidyalay's academic excellence, but the divine atmosphere that envelops the entire campus. At dawn, some students gather to perform *yajna* or *mahapuja*, their resonant chanting of Vedic mantras filling the air with a sacred energy. As evening descends over Sarangpur, the echoes of *dhun*, *stuti* and *aarti* linger in the air. Watching young students perform *seva* with remarkable devotion, one feels transported centuries back to the ancient gurukul.

Thus, the Mahavidyalay emerges as a remarkable embodiment of Pramukh Swami Maharaj's vision: a sacred bridge connecting the wisdom of ancient India with the needs of the modern world, ensuring that the light of Sanatan values continues to illuminate generations to come.

(The writer Dr Swami Gyanananddas is a dedicated follower of the Swaminarayan tradition and has earned a PhD from MS University)

Religion and Atheism: Two Sides of the Same Coin

SADHGURU

On a certain day, Gautama, the Buddha, was sitting in a congregation of his disciples, and a man came. He was a great *bhakta*, or devotee, of Rama. All his life, he did, "Rama, Rama, Rama." Nothing else; his life was Rama. He not only went to the temple, but he also built many temples for Rama. But as age was passing away, a little doubt had come. He knew God existed, but he also saw many people who did not believe in God living well. They were enjoying all the pleasures of life and living more happily than he was.

He thought, "Suppose there is no God, my whole life will go to waste." So, he wanted to know, and there was an enlightened being here; this was the opportunity. But after being recognized as a great devotee, how could he come and ask whether there is a God or not? So, early in the morning before the sun had risen, he stood in the shadows and asked the question, "Is there God?" Gautama looked at the man and said, "No." There was a big relief in the disciples because this turmoil was on in everyone's mind. Many a time, they had posed this question to Gautama, but whenever such questions came, Gautama just became silent and never answered. For the first time, he said an emphatic "no," and there was a big relief.

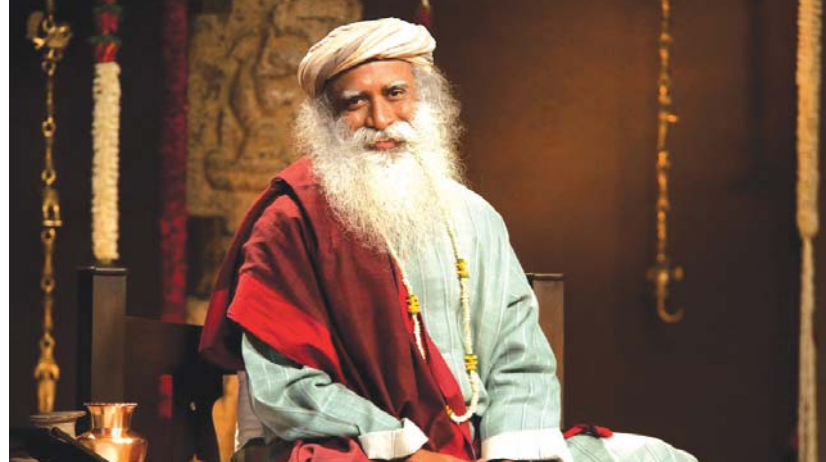
In the evening, another man came. He was a *charvaka*. *Charvakas* are out-and-

out materialists; they do not believe in anything that their two eyes cannot see. This man had proven to thousands of people that there was no God. But then, age was passing away, and a little doubt had come, "Suppose there is a God? I have proved to everyone that there is no God. What if he is there? When I die, will he leave me? And anyway, people say God is very vengeful." So, a little fear had come.

He came in the evening after the sun had set, and once again, standing in the shadows, asked the same question, "Is there God?" Gautama looked at the man and said, "Yes." Once again, there was turmoil among the disciples. In the morning, he had said, "No God," and they were all happy. In the evening, he said, "There is God." Again, there was trouble. What was the idea anyway?

The idea was to destroy all belief. Because belief means you do not know. If you know something, you do not have to believe it; you simply know it. And belief systems are of different kinds; they can be theistic or atheistic. One believes there is God, another believes there is no God, but there is no difference between the two; both believe something that they do not know.

Essentially, a belief system comes from a basic problem that you are not sincere enough to admit that you do not know. If you want to seek something, the first and foremost thing is that you realize that you do not know. When you see this, the



longing to know arises, and seeking follows. Then there is a possibility of knowing.

"I do not know" is a tremendous possibility. The moment you kill it with some kind of belief that is convenient for you, you are destroying all possibilities of knowing. I want people to remain in a way where they come to terms with, "What I know, I know. What I do not know, I do not know." Then seeking will start, and a whole spiritual process can be set forth.

Somewhere, at some point, all religions started as a spiritual process. But in their eagerness to organize, they lost the fundamentals of it. Religion is an inward step. It is a very intimate and personal process.

Everyone has to pursue it in his own way; you can never organize it into a large group. You can help someone else, but fundamentally, this inward step can only be taken by an individual.

This is why in the East, spirituality or religion was never an organized process. Organization was only to the extent of making spirituality available to everyone — there was never an organized conquest. A farmer worshipped his plough; a fisherman worshipped his boat; people worshipped whatever aspect of life they related most with, and that was perfectly fine.

Essentially, in the East, religion is about you; it is not about God. Religion is about

your liberation, and God is just one more tool to find your ultimate liberation. The purpose is to create reverence in a person. What you worship is not important. It is not about whether you like something or dislike it. It is just that you learn to bring reverence into your life. The object of reverence is irrelevant. If you make reverence the quality of your life, then you become far more receptive to life. Life will happen to you in bigger ways.

So, in indigenous cultures, religion was never juxtaposed against the state. In the past, religion was far more important to people than it is now, but still, there were no theocratic states; the ruler had his religion, and the subjects had the freedom to follow theirs. There was no conflict because people did not look at religion as an organized process. Today, organization is coming in even in Eastern cultures because of the examples of very ambitious and conquering religions that came from outside.

These days, politicians are openly and proudly calling themselves "Hindu leaders," "Muslim leaders," or "Christian leaders." Once this is the situation, religion becomes a matter of number games and another disguise for politics.

Religion can be made into a deep science, the most fantastic science, because it is an inner science. The quality of your life and the quality of the world simply depend on how you are within yourself, not on how external situations

are. Every religion has emphasized that the only place to seek is within, not somewhere else.

Once you are on an inward process, you are in no one's way. There is no room for conflict, harmony is the only way you can be. So, religion is fundamentally aimed at making you experience that everything—the whole life process—is a part of you. When you experience everything as a part of you, harmony is the only way you can be. There is simply no other way to be. That is the basis of all religion.

And when inner turmoil stops, there will be no turmoil in society. Naturally, it will stop. Addressing the inner turmoil is a much wiser thing to do than trying to pacify social situations; that can be done for immediate purposes, but the fundamental solution is always within. When a person has a sense of completeness within themselves, then they will be in harmony. And a true revolution is only when man is willing to change himself. "I am willing to change," this revolution will bring harmony.

(Ranked amongst the fifty most influential people in India, Sadhguru is a Yogi, mystic, visionary and a New York Times bestselling author. Sadhguru has been conferred the Padma Vibhushan by the Government of India in 2017, the highest annual civilian award, accorded for exceptional and distinguished service. He is also the founder of the world's largest people's movement, Conscious Planet- Save Soil, which has touched over 4 billion people)